

**“THE #1 DIGITAL BUSINESS MODEL
FOR THE NEXT DECADE”
— ROBERT ROSE**



CONTENT INC.

COMPLETELY UPDATED AND EXPANDED SECOND EDITION

**START A CONTENT-FIRST BUSINESS, BUILD A MASSIVE
AUDIENCE, AND BECOME RADICALLY SUCCESSFUL
(WITH LITTLE TO NO MONEY)**

JOE PULIZZI

**FOUNDER OF *THE TILT*
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PRAISE FOR *CONTENT INC.*

Content creators are the rock star entrepreneurs of the twenty-first century, and *Content Inc.* delivers your winning business model.

—BRIAN CLARK, Founder of *Copyblogger* and *Unemployable*

From the man who invented content marketing. Listen to this guy. He really understands the new world of marketing.

—DON SCHULTZ (1934–2020), the “father of integrated marketing,” professor at Northwestern University’s Medill School of Journalism, and author of 13 books

If you’re serious about turning content into a business, this is the most detailed, honest, and useful book ever written.

—JAY BAER, *New York Times* bestselling author of *Youtility*

What if you launched a business with nothing to sell, and instead focused first on serving the needs of an audience, trusting that the “selling” part would come later? Crazy? Or crazy-brilliant? I’d say the latter. Because in today’s world, you should serve before selling.

—ANN HANDLEY, *Wall Street Journal* bestselling author of *Everybody Writes*

Now there is a better way to promote your business.

—GUY KAWASAKI, chief evangelist of Canva and author of *The Art of the Start 2.0*

Use this as your road map to startup success.

—SALLY HOGSHEAD, *New York Times* and *Wall Street Journal* bestselling author of *How the World Sees You*

The approach to business taught all over the world is to create a product and then spend a bunch of money to market and sell it. Joe outlines a radically

new way to succeed in business: Develop your audience first by creating content that draws people in and then watch your business sell itself.

—DAVID MEERMAN SCOTT, *New York Times* bestselling author of *The New Rules of Marketing and PR*

Anyone, anywhere, with a passion and focus on a content niche can build a multimillion-dollar platform and business. I did it and so can you. Just follow Joe's *Content Inc.* model.

—JOHN LEE DUMAS, founder, *Entrepreneurs On Fire*

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JOE PULIZZI



NEW YORK CHICAGO SAN FRANCISCO ATHENS LONDON
MADRID MEXICO CITY MILAN NEW DELHI
SINGAPORE SYDNEY TORONTO

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For Cora

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INTRODUCTION

Reasonable people adapt themselves to the world: unreasonable people persist in trying to adapt the world to themselves. Therefore all progress depends on unreasonable people.

ADAPTED FROM GEORGE BERNARD SHAW

The model described in this book saved my life.

Here's the synopsis:

I left a six-figure executive media position in 2007 to start a business. Wife. Two kids, ages four and six. Not much money in the bank.

Grappling through more mistakes than I care to mention (and almost quitting in 2009), my wife and I hit our first million dollars in sales in 2011. By 2015, we just missed \$10 million in sales.

That same year, I wrote the first edition of this book, *Content Inc.*, which detailed the exact business model we used to go from zero to millions in less than five years. More than 100,000 copies were sold in print, digital, and audio.

Here's the rest of the story.

In June 2016, we sold our company, the Content Marketing Institute (CMI), for a little less than \$30 million to a billion-dollar, London-based events company.

I stayed on for a bit, left at the end of 2017, and took a sabbatical for the entire calendar year of 2018. I flew to Sicily with my father, spent more time with my wife and two boys than ever before, ran a couple half marathons, and barely looked at social media. It was, perhaps, the most perfect year of my life.

The next year I wrote a bestselling mystery novel.

I made the decision to become a full-time novelist; focus more energy on our speech therapy nonprofit, the Orange Effect Foundation; and spend an increasing amount of time with my family before my two teenagers left for college.

Then COVID-19 hit particularly hard in the United States (I'm sure you know the story). Yes, there was death and sickness. There were also millions left without jobs or prospects. Whatever was the worst scenario you can think of, the world seemed to be smack dab in the middle of it.

Then I received an email from a close friend who had just been downsized from her job. She wanted to know more about the *Content Inc.* model.

Two days later, another friend reached out. Then another. After a few months into the coronavirus pandemic, the *Content Inc.* model had seen a resurgence. Sales of this first-edition book tripled in two months, and my old podcast downloads started to pick up, even though I wasn't producing the podcast any longer.

How do I put this so I don't sound egotistical? This is just a business model. I am not saving the world. In this environment, though, I believed that the *Content Inc.* model could truly help people around the globe who were struggling to put food on the table. What if more people used the *Content Inc.* model to start amazing businesses and earn their own financial freedom? What if more small businesses, currently fighting for survival, could leverage the *Content Inc.* model not only to stay afloat, but to prosper? What if, even in large businesses, marketers could use this model to stay in business, to grow, and to employ more people?

I shelved part two of the mystery novel and emailed my executive editor at McGraw Hill. I wanted to finish the *Content Inc.* book. When I published the first version of *Content Inc.* in 2015, the process was only half completed. Now I can tell the rest of the story.

I relaunched the *Content Inc.* podcast, developed an email newsletter for content entrepreneurs called *The Tilt*, and completely updated the *Content Inc.* model.

I have had more than my fair share of breaks. I will never be concerned about money for me or for my kids (it's an amazing feeling). I would like more people to have that opportunity. I believe this book is the answer.

WHAT'S THE BIG DEAL?

Here's the underlying concept for *Content Inc.* By focusing on building an audience first and defining products and services second, a person can change the rules of the game and significantly increase the odds of financial and personal success.

Let me repeat that: I believe the absolute best way to start and grow a business today is *not* by launching or pushing products, but by creating a system to attract, build, and retain an audience. Once you've built a loyal audience, one that loves you and the information you send, you can most likely sell the audience anything you want. This model is called *Content Inc.*

The content entrepreneurs who dedicate their time to this model are wildly successful in their business and personal lives. If you execute the *Content Inc.* model and deliver desirable information consistently to a specific audience, \$5 million in five years is most certainly within reach for anyone in the world.

THE TRUE STORY OF DAVID AND GOLIATH

The challenges facing every entrepreneur who dreams of success can be summed up in one of two interpretations of the biblical story of David and Goliath.

Growing up in the Catholic school system, I heard the David versus Goliath story often. Goliath, the Philistine giant, is the most powerful warrior on the planet, and David, a young boy and the ultimate underdog, doesn't have a chance of defeating such a powerful and skilled warrior.

But as a result of David's faith in God, *a handful of smooth rocks*, and perhaps a small miracle, David defeated Goliath.

Jack Wellman from the *Christian Crier* asserts that "Goliath had everything going for him. He had every advantage possible. He had great ability and he was trained, equipped, experienced, battle tested, and battle hardened, and he was completely fearless. He was totally

confident, but it could also be said that he was overconfident.” He was also about 6 feet 9 inches tall.

Then here comes David, small and totally outmatched. Just a boy, David won because he had supreme confidence in the Lord, who was with him, and the giant lost the seemingly unlosable battle. It’s a battle that is over in a matter of seconds when David makes his storied move:

Reaching into his bag and taking out a stone, he slung it and struck the Philistine on the forehead. The stone sank into his forehead, and he fell facedown on the ground.

So David triumphed over the Philistine with a sling and a stone; without a sword in his hand he struck down the Philistine and killed him.

David ran and stood over him. He took hold of the Philistine’s sword and drew it from the sheath. After he killed him, he cut off his head with the sword.

When the Philistines saw that their hero was dead, they turned and ran. (1 Samuel 17)

David beat Goliath because of his faith in God. Of course, David had confidence in victory because the Lord was with him. *But perhaps there is another way to interpret this story.*

Goliath: The Underdog

Malcolm Gladwell gave me a new perspective on this story in his book *David and Goliath: Underdogs, Misfits, and the Art of Battling Giants*. Gladwell’s version makes perfect sense to my entrepreneurial spirit.

According to Gladwell, Goliath was indeed a giant, and therefore was also extremely slow to move. On top of that, he was wearing 100 pounds of armor. Some medical experts believe Goliath was suffering from acromegaly, a hormone imbalance that causes a human to grow to extraordinary size. If that was the case, his vision was most likely impaired as well.

How about David? Yes, David was small in stature, but he was accomplished with a slingshot and could strike large beasts from great

distances. Light on his feet, David could move in unsuspected on a target and still win an attack from far away.

The biblical interpretation tells us that David, the underdog, was shown favor by the Lord, which helped him defeat Goliath, the heavy favorite. Actually, Goliath had no chance to win. *God favored David by helping him discern a better strategy.* The fight was over before it ever began.

Changing the Game

David won because he played an entirely different game than Goliath did. If David had fought Goliath in hand-to-hand combat, as tradition demanded, he would have lost.

This is what happens to almost all entrepreneurs or small businesses dreaming up an idea that will make them successful. Smaller organizations have no resources compared with those of their much larger competitors. *That means they need to play an entirely different game.*

ENTREPRENEURS ARE GETTING BAD ADVICE

According to the US Small Business Administration, the first step in starting a business is to develop a business plan. The standard business plan includes things like “defining what you are selling” and “creating a sales and marketing plan.” Of course it does. I’m sure if you search the thousands of different business plans on the web, they all look pretty much the same. Every startup essentially plays the game by the same rules.

Even Peter Thiel, cofounder of PayPal and the first outside investor in Facebook, focuses all the attention in his book *Zero to One* on developing an amazing product. While I believe Thiel offers some excellent advice to entrepreneurs, his advice is the same as that of all the other experts out there: create a great product first. Find the problem; then solve the problem with an exceptional product or service.

But the results aren't exceptional at all. According to the US Census Bureau, the majority of businesses fail in their first five years. Every other statistic out there on startup failure says it's probably a lot worse than that.

Why do people go to market with their businesses in the same way? Is humanity so devoid of creativity that we've accepted that there is only one way to start and grow a business?

According to the *Wall Street Journal*, Americans are starting businesses at a faster clip than at any time since 2007. Most of these businesses are still leading with product first.

I say, be like David.

CAN CONTENT INC. BE REPLICATED?

Brian Clark, founder of Copyblogger Media, had some amazing ideas about how businesses should market online. Unfortunately (or maybe I should say fortunately), he didn't have a product to sell.

For one year and seven months, Brian consistently developed amazing content for a targeted audience. As he defined it, his ultimate mission was "to create media assets that depended on the permission to contact my audience, not the permission of a media gatekeeper."

In shorthand, he worked to become the expert resource that attracts the right audience without having to buy advertising on someone else's platform. And Brian did just that. Today, Copyblogger is a multimillion-dollar educational platform.

In our research for *Content Inc.*, we've uncovered countless entrepreneurs and small businesses from all over the globe in varied industries using a similar philosophy. In other words, Brian and I are not alone. The *Content Inc.* model can be replicated.

THE CONTENT INC. FUTURE IS NOW

Today thousands of businesses around the world are leveraging a *Content Inc.* go-to-market strategy. Why? Because having a singular focus on audience, and building a loyal audience directly, gives you the best understanding of what products ultimately make the most sense to sell.

Content Inc. tells us that there is a better way and a better model that lead to a better life for entrepreneurs and business owners. You have the opportunity to be like David, who looks like an underdog to the Goliaths of the world, but the truth is that you've simply uncovered a better business strategy than all the rest.

While all this is happening, big companies are getting bigger, swallowing up smaller companies around the globe. What does this mean? The atmosphere is ripe for disruption.

THE *CONTENT INC.* MODEL

In our experience working with and interviewing hundreds of businesses from all over the world, we've found that there are seven distinct steps that make up the *Content Inc.* model, illustrated in [Figure I.1](#). The steps are the subject of the chapters that follow and are briefly described below.

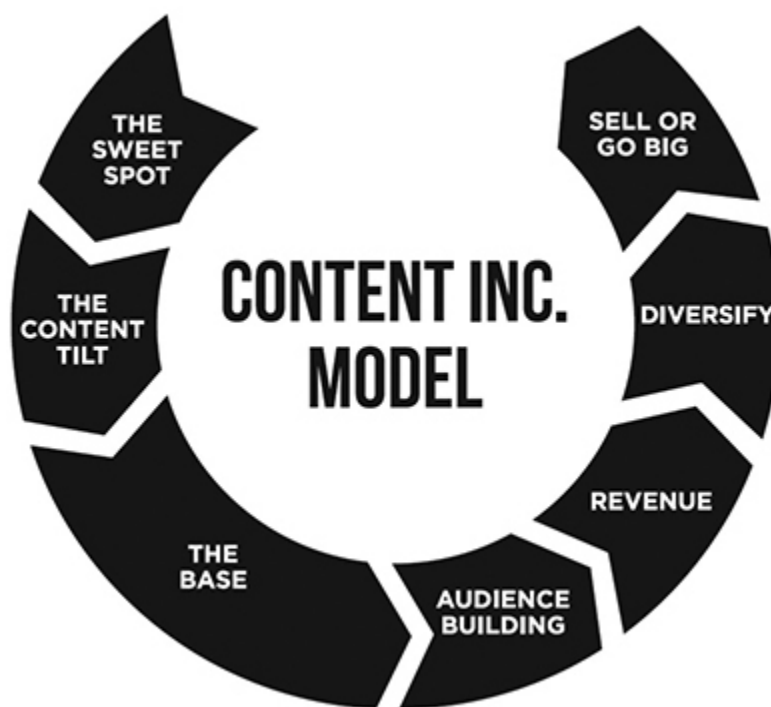


Figure I.1 Introducing the *Content Inc.* model.

1. THE SWEET SPOT

Simply put, the entrepreneur needs to uncover a content area that the business model will be based on. To make this happen, we need to identify a sweet spot that will attract an audience over time. This sweet spot is the intersection of a knowledge or skill set (something the entrepreneur or business has a competency in) and a specific audience desire.

For example, global manufacturer John Deere started its *Content Inc.* journey in 1895 with its magazine, *The Furrow*. *The Furrow*'s sweet spot was the intersection between John Deere's knowledge of agricultural technology and the farmer's (Deere's audience) need for information on how to operate a farm more profitably. By the way, *The Furrow*, still around today, is delivered to over a million farmers every month.

2. THE CONTENT TILT

Once the sweet spot is identified, the entrepreneur needs to determine the "tilt," or the differentiation factor, to find an area of little to no competition.

Kristen Bor started a blog and wrote consistently about hiking and backpacking. A 2015 trip changed everything:

I was driving back from a backpacking trip in Southern Utah . . . passing the North Rim of the Grand Canyon and I had never been there. I was really intrigued . . . but I was alone and the weather wasn't good. So I bypassed it and thought, "Oh, I'll be back some other time."

And that's when I started hearing more about van life. If I had a van, I could have stopped [at the Grand Canyon] and explored the next day. That sparked my initial idea.

At the time, there were many media sites, blogs, and podcasts about travel and backpacking, but not very many on van life (traveling while living in a van). From that one situation, Kristen found the content tilt that separated her from all the other backpacking sites: van life. Today Kristen attracts more than a half a million page views per month and has become one of the world's leading experts on van life.

3. THE BASE

Once you find the sweet spot and discover the tilt, you choose a platform and construct a content base. This is exactly like building a house. Before we get into the paint and fixtures and flooring options, we have to plan and install the foundation. We do this by consistently generating valuable content through one key channel (a blog, a podcast, YouTube, etc.).

Ann Reardon, known now as the baking queen of Sydney, Australia, started a YouTube channel in 2011. Every week she delivers eye-opening dessert recipe videos to her international audience via YouTube (now more than 4 million subscribers).

Ann was successful because she focused on being great on one platform, not dabbling in many at once.

4. AUDIENCE BUILDING

After choosing the platform and building the content base, you have the opportunity to increase the audience and convert one-time readers or viewers into ongoing subscribers. Here, we go from getting attention to keeping attention.

This is where we leverage social media as a key distribution tool and take search engine optimization seriously. At this point, our job is not just to increase web traffic. By itself, web traffic is a meaningless metric. Our goal is to generate traffic to increase the opportunity to acquire an audience.

Here's how Michael Stelzner, CEO of Social Media Examiner (SME), explains this step in the process:

I knew email acquisition was the key metric and I had decided that we weren't going to promote (meaning "sell") anything until we had at least 10,000 email subscribers. And we got to that number so quickly that I knew we were really onto something.

Today 2.4 million unique people visit SME monthly. We have 416,000 people that we email three times per week. We currently publish four articles, two podcasts and three videos per week.

The critical acknowledgment for this area: though there are many metrics for analyzing content success, subscribers are the number one metric. It's almost impossible to monetize and grow your audience without

first getting readers to take action by actually opting in and subscribing to your content.

5. REVENUE

It's time. You've identified your sweet spot. You've "tilted" to find an area of content noncompetition. You've selected the platform and built the base. You've started to build subscribers. Now is when the model monetizes against the platform.

By this time, you are armed with enough subscriber information (both qualitative and quantitative) that you'll see a multitude of opportunities for generating revenue. This could be consulting or software or events or more.

For Content Marketing Institute's revenue model, we initially sold sponsorships to cover our costs and keep the company going. Over the next two years, we added webinars, live events, and print advertising to our sales model. [Figure I.2](#) shows our revenue growth over a five-year period.

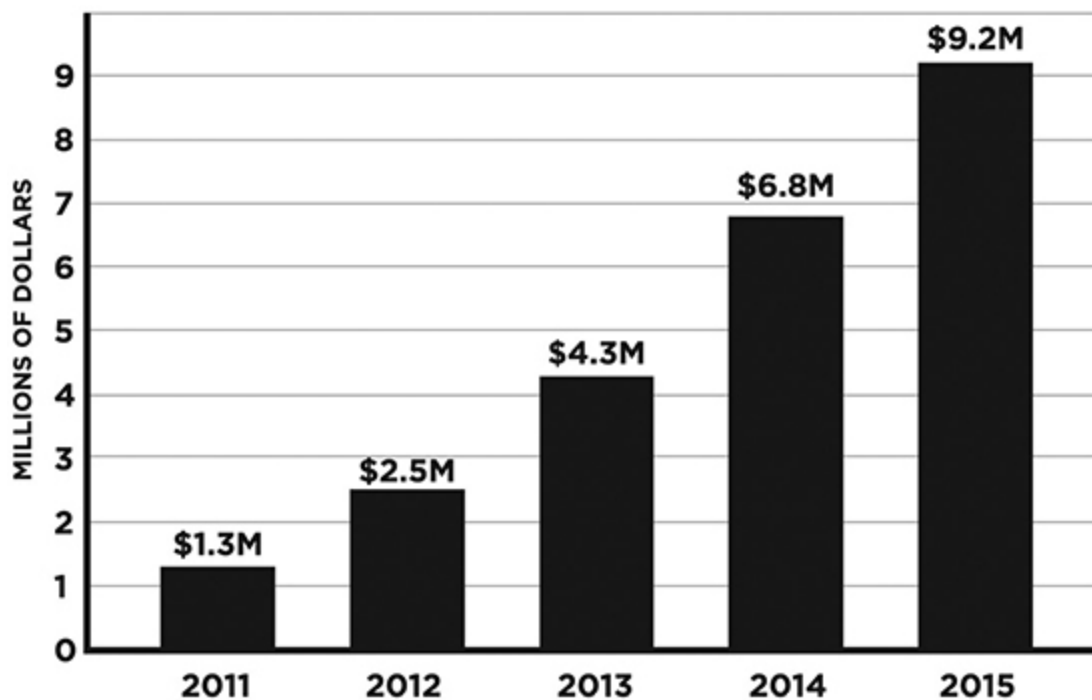


Figure I.2 Content Marketing Institute revenue.

6. DIVERSIFY

Once the model has built a strong, loyal, and growing audience, it's time to diversify from the main content stream and create brand extensions. Think of the model like an octopus, with each content channel as one of the eight arms. How many of those arms can we wrap our readers in to keep them close to us and coming back for more?

ESPN, originally started as a sports-only cable television station in 1979, began with a \$9,000 investment by Bill and Scott Rasmussen. Now, more than 40 years later, ESPN is one of the world's most profitable media brands, with revenues of more than \$11 billion, according to Disney's financial statements. (ESPN is now a part of Disney.)

For 13 years, ESPN directed its attention to just one cable channel for 100 percent of its audience-building focus. Starting in 1992, the floodgates opened on diversification, first with the launch of ESPN radio. Then [ESPN.com](#) (originally called ESPN SportsZone) launched in 1995, followed three years later by *ESPN the Magazine*.

Today, ESPN has a property in almost every channel available on the planet, from Twitter to podcasts to documentaries. Even though the channels were limited in the 1980s and 1990s (compared with today), ESPN didn't diversify until the core platform (cable television) was successful.

7. SELL OR GO BIG

When I first released the *Content Inc.* model in 2015, the process had only six steps. In this book, I've added a critical seventh step. Once you proceed through the first six steps of the model successfully, you have some interesting options.

One option is to keep the asset and substantially grow it. As an example, Matthew Patrick, who created the hugely popular *Game Theory* channel on YouTube, decided not to sell for millions. Instead, he launched *Film Theory* and *Food Theory*, turning his small operation into a fast-growing media, merchandising, and services company.

John Lee Dumas, from the successful podcast *Entrepreneurs On Fire*, is another example of someone who decided not to sell, but to stay small. John says: "We have three virtual assistants (with payroll under \$3,000 monthly), a 70 percent or more net profit margin, and a couple million in revenue we get to keep every year. I have no desire to build a content enterprise, but

rather focus on lifestyle design, where happiness, health, and freedom are the focus.”

The second option is to exit the business, like my wife and I did in 2016. When we started our *Content Inc.* model, our goal was always to sell the company. We set a goal price and began the selling process when we knew we could hit our number. Later in the book, I’ll break down everything you need to know if you’d like to sell your content asset to another organization and live the rest of your life financially (and worry) free.

THE AUDIENCE FOR THIS BOOK

Fifty years ago, Harvard Business School professor Howard Stephenson defined entrepreneurship: “Entrepreneurship is the pursuit of opportunity without regard to resources currently controlled.”

Before writing the first version of this book, I believed that the term “entrepreneur” was relegated to startups. According to Stephenson’s definition, this is an incorrect presumption. As Eric Ries contends in *The Lean Startup*, when you look at the entrepreneur in this way, it should be “regardless of company size, sector, or stage of development.”

At the same time, Ries explains that “a startup is a human institution designed to create a new product or service under conditions of extreme uncertainty.” This combined look at the core definitions of “entrepreneurship” and “startup” plays into Ries’s argument that neither one means that these terms are owned solely by new companies.

Written from this perspective and leveraging a *Content Inc.* methodology, this book contains a proven digital business model for the startup/entrepreneur in organizations of any size, including:

- **A pure startup.** You are creating a new organization, launching a content-first, audience-first model as a content entrepreneur. You are using funding from various sources to keep the lights on until you discover your revenue-generation product or service.
- **A startup inside a large organization.** You’ve received buy-in to develop an audience around a current customer segment. Your goal is to build an engaged audience around a content niche. Once that’s complete, you’ll look to monetize the platform into new or current

product sales, or perhaps use it to keep customers more loyal. This is where most enterprises are with content marketing. They believe that if they launch a content platform, it will help their current business, but they are not 100 percent sure how it will unfold or what the ultimate benefits might be. In this case, models include:

- **A large enterprise.** Organizations like Red Bull (extreme sports) and electronics distributor Arrow Electronics (electronics engineering) have built media properties and massive audiences that have helped substantially grow their companies.
- **An educational institution.** A school wants to become well known for a particular discipline (logistics, healthcare, marketing, etc.). For example, Mercyhurst University in Erie, Pennsylvania, uses this model to create an expertise in cybersecurity. On the corporate side, Schneider Electric has graduated more than 200,000 students from its own Energy University.
- **A government or political action committee.** Today government entities are becoming small media companies, building audiences around key issues such as universal income or fiscal stimulus. For example, the Lincoln Project, through a group of former Republicans, has built a massive audience around what they feel is the future of the new Republican Party. A *Content Inc.* model is also the perfect defense mechanism against an increasing amount of false information on social media and other traditional media channels.
- **A nonprofit.** Nonprofits rely on ongoing fund-raising for their missions' survival. A *Content Inc.* model can be crucial for raising awareness about a cause, which can ultimately lead to increased giving.
- **A stalled business.** You currently have a number of products and services you sell, but you are not happy with your growth. You believe that building an audience around content can lead to new business opportunities. LEGO is an example. Years ago LEGO's growth stalled, so it took a fresh look at its audience and platforms. Today LEGO is a vibrant, growing company. Much of the credit goes to the multitude of content platforms the company built. What's more

valuable, LEGO the manufacturing company or LEGO the media company?

- **A small business.** You started your small business years ago. In order to grow, your business needs to sell more products and services, and you don't have access to an audience. You believe that launching a *Content Inc.* model can help transform your business into the leading industry expert and open up new revenue opportunities accordingly.

The majority of examples in *Content Inc.* revolve around the creation of a new or small organization, one that is developing processes around building a new audience that becomes loyal and engaged through consistent content creation and delivery. To be honest, this is the audience in my mind as I'm writing this. Even so, I believe this book is relevant for any of the business stages I've listed. Depending on the goal, it can be leveraged in organizations of any size.

HOW THIS BOOK IS ORGANIZED

Some chapters in this book will be long, because I feel depth is needed in those areas. Some will be short.

At the beginning of each chapter, I'll tell you what's in it. I do that because I don't know where you are in your *Content Inc.* timeline. If you believe you have the chapter material covered after reading the synopsis, you can skip it.

Finally, this book is not a personal memoir, but it does share all the secrets about how my wife and I built our business using a content-first (not product-first) approach. I'll also be sharing multiple case studies, to show that the *Content Inc.* methodology is not a one-hit wonder. Any content entrepreneur in any industry can, by following a few important steps, develop a successful business by focusing on building audience first and product second.

Thank you for taking the time to make this journey with me.

If today were the last day of your life, would you want to do what
you are about to do today?

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PART 1

STARTING THE JOURNEY

How wonderful it is that nobody need wait a single moment
before starting to improve the world.

ANNE FRANK

To be successful at launching a *Content Inc.* model, we need to get our
goals and plans in the right place. Let's get started!

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CHAPTER 1

BEGINNING WITH THE END IN MIND

Goals allow you to control the direction of change in your favor.

BRIAN TRACY

This chapter is about getting your goals in order and figuring out what's important to you. This is your why.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

I went through a fairly long period of not feeling successful, though in hindsight it's more accurate to say that I didn't really know what success was.

I graduated from Bowling Green State University (just south of Toledo, Ohio) with a degree in interpersonal communications. My major had been "undecided" until the beginning of my junior year. The only reason I chose interpersonal communications is that it was the only degree I could pursue that would allow me to graduate on time.

As I came close to graduation, I felt like sports marketing was something I'd be good at. I was lucky enough to get an internship with the Cleveland Cavaliers, the professional basketball team, after graduation. But after finding out that all the money went to the players (the operations team

works very long hours for very little pay), I decided to go to graduate school.

With two weeks left before fall semester, someone dropped out of the teaching assistantship program at Penn State University, leaving an opening for yours truly. I taught four semesters of public speaking and ended up with a master's degree in communications.

Overeducated and underexperienced, I traveled to Cleveland, Ohio, to find a job. After sending out seemingly hundreds of résumés with no luck, I took the master's degree off my résumé and started to do temp work. After a few monthlong work engagements, I landed a full-time job at an insurance company working on internal communications projects.

Shortly after starting my new job, I read the book *Think and Grow Rich* by Napoleon Hill. It made a huge impact on how I defined success and what I really wanted to do with my life. Though I read the entire book, cover to cover, there was one powerful passage I felt particularly compelled to remember: "Opportunity has spread its wares before you. Step up to the front, select what you want, create your plan, put the plan into action, and follow through with persistence." It was then that I started to *set goals* for my life.

Next I read *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People* by Stephen Covey. The second habit listed is "Begin with the End in Mind," which means "To begin each day, task, or project with a clear vision of your desired direction and destination, and then continue by flexing your proactive muscles to make things happen." And it was then that I started to *write down my goals* for the first time.

After three years and a few promotions at the insurance company, I left for a new opportunity at Penton Media, then the largest independent business-to-business media company in North America. It was there that I expanded on my education, learning the world of media, marketing communications, and corporate content creation. It was at Penton where I learned the power of listening to an audience and became familiar with the various business models that made media companies work.

In March 2007 I decided to leave Penton Media (where I was vice president of custom media) primarily because I didn't feel I had any real influence over the direction of the company (one of my written goals was to have influence at whatever job I was currently in). So I left and started what was to become the Content Marketing Institute.

In that same year, research conducted by Dr. Gail Matthews from Dominican University of California showed that people who wrote down their goals, shared with a friend, and sent weekly updates to that friend were on average *33 percent more successful* in accomplishing their stated goals than those who merely formulated goals.

So I started to share my goals with others; but more importantly, I reviewed those goals on a daily basis. That's right—every day I would read my goals, making sure I was staying on track.

I separated my goals into the following six categories:

- Financial goals
- Family goals
- Spiritual goals
- Mental goals
- Physical goals
- Philanthropic goals

The difference in the direction my life took from that point on is beyond remarkable to me.

A THINKING PROJECT: YOUR IDEAL SELF

In his book *Atomic Habits*, James Clear talks about finding your true identity as part of developing successful habits. I would call this “searching for your ideal self.”

Before you start to think about what you want to accomplish, you need to spend some time thinking about who you are and who you want to be.

- Do you want to be an athlete?
- Do you want to be a successful business owner?
- Do you want to be a great husband/wife or father/mother?
- Do you want to give more than you receive?

Although it's a bit morbid, *think about what your obituary would say*. What did you accomplish? What did people say about you? Did you start learning piano at age 50? Did you become a triathlete late in life? Did you transform your city in some way? Did you leave this world a better place?

I recommend sitting with these questions for a few days, and if you can, read these before you go to bed at night. The subconscious mind works wonders!

TWO ACTIONS AND THEIR IMPACT ON A *CONTENT INC. APPROACH*

Two daily behaviors have made all the difference for me: *writing down my goals* and *consistently reviewing those goals*.

Why am I telling you this, and what does it have to do with content marketing and this book? Well, in this case, everything.

Every year, Content Marketing Institute and MarketingProfs release an annual benchmark study on the state of content marketing around the globe.

I wanted to know what separates great content marketers from those who are not successful. While many characteristics came to the surface, there are two critical differentiators. Great content marketers do two things differently from the rest:

- They document their content marketing strategy in some way (written, electronic, etc.).
- They review and refer to the plan on a regular basis.

These two actions make the most difference in determining content marketing success. It seems so simple, but the fact is that few marketers do these two things consistently.

Whether it's personal or it's business, the same two critical behaviors rise to the top.

FROM GOAL AREAS TO ACTIONS

Creating goals is one thing. Developing actions around those goals and removing the clutter so you can actually complete the goals is an entirely differently thing. Now it's time to start. I call this goal-setting process the "Three Rs": *record—repeat—remove*.

- **Record.** Document your desires.
- **Repeat.** Review them consistently every day.
- **Remove.** Distance yourself from the clutter in your life so you can be successful.

RECORD

"Record" means that you document your desire. Depending on what research study you look at, about 3 in 100 people actually write down their goals.

Let's say you were going to build a house. If we treated building this house like we do building our lives, we would just call the contractors, the electrician, the plumber, the concrete guy, the drywall team, and the roofers and have them get in a huddle and figure it out.

Can you imagine the chaos of building a house without a plan? But that's what we do with our lives. We don't plan for our desires to come true.

In the 1930s, Napoleon Hill interviewed 500 high achievers including Ford, Roosevelt, and Carnegie to find out why they were so successful. He found, actually, that the key similarity for these high achievers was incredibly simple. *They wrote down their desires.*

But what kind of goals and desires?

Billionaire investor Warren Buffett says: "If you are going to try to bat 1,000%, you won't accomplish many things of importance. If you're willing to strike out a few times, you can change the world."

So we're not talking about small goals here . . . we are talking about *I'm Gonna Change the World* goals. I want my goals to be big and unreasonable. *The problem is that some might feel overwhelmed at this prospect and not do anything.*

Big Goals Are Accomplished Through Everyday Habits

I use the HabitBull app to keep track of my habits so I can accomplish my goals. For example, one of my past goals was to write my first novel. So I thought about what habits would get me to that goal.

What do writers do? They write. Every day.

So I set a goal to write at least one hour every day. For three months solid I wrote at least 1 hour for 44 consecutive days and finished the novel.

So take the big goal, in this case finishing a novel, and write that down in the present or past tense—as if you are actively doing it or you’ve already achieved it:

I Finished My Novel in 2019.

Then add the habit that will help you accomplish the goal so you can measure it:

I Finished My Novel in 2019 by Writing One Hour Every Day.

Boom! That’s all it takes.

REPEAT

What do we mean by “repeat”?

Every day both in the morning and in the evening, we are going to review this goal. We are going to take about 1 percent of our day—less than 15 minutes—to review our desires—the plan for our mental house.

In a study published by Dr. Phillipa Lally and coauthors in the *European Journal of Social Psychology*, 96 people over a 12-week period reported their efforts to change their behavior and habits. They each chose one new habit and reported each day on whether or not they did the behavior and when the behavior became automatic.

Some people chose simple habits such as “drinking three bottles of water a day” or “skipping desserts.” Others chose more difficult tasks such as “exercising for 15 minutes before dinner.” At the end of the 12 weeks, the researchers analyzed the data to determine how long it took each person to go from starting a new behavior to automatically doing it.

On average, *it took 66 days for a new behavior to become automatic.*

This is exactly why you have to review your success goals every day over a long period of time. You have to condition your mind to believe that the goals are attainable. And that helps motivate you to do the habit that leads to the successful accomplishment of your goals.

Here's the big idea most people just don't get. The *most* important thing in accomplishing your goals is to *believe* that it is possible. You don't need more money, skills, abilities, or a better job.

Once you can condition the mind to your goal, your day starts to shape itself.

For me, to be a novelist, I needed to write. Reviewing that goal multiple times per day made sure I was motivated to do the writing, every day.

REMOVE

In order for *record* and *repeat* to work, we have to clear away the garbage that is stopping us from accomplishing our desires.

Microsoft founder Bill Gates didn't really want to meet Warren Buffett. He did not think they'd have anything in common. But at the urging of *Washington Post* editor Meg Greenfield, they met on July 5, 1991. Gates was nervous, dreading the meeting.

Greenfield gave both men a sheet of paper and asked each to write down the one word that is their key to success. Both, as it happened, wrote down the same word: *focus*. The two became best friends.

To be successful, we need focus, we need discipline, and we need to *remove* the distractions around us.

Put Away Your Phone

A few months ago someone asked me to take a coffee meeting with him. He said he had some very important business model questions for me and thought I could help. We met at Panera Bread on the west side of Cleveland.

I sat down and put my coffee on the table. He sat down and put his coffee on the table—along with his phone just to his left, face up. Throughout our chat, he kept looking at his phone. Instagram, Twitter, Messenger . . . all kinds of notifications. Clearly, he was not paying attention to our conversation.

Whenever I see people with a phone—face up or face down—next to them during a meeting, I already know they have a focus problem.

After a bit of back-and-forth, he asked me, “What’s the first thing I should do? I told him to take his smartphone and throw it in the garbage.

Lack of Time?

“I don’t have time to accomplish my goals.” I hear this all the time.

According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, the average American watches three hours of television per day. That’s 1,100 hours per year.

Let’s say that’s you and you’re blessed enough to live to be 80 years old. That means you’ll dedicate almost 10 years of total time to watching television. That’s like turning the TV on when you’re 30 and never moving until you are 40. A lost decade.

What if, instead of watching television (or whatever else you do to kill time), you filled it with meaning?

Record—repeat—remove . . . the simplest of formulas.

WARREN BUFFETT’S 25/5 RULE

Warren Buffett is famous for many things, including his annual goal setting. Follow his lead.

First, list 25 things you want to accomplish. This should take a week or two. Look at all areas of your life. Ask yourself:

- What do I want to accomplish in my career?
- What financial goals do I want to tackle?
- How’s my health? What can I do better? How do I stay in size 32 pants (uh, that’s mine)?
- How about my family? How do I find more quality time?
- What about charitable goals? Is there a cause I should align with?

Don’t stop until you get to at least 25.

Narrow It Down to Five

Take the entire list and select the *most important* five goals.

Once you have selected the five, circle each one. Remember, circle five. No more, no fewer.

Detail a Plan for the Five and Forget the Rest

Of course, you'll want to come up with a plan to accomplish your top five. Critical to success here is how you are going to measure each one.

If the goal is completing a project, how will you get there?

The best part is that once you complete that step, you forget about the other 20 goals you listed.

That's right—following Warren's plan, you vow to never work on them. You need to avoid these at all cost. Why? If you even have an inkling that you can accomplish more than five, you are kidding yourself. Okay, let me qualify that just a bit. I agree with Warren, but I believe you can have six goals—one for each goal area shown below. The same procedure works when you start building your content platform. We'll get to that later.

DO THIS FIRST

This book is filled with actionable items on how to develop and execute your own *Content Inc.* initiative. But without setting a direction for your life, what good will it do?

I've seen so many smart entrepreneurs start with a business idea they think will change the world, only to fail many months later by not having their priorities straight.

Your work begins now. Before you embark on this journey with me, you need to get your goal areas in order. Here's how to do it.

Under each area, list one actionable goal with specific numbers and timetables. It doesn't have to be perfect. And most likely, if you are reading this book, those "career" goals may not be ready for show yet. No worries. You can fill areas in as you delve into this book.

CONTENT INC. IN ACTION

My Goal Areas

Financial

I own companies that I can control at a distance.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Family

I have children who believe they can accomplish anything.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Spiritual

I pray every evening with my family.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Mental

I read one book per month on something non-business related.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Physical

I run three times per week.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Philanthropic

I have helped deliver speech therapy services to children in all 50 states.

1. _____
 2. _____
 3. _____
-

WHAT YOU ARE RISKING WITH A *CONTENT INC.* APPROACH

When I left my “real job” to start a business, countless friends and family members voiced their concerns.

“Are you sure you want to take that big a risk and leave a secure job?”

The question was understandable. I had a young family with two small kids. Heck, even my friends who were entrepreneurs and business owners questioned my move from a six-figure salary and solid benefit package.

The problem was, as cushy as some may have thought my position, I had virtually no control over what the company did or did not do. I’m not sure if my position was at risk, but my job seemed awfully risky, benefits and all.

WHAT CAN YOU CONTROL?

If you’ve ever read any of Robert Kiyosaki’s books (from the *Rich Dad* series), you may see risk a bit differently than most. Here’s an overview:

If you cannot make a phone call or send an email that will directly influence how a company is run, then investing in that company is like

gambling at the casino.

I have investments in the stock market. I own stock in Amazon, Google, Apple, and others. But to be honest, since I cannot call the CEOs of these companies to influence change, these investments are risky to me personally. Whatever you think about investing in stocks, if you have no control over what decisions are made, you are just playing the odds that some companies, for whatever reason, may perform better over time and increase in value.

PULLING THE GOALIE

Malcolm Gladwell never had a rule for living until he read a review paper by Clifford Asness and Aaron Brown titled “Pulling the Goalie: Hockey and Investment Implications.”

Pulling the goalie is a hockey reference. In a 1931 hockey match, the Boston Bruins trailed the Montreal Canadiens 1–0. With a minute to play, Bruins coach Art Ross pulled his goalie out of the game and inserted an extra attacker. The game ended without any additional goals, but Art Ross gets credit for the aggressive coaching move. Today the move is used all the time, generally still with just a minute or less left in a match.

Asness and Brown did the math on the maneuver. They found that pulling the goalie was indeed the proper move, but that coaches weren’t nearly aggressive enough. The authors found that, in actuality, if a team is down by one goal, the coach should pull the goalie at the 6-minute mark. If a team is down by two, it should be the 11-minute mark.

Crazy? Perhaps. Pulling the goalie increases the odds that the other team could score four more times! But (and this is a big but) the team only loses a little when the other team scores. The team was already losing, so losing by three or four, rather than two, doesn’t change things; it’s still a loss.

At the same time, the tactic almost doubles the chance of scoring, because of the extra attacker. The math says that it’s the right decision—and that hockey coaches are way too conservative.

The paper goes into detail about why the coaches are reluctant. The findings? Math (the correct decision) usually takes a back seat to how our actions look to other people.

This is exactly the reason we fail to reach our goals. We keep the goalie in the net for extra defense. For safety. According to the people you hang out with, it's the right thing to do.

Take the job with benefits. Select the college major that could get you a job instead of something you truly love. Never launch a *Content Inc.* business, because people will call you crazy. We make decisions based on what we think will be socially acceptable or offer the least amount of risk. This is bad math.

When I left that executive position in 2007, my friends and family thought I was risking too much and said so to my face. I can only imagine what they said when I wasn't around.

My belief was (and still is) that there is way more risk in working for a company. You don't have control over what the company does or how and when it gives out benefits. Working for someone else almost always puts a cap on your earning potential and overall freedom.

I did the math. The math said leave. Every "sensible" person said stay. And the math worked out really, really well for me. (More on that later.) What is the math telling you about your Content Inc. approach?

The worst case? People will think you are crazy. People may look down on you. They may talk about you behind your back.

The best case? You fulfill every one of your dreams. You win and keep winning until you've won everything.

Time to pull the goalie.

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CHAPTER 2

THE *CONTENT INC.* OPPORTUNITY

Whatever you can do or dream you can, begin it. Boldness has
genius, power and magic in it!

JOHANN WOLFGANG VON GOETHE

This chapter explains why the *Content Inc.* model is perfect for today's economic environment, in terms of both emerging technology and changing consumer behavior. Content-first/audience-first communication, as opposed to product-first thinking, is just beginning to go mainstream.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Wally Koval wanted to travel the world. He started searching Instagram and Reddit and Google for ideas. A huge Wes Anderson fan, Wally wanted to travel to places that “looked as though they could be plucked from the screen of a Wes Anderson film.”

But he ran into a problem during his search. Every wonderful photo that Wally found had no context. “There was no information provided when I was finding [the images], except for some general captions,” says Wally.

So Wally began to research the information behind the amazing images, and started a destinations list using Instagram. “I created this travel bucket

list, just like you would create a list of movies. Like on Netflix, but instead of flipping around, I would have this list. So when we [Wally and his wife Amanda] had vacation time coming up, we just looked at these places.”

Wally’s friends noticed. The pictures were breathtaking. They appreciated the added details. So Wally kept at it. Every day he posted a picture of a destination he wanted to visit that just happened to look like a scene from a Wes Anderson movie.

More and more people began to like Wally’s Instagram page. He was inspired, and started adding even more background information and using specific hashtags that were related to the image or interest area. He named his Instagram page *Accidentally Wes Anderson*.

After a little more than two years, *Accidentally Wes Anderson* amassed 3,000 followers, with some major international tourist boards and media companies as part of the mix. Even *Vogue* magazine got involved. An interview with *Vogue* came out in August 2017, and the follower count on *Accidentally Wes Anderson* jumped by a factor of 10.

Today, Wally and Amanda’s “accident” has more than 1 million followers. In October 2020, they published the book *Accidentally Wes Anderson*, which became an immediate *New York Times* bestseller. Revenues in multiple forms are pouring in.

Best of all, Wally has developed a remarkably substantial, growing business—all while spending time with family and having a blast in the process. Although they aren’t millionaires yet, Wally and Amanda are well on their way.

What Wally and Amanda accomplished would have been impossible 20 years ago. Today this model (called *Content Inc.*) is absolutely possible. More than that, I believe that Wally and the others you’ll hear about in this book have uncovered the least-risky, highest-potential business model available today.

WHAT CHANGED?

Before 1990, there were only eight channels a company could use to communicate with a consumer: at an event, by fax, through direct mail, by telephone, on television, through the radio, on a billboard, or in a print

magazine or newsletter (see [Figure 2.1](#)). In 2021, there are literally thousands of channels where consumers access content.



Figure 2.1 Back in 1990, there were only eight channels to communicate with customers. Today there are thousands.

Original image concept: Jeff Rohrs.

Before 1990, large media companies had the most power, because they controlled the information channels. They controlled access to the audience. Now, more than 30 years later, that power has completely shifted to the consumer. Today consumers have almost unlimited choices when it comes to where and how they consume content. This means that today anyone, anywhere, can be a publisher and build an audience (even if you have very little money). This is a major development in the communications market that affects every business, large and small.

Here are five reasons for this power shift:

1. **No technology barriers.** In the past, the publishing process was complex and expensive. Traditionally, media companies spent hundreds of thousands of dollars on complex content management and production systems. Today anyone can publish for free online in five minutes (seconds?) or less. At the same time, 81 percent of Americans own a smartphone (Pew Research), and 75 percent of US households have internet access (US Census). Simply put, anyone can publish, and anyone can receive content.
2. **Talent availability.** When I started in the publishing business more than 20 years ago, it was often a challenge to find writers and other content creators with a particular expertise. Two things have changed since then. First, credible journalists, writers, and producers are very willing to work with nonmedia companies. In the past, many content creators would balk at the idea of working with nonmedia companies, because it was often considered less prestigious work. That stigma has gone. Second, between Google, dozens of content marketplaces, and direct access through social media, content creators are significantly easier to find. Any company of any size can get access to the best content creators on the planet.
3. **Content acceptance.** Take a look at the current state of consumer behavior:

- 70 percent of consumers prefer finding product information themselves over speaking directly to a company representative (Zendesk).
- Consumers spend 22 times longer engaging with an article from a company than with an advertisement (Pressboard).
- 70 percent of consumers prefer getting to know a company via content rather than through ads (Content+).
- 64 percent of consumers want to communicate directly with brands (Sprout Social).

You don't have to be the *New York Times* or the leading trade magazine in your industry to get people to engage with your content. Readers are open to receiving and engaging in any content that will help them live better lives, get better jobs, or solve a particular problem. You have as much opportunity to deliver amazingly helpful content as anyone else.

4. **Social media.** Social media won't work without valuable, consistent, and compelling information creation and distribution. If any company wants to be successful in social media, it needs to tell compelling stories first. Interesting and helpful stories spread, which means that other people help us market our content. Social media is useless without the content to fuel it.
5. **Search.** Almost every time Google updates its search algorithms, the most helpful information rises to the top (for text and voice search). Even though Google wants to keep more of its traffic to itself, smart entrepreneurs can employ strategies to get found effectively and often. Even the smallest company that understands digital content creation and distribution can beat out a big media company with the right processes.

Today anyone, anywhere, can publish books, develop media sites, and create feature-length movies, with each creator having the ability to reach an audience directly. For example, writer-director Sean Baker released his movie *Tangerine* at the Sundance Festival to glowing critical review. The big deal? He filmed the entire movie using an iPhone. Heck, even Steven Soderbergh has filmed multiple movies using just an iPhone (*Unsane* in 2018 and *High Flying Bird* in 2019).

Disruption is happening everywhere, but nowhere is this more apparent than around content creation and distribution.

Entrepreneurs and small businesses should be rejoicing. Today's technological availability means that any business in any industry can develop an audience through consistent storytelling. No longer does the company with the biggest marketing budget win the most attention. Businesses are now rewarded for the substance of their messages and the audience they can attract through a consistent flow of information.

ENTER CONTENT INC.

Adam Barrie and Lee Wilcox, two young friends from Birmingham, United Kingdom, found their own innovation while drowning their miseries over beers one summer night in 2014. Barrie had been in the trades for 12 years and was struggling to find a plasterer for a job. Wilcox was living with his parents after a divorce and near bankruptcy.

They believed there was a need for tradespeople to connect with industrial companies. But there was no means for doing that in the UK B2B market.

Using about \$10,000 between them, they launched *On The Tools*, a Facebook Page for builders and tradespeople to share funny videos. Within a few months, they hit 250,000 fans. By the end of 2016, they had amassed 1.5 million followers.

Today Adam and Lee have turned their little idea into a multimillion-dollar diversified media company (Electric House) with 88 employees.

How did Adam and Lee do it? How did any of the entrepreneurs and small businesses featured in this book do it? Did the stars align in each of these cases, or is there something about how they launched and positioned their businesses that we can learn from and replicate? Did they just happen to find a model that is *not* capital intensive in any way and in which the core asset is derived from selling educational information or entertainment?

Over 10 years and countless interviews, we've been able to deconstruct and then reengineer the *Content Inc.* model. We've identified a series of steps each entrepreneur took, which together helped us create a new and viable business model for startups (see [Figure 2.2](#)):

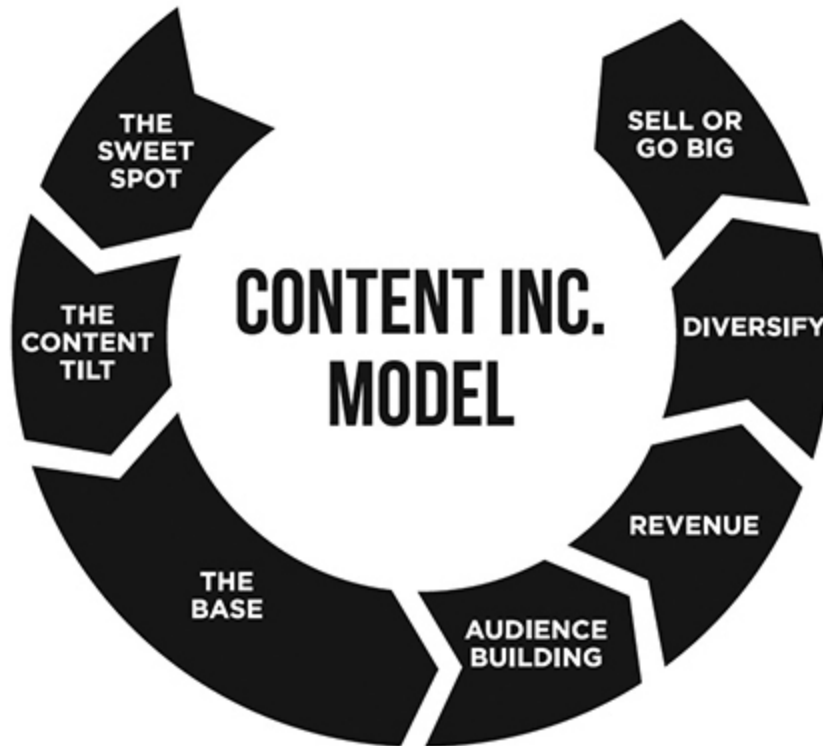


Figure 2.2 Introducing the *Content Inc.* model.

- **The sweet spot.** Mixing a knowledge area or skill with an audience desire
- **The content tilt.** Finding an area of little to no competition so that our content can break through the clutter
- **The base.** Publishing consistently in one core channel
- **Audience building.** Converting the publishing activity to a subscriber asset
- **Revenue.** Creating content experiences that your audience is willing to pay for or sponsors want to access
- **Diversify.** At the proper time, expanding the publishing process to additional channels and/or brand extensions
- **Sell or go big.** Upon success, deciding to build a larger enterprise, create a pure lifestyle business, or exit the business for financial freedom

In the next few chapters, we'll open up the kimono on each one of these areas so that you too can launch and execute a *Content Inc.* model.

A THOUGHT ON WHY

Don Schultz, the father of integrated marketing and author of *Integrated Marketing Communications*, discussed the idea that any company, anywhere in the world, can copy everything about what you as a company do, except for one thing—how you communicate. The way we communicate with our prospects and customers is the one remaining way we can actually *be* different.

In their book *Experiences: The 7th Era of Marketing*, Robert Rose and Carla Johnson build on Schultz's commentary by adding that valuable information, and the experiences that customers have with our content, is the ultimate differentiator.

This is why entrepreneurs who follow a *Content Inc.* strategy have a strategic advantage over other companies. The entire business model is dedicated to developing content experiences and building an audience, not leading by selling products.

NO PRODUCT? THAT'S GOOD!

Sometimes having product offerings hurts a *Content Inc.* model. Take the print magazine industry, for example. For years, print magazine publishers were so protective about keeping print advertising dollars that they were ignoring the audience's need for digital, events, or subscription products. Print magazine providers that didn't listen to this change are no longer with us.

When all your focus is on an audience you know deeply, instead of a product, good things usually happen. When we listen intently to our audience, we are automatically led to new product opportunities. The challenge is that sometimes we don't know when the model will take shape—which is why patience with the *Content Inc.* model is key. As Chris Brogan, founder of *The Backpack Show*, states, audiences are eager for their lives to be changed in some way. Focusing on that gives *Content Inc.* the advantage.

CONTENT INC. LEARNINGS FROM NAPOLEON HILL

Napoleon Hill's classic *Think and Grow Rich* was first published in 1937. Even though they're more than 80 years old now, Napoleon Hill's lessons are still extremely relevant and valuable.

Desire

Whatever the mind can conceive and believe, it can achieve.

You can talk about all the things *Content Inc.* businesses should do to attract and retain customers—content strategy, content planning, content organization, content integration, etc.—but desire is numero uno. Everywhere I speak I hear the objection that most businesses simply do not have the desire to be *the* informational resource for their customers and prospects—these businesses don't want it enough. They talk of content creation as a chore, not as a core service to customers that is necessary for the company's survival.

Faith

Faith is the eternal elixir that gives life, power, and action to the impulse of thought!

Wanting it is one thing, but actually believing you can be *the* informational expert for your industry is another. When we first started the Content Marketing Institute, we firmly believed that we would be the informational resource for our industry. It was unquestioned. It was only a matter of time, energy, and persistence.

Rarely do you see this kind of faith from startups around content creation. When I worked at a business publishing company and met with the chief editors for our brands, they believed without question that their brand was the leading provider of information in the space. It was a nonissue. It just was. That is exactly the kind of faith you need to be the expert in your field.

Specialized Knowledge

General knowledge, no matter how great in quantity or variety it may be, is of but little use.

A lack of specialization is one of the biggest failures when it comes to content. I see heating and air-conditioning companies blogging about the town festival next week. I see manufacturing companies creating videos on human resources best practices. It hurts to see this.

To be the expert in your industry, you must first define your customers' pain points and the niche industry you will cover that will make a difference in your business and in your customers' lives. Get laser-focused. Think of yourself as the trade magazine for your industry. Cover that. Be the expert in that area. If you are a large enterprise, you will need separate content missions and strategies, not a broad one that has no impact on anybody.

Imagination

It has been said that one can create anything that one can imagine.

As Napoleon Hill says, ideas are the products of the imagination. For a *Content Inc.* approach to work, you need to embrace being not just a content factory, but also an idea factory. Just as news organizations cover the news of the day, you need to cover the news as it relates to your content niche (more on that later). Take the content that you have and think creatively about storytelling concepts—visual, textual, and audio—in new and compelling ways.

Decision

Procrastination, the opposite of decision, is a common enemy that must be conquered.

Napoleon Hill profiled hundreds of the most successful people in the world. Every one of them reached decisions promptly and changed these decisions slowly, if and when they changed their minds. Unsuccessful

people, the book says, reach decisions slowly (if at all) and change these decisions quickly and often.

Persistence

Willpower and desire, when properly combined, make an irresistible pair.

Without a doubt, the biggest reason content marketing fails is because it stops. I've seen business after business start a blog, e-newsletter, white paper program, or podcast series and stop after a few months. Content marketing is a war of attrition. It's a process. Success does not happen overnight. You must commit for the long haul if you want to be successful.

Before you dive into the rest of the book, I want to give you a serious warning—there are some drawbacks to unleashing the *Content Inc.* model. Some things to consider:

- **Patience.** The model takes time to work. Many of the case studies discussed in this book didn't blossom for a year or two or more. The payoff is big, but it may take a while to get there.
- **Lack of funds.** *Content Inc.* is not an immediate get-rich-quick scheme. You are building a valuable asset. While you are doing that, revenue may be hard to come by. Lower your expenses and get lean so you can make it to the finish line.
- **Against the grain.** *Content Inc.* is a philosophy that most business and startup experts would vehemently disagree with. You are doing something that almost no one would ever think of doing. You need to be able to handle the criticism.
- **Going small to go big.** Many companies fail because they don't pick a content niche that's small enough. They are afraid the niche will be too small to monetize. I've never found that to be the case. Most failures occur because the entrepreneur goes too broad and not narrow enough.

Now that you've been warned, get ready for the business model that will change your life. If you stick with it and can battle against the negativity, success is yours.

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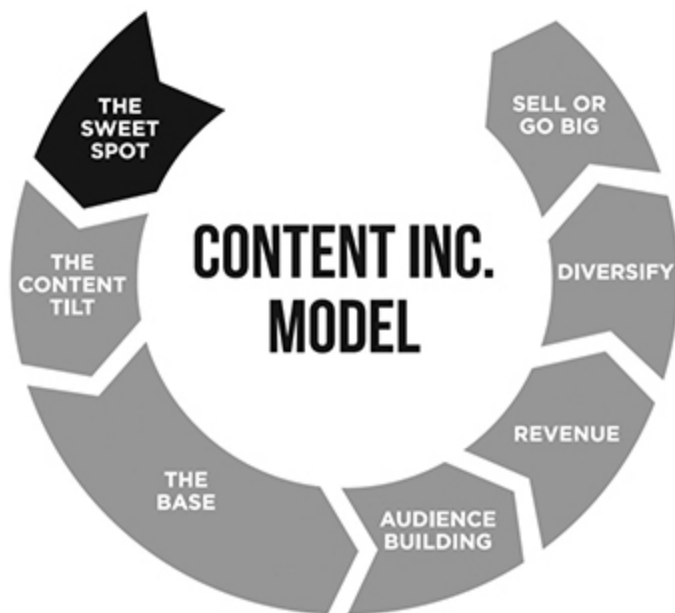
PART 2

THE SWEET SPOT

The essence of strategy is choosing what not to do.

MICHAEL PORTER

Every successful content creator has a sweet spot. It's time for you to find yours.



CHAPTER 3

EXPERTISE + DESIRE

Your work is to discover your work, and then with all your heart
to give yourself to it.

BUDDHA

This chapter defines and outlines the first step in the *Content Inc.* model: the sweet spot. It's the intersection of your expertise (knowledge or skill area) and an audience's desire. Your strategy starts here.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Matthew Patrick grew up in the small city of Medina, just outside Cleveland, Ohio. For as long as he can remember, he's been passionate about gaming, from growing up with a Mario-themed bedroom to late nights with friends playing Dungeons & Dragons. During high school, when most boys in his class went out for sports, Matthew joined the show choir, played the viola in the orchestra, and took part in every stage show the school offered.

Yes, Matthew loved performing, but he was also a genius, scoring a perfect 1600 on his SAT on his way to a college degree in neuroscience. Instead of going to fraternity parties on weekends at college, Matthew hosted Friday fondue nights playing Zelda (a popular video game).

After college, Matthew had his sights set on acting and moved to New York, where he toured with various shows. For two years, Matthew took whatever role was available—and saw about as much success as the average starving actor in New York. To put it lightly, times were tough. Theater wasn't the life Matthew was hoping for.

By 2011, Matthew gave up his dream of becoming an actor and decided to go after a “real” job. Unfortunately, acting and directing were not skills that innovative enterprises were hiring for. Over the next two years, Matthew sent out countless résumés. During that time, he was unemployed; worse yet, his confidence had bottomed out. Not one person opened a door to give Matthew the shot he seemingly deserved.

Matthew pulled himself up by his bootstraps and decided to create a résumé booster that companies simply couldn't ignore. He believed that if he could show companies that he knew how to create an audience and that he understood the inner workings of new media, enterprises would see value in those skills.

While Matthew was watching an online program on learning through gaming, the idea of creating *Game Theory* videos was born. His show *Game Theory* became a weekly YouTube video series that combined his skill set of math and analytics with an audience interested in quirky video games.

After the first year's 56 episodes, Matthew had an audience of 500,000 YouTube subscribers interested in his take on strange math formulas and conspiracy theories in gaming. For example, his episode “How PewDiePie [an online video celebrity] Conquered YouTube” generated more than 8.5 million views. His episode “Why the Official Zelda Timeline Is Wrong” saw more than 8 million downloads.

Today Matthew Patrick's *The Game Theorists* brand has more than 13 million subscribers. Some of the biggest YouTube stars on the planet have hired Matthew to help them attract more viewers. Even the mighty YouTube itself hired MatPat (his online name) to consult on helping YouTube retain and grow its audience numbers.

THE SWEET SPOT

Start where you are. Use what you have. Do what you can.

ARTHUR ASHE

The *Content Inc.* model depends on first identifying the sweet spot. Simply put, the sweet spot is the intersection of your expertise (knowledge or skill) and an audience's desire or pain point (see [Figure 3.1](#)).



Figure 3.1 The sweet spot is the intersection between your expertise and an audience's desire.

Let's take a look at a variety of *Content Inc.* sweet spots.

ANTHONY FASANO (ENGINEERING MANAGEMENT INSTITUTE)

Anthony always wanted to help engineers on their softer skills. He noticed that there was plenty of information for engineers on their craft, but not much out there about how engineers could improve their communication skills.

Anthony had an odd but valuable skill set. He was a trained engineer who also spent his first years out of college training other engineers how to

network, bring in new business, and manage teams. After a few years of training, Anthony started to believe he could try something on his own. He built the Engineering Management Institute (EMI), which now regularly provides educational information (mostly through podcasts) to more than 20,000 engineers. [Figure 3.2](#) shows EMI's sweet spot.

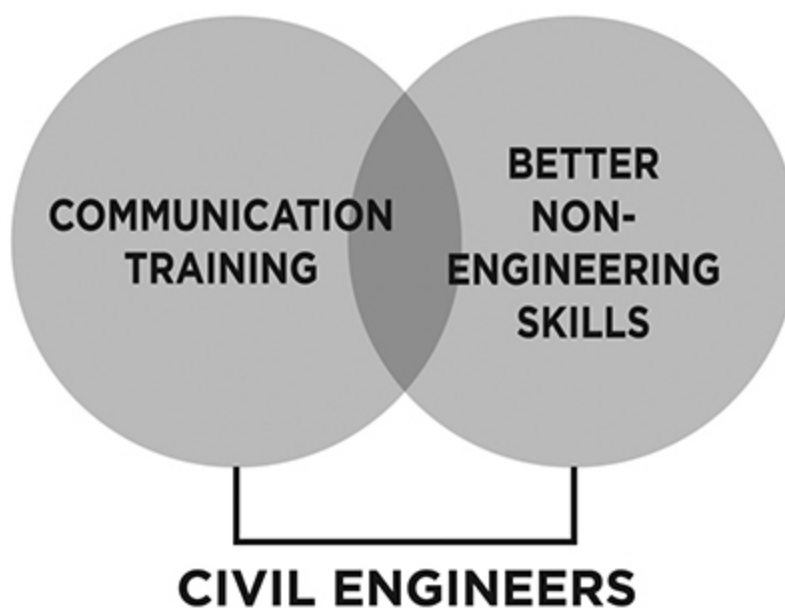


Figure 3.2 EMI's sweet spot is the intersection between EMI's expertise in communication training and civil engineers' desire for networking skills.

ALESSANDRA TORRE (TORRE INK)

Alessandra Torre has made the *New York Times* bestsellers list an amazing seven times, publishing a total of 23 novels. If you didn't look closely, you'd just think that she was a remarkable and successful novelist.

About five years after she started her writing career, she began to notice how many writers were contacting her with questions: "How did you get started?" "What publishing tools do you use?" "Should I go with an agent or not?" "How do I make the *New York Times* bestsellers list?"

After answering these individually for months at a time, Alessandra thought of a better way to help aspiring authors.

"I started putting together lessons and then building a library of videos so I could direct people to everything I know about publishing and writing and marketing," she says. Just like that, Alessandra Torre Ink was born. It

includes the successful Inkers Con authors conference and multiple membership and training programs.



Figure 3.3 Torre Ink’s sweet spot—Torre Ink excels at book publishing. Alessandra’s audience of first-time authors needs to know how to publish a book.

ANDY SCHNEIDER (BRANDED AS THE CHICKEN WHISPERER)

Andy Schneider is the backyard poultry king and has become the go-to resource for anything and everything chickens. As Andy began to raise chickens in his Atlanta-area backyard, he began to sell them to his friends directly and then on Craigslist. There were many who were interested in raising their own chickens, but they needed a lot of education to just get started. So Andy formed a meetup in Atlanta to answer questions from those interested in backyard poultry (see [Figure 3.4](#)).



Figure 3.4 The Chicken Whisperer finds his sweet spot. Suburban homeowners in Atlanta wanted to know about how to raise chickens.

According to Andy, “All these people are from the Atlanta metro area; we could meet once a month, have a great time, break bread in the meeting room in the backroom of a restaurant, and share our experiences and learn. So I got online and found a great resource, [Meetup.com](https://www.meetup.com), very popular, millions of meetups all around the country for people who have hobbies.”

That club met several times a month, and as the club grew, local media started to notice. The local CBS affiliate did an interview with Andy, which was picked up by Atlanta’s major newspaper, the *Atlanta Journal Constitution*. From there, Andy grew the Chicken Whisperer platform into a book, a magazine (with more than 60,000 subscribers), and a radio show, which has now run for over 10 years and has racked up 1,200-plus episodes. He also travels around the country doing road shows, exclusively sponsored by Tucker Milling, his major financial supporter.

FINDING YOUR EXPERTISE AREA

In looking at various *Content Inc.* subjects, the model works by first identifying a key knowledge area. My friend JK Kalinowski has knowledge

in a number of areas, including the band KISS, the Pittsburgh Steelers, superheroes, and Jack Daniels. In any one of these topics, JK could destroy the average person with his knowledge.

In addition to his knowledge areas, JK is also a skilled designer. Recently, JK found one side of the sweet spot by designing different representations of superhero characters, leveraging both his skill as a designer and his knowledge about superheroes.

WHERE TO START?

Begin by listing those areas in which you have a large skill set or knowledge area in something versus what the average person knows. This is brainstorming time, so more is better at this point.

Knowledge Areas	Special Skills

If you completed the exercise correctly, you should have vastly more knowledge areas than skill areas.

Here’s how mine turned out:

Knowledge Areas	Special Skills
The stock market	Public speaking
Billy Joel songs	Nonfiction/fiction writing
Business models	Building publishing models
Cleveland sports teams	Teaching
'80s baseball cards	

Maybe your situation is closer to that of the Indium Corporation. Indium, a global manufacturing company headquartered in upstate New York, develops and manufactures materials used primarily in the electronics assembly industry. At its core, the company develops soldering materials that keep electronic components from coming apart.

Rick Short, Indium's director of marketing communications, knew that Indium employees had more knowledge about industrial soldering equipment than just about any other company in the world. This makes sense. Soldering is the knowledge area in which Indium manufactures most of its products. The Indium culture is that of sharing knowledge, a rising tide lifting all ships. The company had subject-matter experts that were willing to share the art of soldering, as well as a marketing team that was excited about sharing knowledge via social media. But as Rick notes, more important than any of their expertise was the deep need that engineers had for education around the soldering process.

The company chose a blog as its platform for this sweet spot. Indium's blog, called *From One Engineer to Another*, has grown its writing staff from 2 regular bloggers to 29 expert bloggers. Today the blog is Indium's number one new business generator.

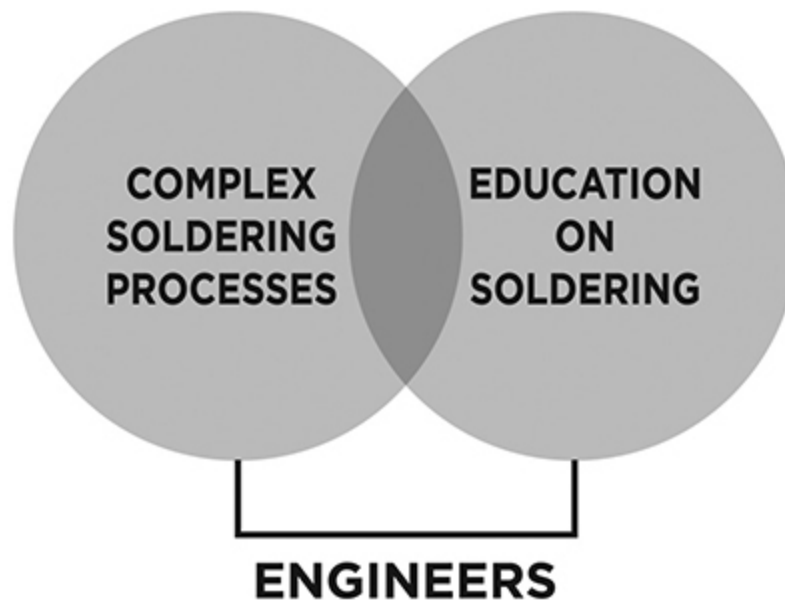


Figure 3.5 Indium Corporation's sweet spot.

WHY PASSION IS NOT MANDATORY

Steve Jobs's 2005 Stanford commencement speech has been watched more than 12 million times. In it, he gives the following advice: "You've got to find what you love. [T]he only way to do great work is to love what you do. If you haven't found it yet, keep looking, and don't settle."

Cal Newport, author of the book *So Good They Can't Ignore You*, believes that if Steve Jobs had taken his own advice, Apple Computer would have never happened. Newport says that “if a young Steve Jobs had taken his own advice and decided to only pursue work he loved, we would probably [have found him] as one of the Los Altos Zen Center’s most popular teachers.”

Some people call the content entrepreneur/content creator industry the Passion Economy. I believe that term is imprecise. As NYU Professor Scott Galloway repeatedly says, “follow your talent, not your passion.” This is true for *Content Inc.* models.

For example, you may have a deep passion for combustible engines or 64-bit computing. Problem is, there isn’t really an opportunity to exploit those areas through *Content Inc.* models. Instead, find something that you have expertise and talent in. Then, invest in that. Educate yourself around that. Over time, you’ll uncover an opportunity for *Content Inc.*

Is it helpful to be passionate about your *Content Inc.* industry or audience or platform? Absolutely. Mandatory? Not at all.

You don’t have to be passionate about everything you are doing to be successful . . . only one part. Many content entrepreneurs are not passionate about their industry, the audience, and the content. Just one area of passion seems to be enough.

NOTHING MATTERS WITHOUT THE AUDIENCE

Look at the sweet spot examples again. They’re successful examples because the entrepreneur understands the audience’s specific desire.

The sweet spot works because someone, somewhere, desires something. People have specific needs and pain points that need to be filled or solved.

Your knowledge or skill level, while important to you, doesn’t mean anything if it can’t help your audience. It’s the mix of what you know and what an audience needs that completes the sweet spot. That’s up next.

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CHAPTER 4

AUDIENCE DEEP DIVE

Everyone has a story to tell or product to sell. Know your audience before you open your mouth.

ANONYMOUS

Knowledge is great, but if you don't know whom you are targeting with that knowledge, it's not very useful in a *Content Inc.* model. Let's figure out with what group you will build a relationship.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

A few years back I participated in a workshop for enterprise marketers in Toronto. In one conversation at the workshop, the blog manager for a billion-dollar technology company told me she was having problems with her blog. She had been adding more and more daily content to the blog, and at the same time was seeing stagnant website traffic and far fewer subscribers and conversions.

My first question: "Who is the audience for your blog?"

She answered: "We target 18 different audiences."

Me: "I found your problem."

WHO'S THE WHO?

Countless businesses fail with their *Content Inc.* model because they focus on what they are good at communicating—and not on the specific audience and what it needs.

When it's all about us and we are sharing what we know without a deep focus on audience desire, who really cares? Probably not very many people.

In order to complete the sweet spot formula, we need to clearly identify the “who.” Who is the audience for your content? Remember, for the *Content Inc.* model to work, we need to figure out how we can build the engine that delivers an amazing content experience for our particular market niche. To make this happen, we need to define our audience and its needs and pain points as specifically as possible ([Figure 4.1](#)).



Figure 4.1 The model doesn't work without knowing the audience inside and out.

Ask the following questions:

1. Who is your typical audience member? How does this person live an average day?
2. What's the person's need? This is not “Why does the person need our product or service?” but “What are this person's informational needs and pain points as they relate to the stories we will tell?”

3. Why will this person care about us, our products, our services? It's the information we provide that will make that person care or pay attention.

Your idea of the “who” doesn't have to be perfect, but it needs to be detailed enough that you can clearly visualize this person in your head as you develop content.

Doug Kessler, cofounder of the UK agency Velocity Partners, says the sweet spot is “the thing your company knows better than—or at least as well as—anyone else in the world.” Understanding the “who” gives you the context you need to make this happen.

Marcus Sheridan and River Pools & Spas became the worldwide leader in information about fiberglass pools for homeowners considering a purchase. If Marcus were targeting fiberglass pool manufacturers, the content would be vastly different. It's the “who” that gives the content the context it needs to be successful.

THE STORY OF RIVER POOLS & SPAS

In late 2009, River Pools & Spas, a 20-employee installer of fiberglass pools in the Virginia and Maryland area, was in trouble. Homeowners were not running out and buying fiberglass pools during the Great Recession. Worse yet, customers who had actually planned on buying a pool were calling up River Pools to request their deposits back. Some deposits were around \$50,000 or more.

For multiple weeks, River Pools overdrew its checking account. Not only was it becoming difficult to pay employees, but the company was looking at possibly closing up shop for good.

CEO Marcus Sheridan believed that the only way to survive was to steal market share from the competition. That meant thinking differently about how the company went to market.

At the beginning of this process, River Pools did just over \$4 million in annual revenues and spent approximately \$250,000 a year on marketing. There were four competitors in the Virginia area that had greater market share.

Two years later, River Pools & Spas sold more fiberglass pools than any other fiberglass pools installer in North America. The company also decreased its marketing spend from \$250,000 to around \$40,000, while at the same time winning 15 percent more bids and cutting its sales cycle in half. The average pool builder lost 50 to 75 percent in sales during the time that River Pools increased sales to more than \$5 million.

Needless to say, River Pools & Spas stayed open.

How did Marcus do it? He wrote down every conceivable customer question and answered it on his blog. Today, from search engine results to social media sharing, River Pools & Spas is the world's leading information provider on the subject of fiberglass pools.

The Rest of the Story

River's story has been shared around the world. But here's something you probably don't know. Content creation has made River Pools an international force. Companies all over the world called on River Pools for installations; one even asked Marcus to fly in and personally oversee an installation. Unfortunately, River Pools only serviced companies in a very small area and could not take advantage of the additional demand.

Enter manufacturing. River Pools began manufacturing its own fiberglass pools. This came about directly because of its content exposure. River Pools & Spas is now positioning itself as the leading installer and manufacturer of fiberglass pools, taking the business in a completely different direction.

Once you develop an audience around your content, the opportunities to sell additional products are almost endless.

MAKING IT REAL

After giving up on his dream of becoming a rock star, Chad Ostrowski decided to be a teacher. It wasn't a pleasant transition.

"Chad would tell you he had the worst year of his life," says business partner and friend Jeff Gargas. "He got to the point where he knew he

needed to make changes to be able to teach better, or he had to stop being a teacher. He was just struggling.”

Chad created something he called the “Grid Method,” a self-paced competency-based system, out of sheer desperation.

The Grid Method began to work. Chad started getting recognition and interest from his fellow teachers at his school, and later in his district and from his administration. “He was getting stopped in the hallway with a lot of questions [from teachers] about what he changed in the classroom,” says Gargas.

Chad believed he had something, but he didn’t know what. So he met with Gargas, who had recently started an online marketing business. After the meeting, both Chad and Jeff (and later adding Rae Hughtart) believed they could take the Grid Method and help teachers in classrooms around the country.

This meeting spawned one of the most successful teaching sites in the world, Teach Better, which today works with school districts all over the country and teachers all over the globe. The key to its success is audience focus.

Teach Better isn’t for all teachers. It is for a very specific kind of teacher. “When we [create content], we focus on a teacher who is in a place where either (1) they’ve realized that they need to recapture or reignite their passion or (2) they’ve realized that [much] of the education system is broken and they want to meet their students where they are,” says Gargas.

Let’s break down Teach Better’s sweet spot. The knowledge/skill is the Grid Method. According to the Teach Better site, “The Grid Method is a student-centered, competency-based system, created at the classroom level and designed to fit any teacher’s style, within any curriculum, in any classroom.” Step one complete.

Now let’s move to the audience desire. Chad and Jeff target teachers who are desperate to improve their situations. They need to either find a better way or leave the profession.

The intersection of the Grid teaching method and the realization that a large number of disenchanted teachers are looking for a better way became Teach Better’s sweet spot ([Figure 4.2](#)).

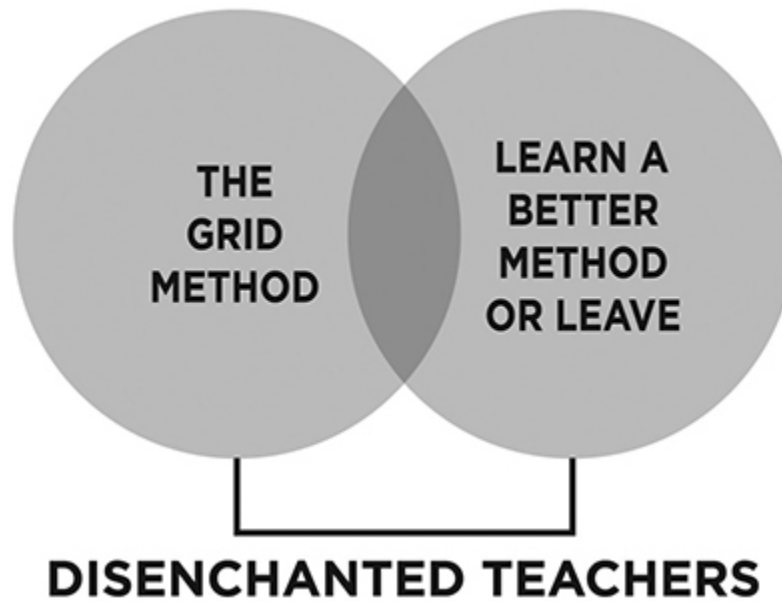


Figure 4.2 Teach Better’s Grid Method targets disenchanting teachers.

Now let’s go back to our friend the Chicken Whisperer. Andy Schneider’s original sweet spot was his knowledge of backyard poultry and a desire by homeowners to learn the art of raising chickens. What made this really work for Andy is that he started small with his audience: suburban homeowners in the Atlanta area.

Now we have enough information to capture the sweet spot in a single sentence. This is similar to how media companies start to construct a content mission statement (more on this later).

Andy Schneider’s mission statement might look something like this:

Answering every possible question suburban homeowners in the Atlanta area might have about raising chickens at home.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

Now that you’ve seen a visual example of the sweet spot, let’s add some dimension to your model. This template can help you begin to construct your initial strategy:

Mission: _____

Key Audience: (Be as specific as possible.) _____

Sample Titles/Functions: _____

Why This Group Is Important: (This is a critical first step in thinking about the purchase power these people have. You'll learn more about this in the chapter on revenue.)

Sample Topic Areas: (What questions need answering.) _____

Here is an example of what this looked like for Content Marketing Institute when we officially started in 2010. One of our key decisions was to focus on content practitioners in larger organizations, instead of in all organizations.

CONTENT MARKETING INSTITUTE

Mission: Delivering detailed, how-to content marketing information to enterprise marketers to help them build audiences and succeed in their marketing careers.

Key Audience: Content marketing practitioners and content creators in large enterprise organizations.

Sample Titles/Functions: Content marketing director, content marketing manager, manager of digital strategy, vice president

marketing, digital marketing manager, public relations manager/director, director of social media, communications directors.

Why This Group Is Important: The majority of marketing in organizations still involves paid media. CMI believes that, over the next decade, the majority of marketing will be content coming directly from brands, instead of advertising or sponsorships. Enterprises today are completely unequipped to handle this transformation and need vast amounts of education and training on the strategies of content marketing.

Sample Topic Areas: Building a strategy, building an audience, operationalizing the process (including getting executive buy-in and continually justifying and communicating progress), content creation, content promotion and distribution, measurement, and ROI.

In the movie *The Grand Budapest Hotel*, the lobby boy's job was to know the clientele so well that he could anticipate their needs. That is your role now. Your job is to learn your audience so well that you'll be able to develop ongoing content that is so good, the people in your audience weren't even aware they needed it in the first place.

RESOURCES

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Interview with Jeff Gargas by Clare McDermott, August 2020.

Interview with Marcus Sheridan by Clare McDermott and Joe Pulizzi, January 2015 and August 2020.

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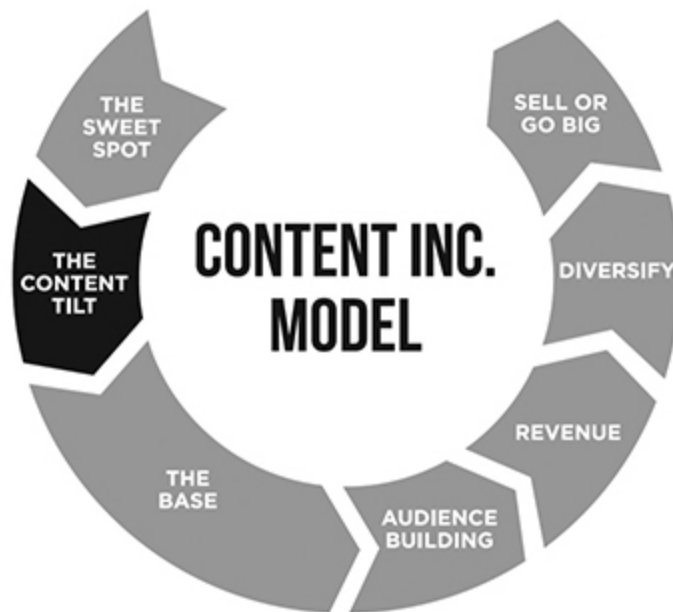
PART 3

THE CONTENT TILT

You can't depend on your eyes when your imagination is out of focus.

MARK TWAIN

There is so much of the same content out there in the world. To succeed with *Content Inc.*, you need to step out of the pack.



CHAPTER 5

TILT OR BUST

When a trout rises to a fly, it does not swim as much as tilt its fins
and jet skyward.

JOSEPH MONNINGER

Unfortunately, the sweet spot is not enough. We need to differentiate
our content enough to break through the clutter, which is almost
impossible without content tilt.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

I n the movie *The Matrix*, which stars Keanu Reeves and Laurence Fishburne, Reeves's character (Neo) is tested to see whether he is "The One." While Neo is outside in the waiting area, a young protégé sitting next to him is holding up spoon after spoon, bending each one. As Neo sits beside the protégé, the young boy tells Neo that he has to look at the spoon in a different way . . . that the spoon actually does not exist at all.

Soon after, Neo is able to tilt his head to the side and slowly bend the spoon.

TELLING A DIFFERENT STORY

Peter Thiel believes that most businesses copy other businesses and thus fail. In his book *Zero to One*, Thiel tells businesses that they should “figure out something that nobody else is doing and look to create a monopoly in some area that’s been underdeveloped. Find a problem nobody else is solving.” Sadly, most companies are creating content and telling stories that are no different from anything else.

Just type “cloud computing” into Google, and you’ll get more than 462 million results. Then go to Amazon, Oracle, Salesforce, and Microsoft and check out their content on cloud computing. It’s pretty much all the same information. Who’s the expert on cloud computing? Apparently not these four companies.

There are a lot of businesses talking about the same things in the same way. Sameness will never break through all the clutter. Doug Kessler calls this “the mountain of meh,” where businesses work to create content that just turns out to be like everything else. *Meh*.

There are hundreds of blogs on chili peppers that tell stories behind the peppers’ heat. Chili-pepper superstar Claus Pilgaard found a way to tell a story that was radically different from that of his content competition by talking about the peppers’ taste. Claus is now an international chili-pepper celebrity because he approached the content area in a new way. Claus’s content tilt made all the difference.

CONTENT TILTING

If *Content Inc.* is to work for you, your content must be different. It must fill a content hole that someone else isn’t already filling. You must find a problem area that no one else is solving and exploit that area with valuable information. This is called creating a content tilt.

The content tilt is that area of little to no competition on the web that actually gives you a chance to break through the noise and be relevant. It’s what makes you so different that your audience notices you and rewards you with its attention.

While identifying the sweet spot is critical to the *Content Inc.* process, it’s the content tilt that will separate you from everyone else in your market area. Andrew Davis, author of *Town Inc.*, calls this the hook—a simple twist on a familiar theme designed to snag your audience. If you don’t tilt your

content just enough to make your story different, your content will fade into the rest of the clutter and be forgotten.

Action Roofing has serviced the market in Santa Barbara, California, for more than 30 years. The company does many things well, including roof service and installation, but the majority of people know Action because of CEO Jack Martin's daily weather reports. A sample from October 5, 2020:

Good Monday Morning,

Today at my house we are starting out with dampness and drizzle. It is wet out there for some coastal locations. My camera even spotted a raccoon on my steps this morning.

Jack's almost daily weather reports are so popular even the local news stations often comment on Jack's folksy weather banter.

CASE STUDY: ANN REARDON

In 2011, after giving birth to her third son, Ann Reardon launched a recipe site called How to Cook That. "I wrote a recipe post every week and made some videos to complement the website. The videos were too big to upload to my website, so I uploaded them to YouTube and started embedding them onto my site."

Before starting a family, Ann worked as a qualified food scientist and dietitian (her skill area). At the same time, she had a passion for teaching and working with children, so she changed careers and began working with youth in a poorer area of Western Australia.

"I absolutely loved it and have so many great memories," shares Ann. "But our budget was extremely tight, so it was during this time that I taught myself to edit videos for the youth ministry, as well as self-catering for lots of events. Over time some of the young adults asked if I could teach them how to cook. A group would come over and we'd all bake and have a great time in my kitchen."

You may be thinking that recipe blogs and how-to baking on YouTube are nothing new, and you'd be right. What separates Ann is her content tilt.

Ann focuses her recipes and baking on seemingly *impossible desserts*, such as a cake that is actually a five-pound Snickers bar or a cake that looks like a Bob Ross painting.

“Many people start a YouTube channel and try to copy what has already been done, but the horse has already bolted,” Ann explains. “For every single breath you take, there are 8 hours of new video footage uploaded to YouTube, so I have to give viewers a good reason to come back and watch my channel.”

In January 2012, Ann saw her 100th subscriber on YouTube and was thrilled. Eight years later, Ann has had nearly 1 billion downloads. Combining all her current platforms, Ann reaches approximately 1 million people per month.

Ann found her sweet spot, the combination of her knowledge of food and her audience's interest in food-oriented, step-by-step education, it was her content tilt of seemingly impossible dessert creations that made all the difference ([Figure 5.1](#)).

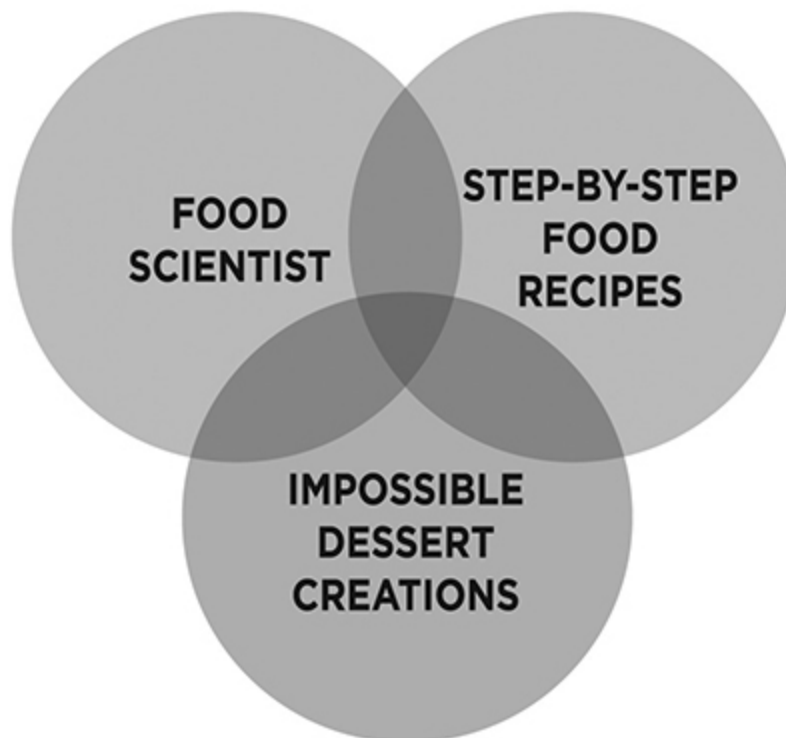


Figure 5.1 Ann Reardon's content tilt was her focus on impossible dessert creations.

THE ODD STRUGGLE WITH STARTUPS AND CONTENT

Jay Acunzo, owner of Marketing Showrunners, has worked with a number of technology startups on content marketing. Oddly enough, while most tech startups want to create the best product in the world for their niche, they don't believe the same about their content.

In an interview, Jay says:

I say [to start ups], do you think that your product, either now or in the future, is going to be the best solution to solving whatever problem you've identified in the market? Because that's really why tech founders start companies; they see a problem, and they want to solve it better than what is in existence. So 100 percent of these founders say unequivocally yes, we're going to have a better product than our competitors.

So then I say, why is it true for your product but not your content? And for me it always comes back to mentality and skill set. They don't think about content in the way that [marketers] think about it. They think about it as a random collection of best practices that just get recycled. "So we've got to blog a lot. Everyone else is blogging, so why should we blog?"

It's not about that. It's about can you solve the problem in a way that is unique? Your product does that, but your content should also do that. Everybody is talking about theoretically how to do marketing, and you're like, "This is really hard; I'm going to build a product that is going to make marketing really, really simple and almost like plug and play." That's great! You're confident your product can do that, so if you're going to create content, don't just blog; do [something different].

They [startups] are so confident that they can do something different that no one has ever seen before with their product, and there is a lot of noise. A lot of people have done what they're doing

before, but they're like no, I don't care; I'm going to do better. Yet when they come to the content, they're like no, I can't be different. I think it's mentality and skill set that is causing them to say that.

. . . I think you just have to think much harder about choosing your niche and on what angle on the problem you're taking with your product . . . that has to come through with your content. And guess what, if your content reflects the product and it's still not innovative enough, chances are that your product wasn't going to stick anyways, so you might want to revisit the actual thesis for the business. I'm always blown away by that. All these entrepreneurs are so confident that we can solve this problem better than anybody else with our product, and it should articulate that through the content too and they just don't think that way.

CASE STUDY: MIILD

In 2016, makeup artist Tine Emilie Svendsen suddenly experienced severe allergic reactions. Sneezing. Red marks on her face. Trouble swallowing. Her dermatologist said it was caused by certain chemicals in her cosmetics.

After conversations with a few of her friends, Emilie realized that many more people have difficulty wearing cosmetics for the same reason.

Soon after, Emilie partnered with her friend Tanja Gregersen and marketing expert Nicki Larsen with the idea of creating sustainable, hypoallergenic makeup. It was a bold concept, and it would take years to get a product to market. Instead, they leveraged a *Content Inc.* model.

“The cosmetics industry is one big claim game and not transparent at all. The first thing we did was launch a blog named *thisispure.dk* to highlight the problems with regular cosmetics and provide guidance,” explains Larsen.

They began testing content on a number of channels, but Instagram became the key. The channel (@miildbeauty) started growing rapidly, as more and more young women sought out their consistent advice on the challenges of wearing traditional makeup. It seemed that Miild's focus on the more scientific side of cosmetics and allergies exploited a clear content gap.

Today Miild's *Content Inc.* approach includes Instagram (32,000 followers), a robust email newsletter offering (9,000 subscribers), Facebook (5,500 members), and YouTube. By becoming one of the leading informational experts in the Danish hypoallergenic industry, the company's 2017 launch was a huge success, with Miild running out of product stock five times during the year due to surging demand.

In spring 2020, it announced that Matas, an omnichannel retail chain with an estimated 80 percent market share in Denmark, had acquired 40 percent of the company for an undisclosed amount. In addition, partnerships with major retail chains in Norway and Germany have been freshly inked.

In the end, the three founders succeeded with their original goal: they became the world's first brand for certified, hypoallergenic makeup products through a content-first approach.

Miild did many things right in its *Content Inc.* journey. The founders' expertise and knowledge of hypoallergenic products, matched with Danish women's desire for eco-friendly, sustainable makeup and advice on how to use it, was a great start at a sweet spot. But that wasn't enough. It was the focus on the scientific angle of cosmetics and allergies that made the difference ([Figure 5.2](#)).

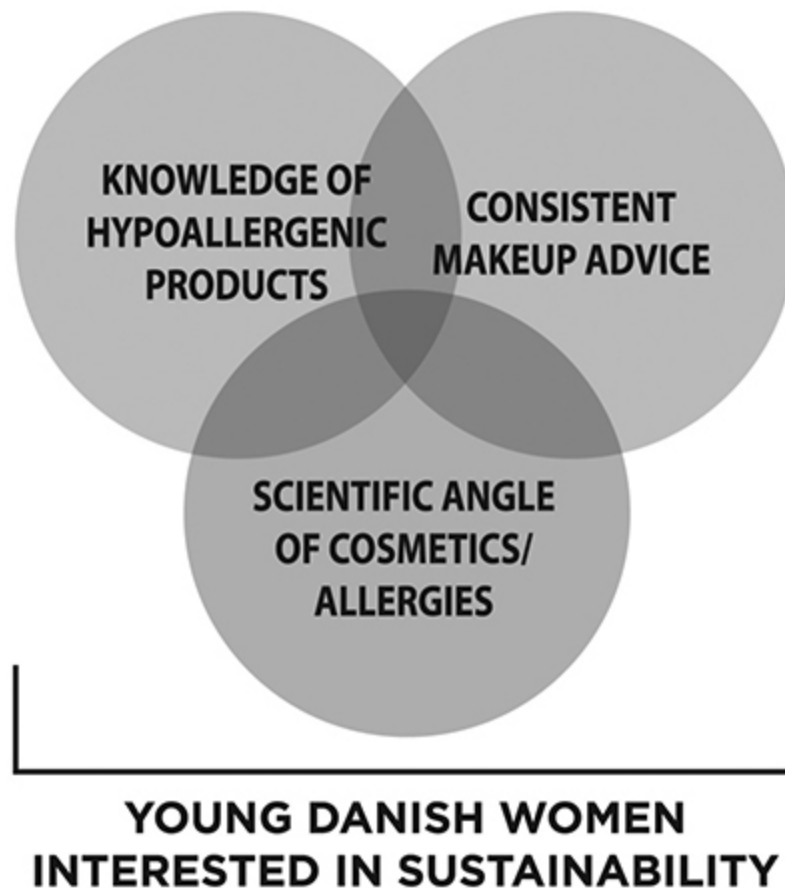


Figure 5.2 Miild’s content tilt was the focus on the scientific angle of cosmetics and allergies.

WHAT IF YOUR CONTENT WERE GONE?

Let’s say someone rounded up all your content and placed it in a box, shut away as if it never existed. *Would anyone miss it? Would you leave a gap in the marketplace?*

If the answer to this is no, *then we’ve got a problem, Houston.*

We want customers and prospects not just needing *but longing for* our content. It becomes part of their lives, their jobs.

Today it’s harder and harder to buy attention. You have to earn it. Earn it today, tomorrow, and five years from now by delivering the most impactful information your customers could ever ask for. Set the uncomfortable goals that will take your business to the next level.

Look at the goals you set in [Chapter 1](#). If you are completely comfortable with them, you are settling for good enough. But good enough won't win the battle for customer attention. *Be great!*

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CHAPTER 6

HOW TO FIND AND TEST THE TILT

I think being different, going against the grain of society, is the greatest thing in the world.

ELIJAH WOOD

Sometimes content tilts are hard to find. If that's your situation, this chapter is all about identifying one and testing to see what works.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

To succeed with *Content Inc.*, you need to create a platform that is the leading informational or entertainment resource around your content niche. This is not easy to do. Many entrepreneurs have ideas about what they want to create content around; they just don't go that extra mile to clearly differentiate themselves.

This chapter will help you do that. Here are a number of strategies and tactics you can leverage to help identify your content tilt.

USE THE AMAZON.COM PRESS RELEASE METHOD

Ian McAllister, former general manager for AmazonSmile, Amazon's charitable arm, says that before a new product is presented for development at Amazon, Jeff Bezos, Amazon's CEO, requires that the company write a press release as if the product were fully built and ready to launch.

"Iterating on a press release is a lot less expensive than iterating on the product itself (and quicker!)," says McAllister.

This type of approach is critical for visualizing our *Content Inc.* strategy and identifying what makes us stand out. It is our differentiating factor.

Amanda MacArthur, managing editor for *Mequoda Daily*, details the critical parts of the Amazon press release method. This is how to find your content tilt:

- **Heading**—Name the content area in a way the reader will understand.
- **Subheading**—Describe who the market for the content is and what benefit they get.
- **Summary**—Give a summary of the content and the benefit.
- **Problem**—Describe the problem your content solves.
- **Solution**—Describe how your content elegantly solves the problem.
- **Quote from You**—A quote from a spokesperson in your company.
- **How to Get Started**—Describe how easy it is to get started.
- **Customer Quote**—Provide a quote from a hypothetical customer that describes how they experienced the benefit.
- **Closing and Call to Action**—Wrap it up and point readers toward their next destination.

According to Fast Company, "The point is to help [Amazon employees] refine their ideas and distill their goals with the customer in mind."

It can do the same for you and your *Content Inc.* strategy.

LEVERAGE GOOGLE TRENDS

Google Trends is a free tool that shows search results and keyword patterns worldwide or in specific regions. For example, if you type "kitchen blender" into Google Trends, you'll see that the searches peak every

December in every year, right around the holiday gift-giving season (Figure 6.1).

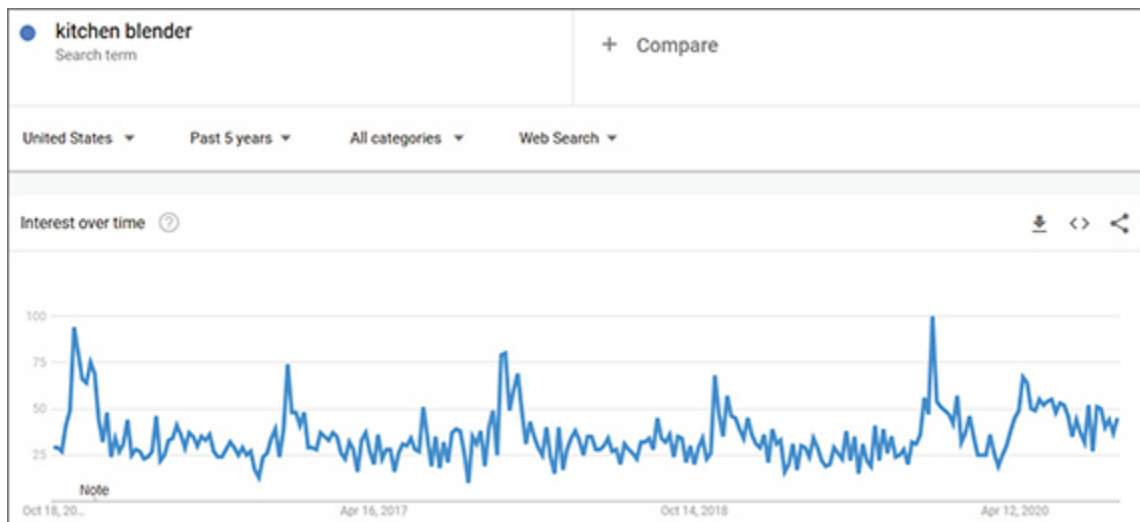


Figure 6.1 Google searches for “kitchen blender” pop every holiday season.

Using Google Trends, you can uncover breakout terms for which there are few instructional resources. This quote from *New York Times* bestselling author Jay Baer is an example:

It’s like, “Hey, I like knitting, and I’m going to start a knitting blog.” Really! There are 27 other knitting blogs. Why would anybody read yours? What is different? What is unique? What is interesting? Why would anyone stop reading the knitting blog that they’ve been reading for the last three years and read yours ever? And if you can’t articulate that, you need to go back to the drawing board. And most people I find, who haven’t been doing this for a while, just don’t go through that competitive calculus, and it’s dangerous.

From the subject-matter standpoint, knitting is too broad. Are there certain types of knitting that are underserved, where you could be the world’s leading content provider?

Here’s where Google Trends earns its stripes. If we do a Trends search for knitting, we find that overall searches (Figure 6.2) are actually down for that term (not a good sign).

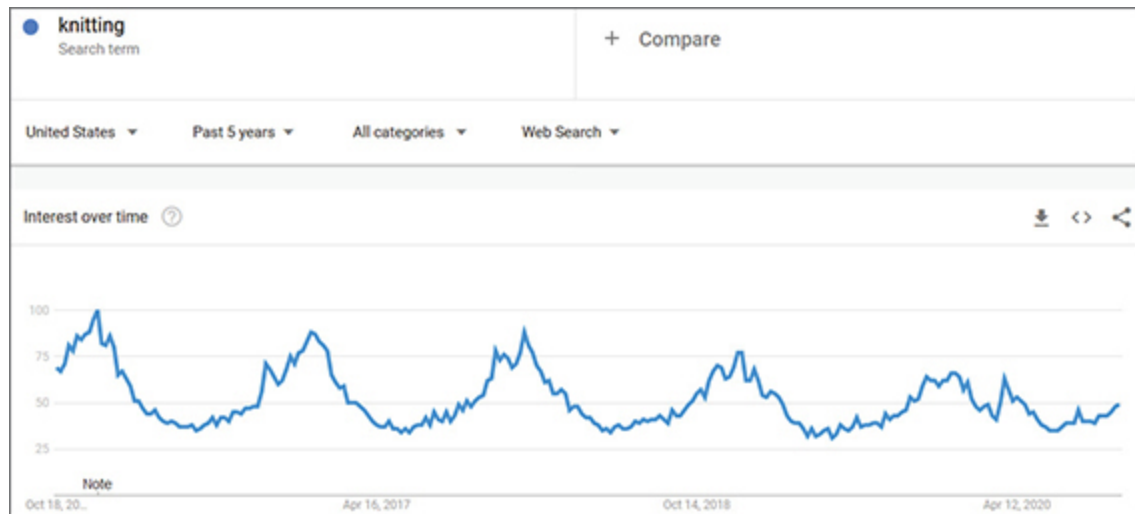


Figure 6.2 Knitting has been trending down over the past five years. Not good for general knitting content sites.

But if we dig a bit deeper, we'll find gold. Moving down the page, as [Figure 6.3](#) shows, you see sections called "Interest by subregion" and "Related queries." Here's where we find our tilt. Under the "Related queries" area, we find that information around "magic knot knitting" is up 70 percent in searches. If we look under the "Interest by subregion" area, knitting seems to be hot in the New England area.

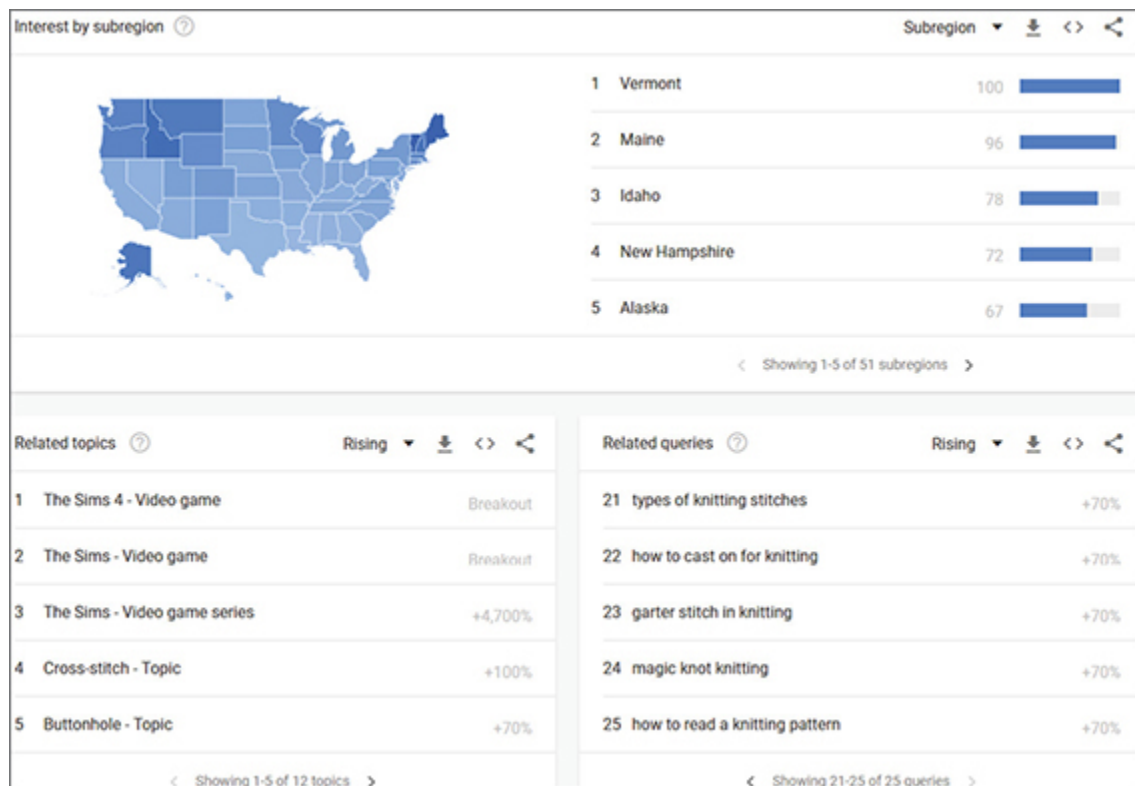


Figure 6.3 Magic knot knitting searches are up 70 percent, and Vermont and Maine are locations showing increased interest in knitting.

If we go back to Jay’s example, instead of just focusing on knitting in general, the data might be telling us to focus on *innovative methods for using magic knot knitting (targeting consumers in the New England area)*.

OR . . . ASK A QUESTION GOOGLE CANNOT ANSWER

Drew Davis loves Google Trends and discusses it in his keynote speeches around the world. That said, he believes the best way to find your content tilt is to start with a question Google cannot answer. “The world is full of experts,” Drew says. “To separate yourself from the pack you need to go from expert to visionary, and that means challenging conventional thinking. How do we do that? Ask a question Google cannot answer.”

Drew uses Jenny Doan, the Queen of Quick Quilting, as an example (more in [Chapter 13](#) on Jenny). All the experts told Jenny that sewing a

quilt would take nine months. Jenny simply asked, “Why does it take nine months to sew a quilt?” She then launched a YouTube show that taught people how to sew a quilt in a day. She releases an episode every Thursday, and more than half of her YouTube subscribers watch every show almost immediately after it publishes.

If you are answering how-to questions that don’t challenge conventional thinking, it will be difficult to find and develop a true content tilt.

LEVERAGE UDEMY

Brendon Lemon is a stand-up comedian who desperately needed a consistent, passive revenue stream. He decided to launch multiple courses on the learning platform Udemy, including “How to Start Doing Stand Up Comedy” and “How to Do Sales-Development Like a Comedian.” Brendon now has six courses that provide him not only a revenue stream, but one that continues to grow. By the way, Brendon spent no money on the creation of each course (just time).

Part of Brendon’s success came from finding a free search tool on [Udemy.com](https://www.udemy.com) that tells you what courses students are looking for that don’t have either (1) many courses under that search or (2) quality courses under that search. The good news? You don’t have to produce a Udemy course to use the free search tool.

ASK YOUR POTENTIAL READERS

This is such low-hanging fruit that I almost didn’t include it as a strategy. Asking your customers or potential readers seems like such a simple thing to do, but sadly it’s rarely done.

I recently conducted a workshop for one of the largest manufacturing companies in the world. When I came to the section about creating a specific content mission, we asked senior marketers if they ever surveyed or talked to their customers to identify content gaps or opportunities to tell different but needed stories. Unfortunately, each one of them said that the marketing team hadn’t been employing any surveys or asking their audience what their pain points, needs, or wants were in any way.

Here is an opportunity to take advantage of what large enterprises don't do well—talk to your readers. Ask potential readers (who could be your friends or family) face-to-face or send out a survey (using a tool like Google Forms) via email. Either or both ways should be part of your regular strategy. This is especially critical in the beginning stages, as you are discovering your niche.

While working on a project, I needed some data points on the needs of content marketing professionals. I used a one-question survey (with free Google Forms) and shot it out on social media. Within 24 hours, I received more than 200 responses, which included some amazing qualitative feedback that I never expected ([Figure 6.4](#)).

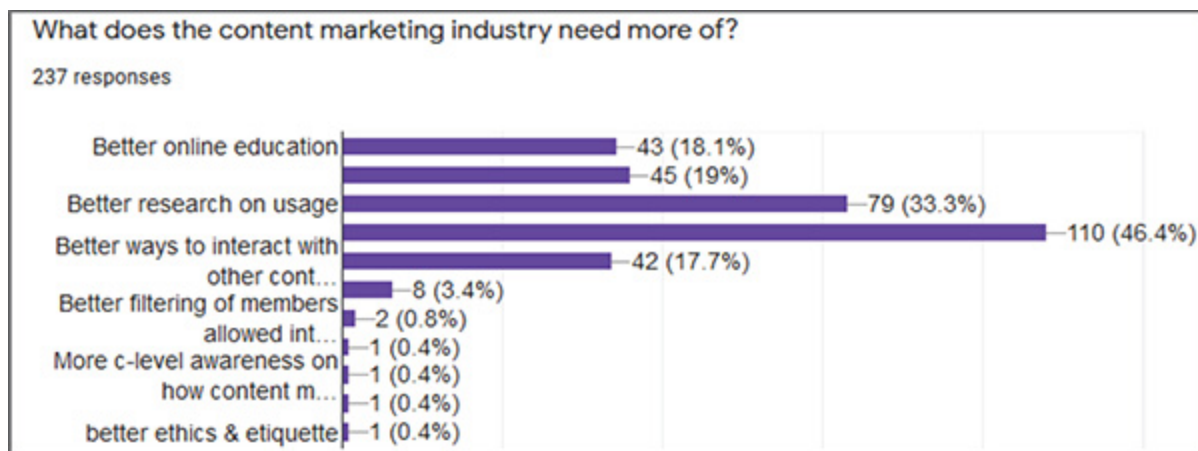


Figure 6.4 A simple one-question Google Forms questionnaire netted more than 200 results in one day.

Another strategy is to ask questions in your emails. In just about every one of my email newsletters, I include a question. Readers can just reply directly back in the email. One September e-newsletter netted more than 100 responses. Invaluable!

SETTING UP LISTENING POSTS

I started in the publishing industry in February 2000. I learned what great storytelling was all about from my mentor, Jim McDermott. Jim constantly talked about the importance of “listening posts.” Listening posts are all about getting as much feedback from a variety of sources as possible, so you can find the truth.

Setting up listening posts is critical for all editors, journalists, reporters, and storytellers to make sure they truly know what is going on in the industry. For you, listening posts are critical so that you can identify your content tilt and make sure it's an opportunity for you to differentiate yourself. All of us need listening posts to truly discover our customers' needs. The following are all means of getting feedback from customers—in effect, they function as listening posts.

1. **One-on-one conversations.** Adele Revella, one of the leading thinkers around audience personas, believes that nothing can replace talking to your audience directly.
2. **Keyword search.** Using tools such as Google Trends, YouTube search, Udemy, and search engine keyword alerts will allow you to track what customers are searching for and where they are hanging out on the web.
3. **Web analytics.** Dive into your web analytics. Finding out what content your readers are engaging in (and what they aren't) can make all the difference to your success.
4. **Social media listening.** Whether through LinkedIn groups, Facebook groups, or Twitter hashtags and keywords, you can easily find out what your customers are sharing, talking about, and struggling with in their lives and jobs.
5. **Customer surveys.** Survey tools like Google Forms (free) can easily gather key insights into your customers' informational needs.

TEST DIFFERENT TILTS

Jay Acunzo from Marketing Showrunners employs a testing strategy every time he's considering a new content area. He recently took small subsets of his database and sent out test content to different groups. For each one, he measured the open rate, the click-through, the on-site engagement, and the unsubscribe rate. He did this for six weeks, and at the end of the process, he identified a clear and overwhelming winner in a content subcategory.

Matthew Patrick, founder of the YouTube show *Game Theory*, discovered his niche through testing as well. According to Matthew, “I really started to approach the platform in a very experimental way. I would do A/B tests; I would run very small experiments with descriptions. And over time I was able to really get a sense of how users engage with this platform, but also how YouTube and their algorithms work to sort videos and spread them across the system.”

Once the data told Matthew what made a hit and what didn’t, he built his model around that, which skyrocketed his *Content Inc.* model to success.

REPOSITION THE CONTENT AREA

I launched the content marketing revolution blog (what ultimately became Content Marketing Institute) in April 2007. Even though I had used the term “content marketing” on and off for the previous six years, it was still new marketing terminology.

The dominant industry term at the time was “custom publishing.” From conversations with senior marketing practitioners, I could tell that that term was not something that resonated with them. But was there an opportunity for “content marketing”? Could changing the industry terminology be our content tilt?

I tinkered with the Google Trends tool and looked at a number of phrase variations. Here is what I found as it related to the dominant industry term (“custom publishing”) and an emerging term (“content marketing”):

- **Custom publishing.** If this were a stock for purchase, we at CMI definitely wouldn’t want to own it. Every year people searched for this term less often. In addition, many of the articles referred, not to our idea of brands creating content, but to customized print books. This confusion was a problem.
- **Content marketing.** The term didn’t even register on Google Trends. I began to think that if we created enough of the right content, we could start a movement around the term. With confusion around other terms, such as “branded content” and “custom content,” the industry likely needed a new term around which to rally key thought leaders. In addition, without a clear leader in the “content marketing” group,

CMI could move quickly and gain search market share. As you can see in [Figure 6.5](#), this strategy paid off. A combination of talking to our audience and using free tools such as Google Trends helped CMI define its content niche and tilt around this name change.

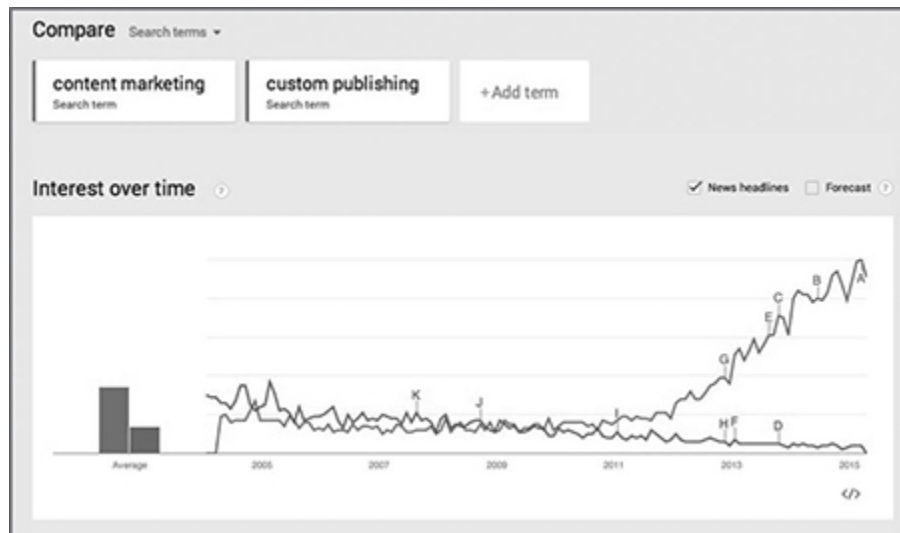


Figure 6.5 “Content marketing” took over as the industry term from “custom publishing.”

HubSpot, the marketing automation enterprise, employed the same strategy with the term “inbound marketing.” In 2006, HubSpot launched a blog around the concept and developed a book (called *Inbound Marketing*), a video series, and an event called Inbound. The community gathered around this term and helped thrust HubSpot into a leadership position. HubSpot is currently valued at more than \$13 billion.

TILTING EXAMPLES

AUDIENCE FOCUS

Are you really niche enough with your audience? “Pet owners” is too broad a target audience. What about “homeowners who like to travel with a dog in their recreational vehicle and live in southwest Florida”? To be truly relevant with your story, you need to focus on a very specific reader. As

Stephen King says in his book *On Writing*, you should think about this person every time you create content.

When I wrote my novel, *The Will to Die*, my audience was my wife, Pam. Every time I sat down to write, I thought about what type of content she would find engaging. If you can write to a specific customer, all the better.

Bestselling author Ann Handley followed this advice with her newsletter *Total Annarchy*. Ann says: “As much as I say that I address all marketers, who I speak to is, at any given time, one specific marketer. When I’m writing a newsletter, I always think about one marketer at a time or one person, one conversation that I had. And I’m writing that newsletter specifically to that person.”

In less than three years, Ann has built her email newsletter audience to more than 45,000 readers with an open rate that’s higher than 40 percent.

My *This Old Marketing* podcast cohost Robert Rose says an audience content tilt “can be very specific on the topic but created for a general audience, or you can cover a general topic but for a very specific audience. You can be narrowly applicable to a broad audience or broadly applicable to a narrow audience.”

Jay Acunzo believes this a great place to start: “Eventually, you want to ‘niche down’ on both things: a very specific topic and a very specific audience. As you plan, however, pick one and make that your focus, refining the other as you create, learn, and iterate.”

PLATFORM TILTING

Last year I gave a content workshop to a group of heating and air-conditioning contractors. In it I learned that everyone was blogging about energy efficiency, but no one was creating and distributing a podcast about the topic.

Being first on a platform can work as a powerful content tilt, even if the content niche isn’t new or targeted. Having the first in-person event in your industry (as we did with Content Marketing World) or the first Twitch livestream (as Twitch streamer Reckful did with the game World of Warcraft) can make an impact.

RECOMBINATION

Adam Alter is a two-time *New York Times* bestselling author, as well as associate professor of marketing at New York University's Stern School of Business.

In a Scott Galloway *Prof G* podcast, Alter discussed the concept of recombination. The idea is that finding originality today is nearly impossible. In his research with musicians and other artists, Alter states that all the building blocks around creating art have already been developed. Today's creator must recombine already developed elements into something new.

When rock music was first created, was it new?

In the late 1940s, country music and blues were extremely popular. Add electric guitars and a steady drumbeat, and presto, rock and roll!

Recombination takes two successful, independent concepts and combines them to create something new. That can be your content tilt.

For instance, take one knowledge area (collectibles) and mash it up with another area (cryptocurrency). This happened recently in the cryptocurrency nonfungible token space.

Another example is Rob LeLacheur's podcast, *Top Cheddar*, which mashes up two different skill sets. LeLacheur interviews former successful hockey players who, after hockey, also created successful businesses. For those interested in hockey and growing a business, this podcast is a goldmine.

PERSONAL TILTING

Joe Rogan has a daily podcast, just like a million other people. Joe's unfiltered commentary, flawless memory, and humorous personality stand out.

Malcolm Gladwell covers the same topics as dozens of other people, but Gladwell's persistence in breaking down human behavior is second to none. Also, Gladwell created an audiobook experience for his latest book, *Talking with Strangers*. The audiobook reads more like a soap opera, adding commentary from dozens of experts.

Seth Godin writes marketing books. So do thousands of others. But does anyone else cover a topic with Seth's simplicity? I think not.

CASE STUDY: DAVID PORTNOY

David Portnoy left corporate America in 2003 and founded *Barstool Sports*, a publication devoted to fantasy sports, gambling predictions, sports culture, and gratuitous pictures of models. Portnoy himself described the content as sports smut. For distribution, Dave personally handed out copies to Bostonians around subways and street corners.

Since that modest start, Portnoy executed the *Content Inc.* model to perfection, selling two stakes in *Barstool Sports* (one in 2016 and one in 2020), the latter valued at \$450 million.

But when the pandemic stopped all sports events in mid-March 2020, content for the site was hard to come by.

Enter the stock market. Portnoy began livestreaming his daily stock trading activity to millions of sports fanatics turned day traders. Portnoy regularly chastised big-time investors like Warren Buffett and actively promoted stocks as “bets.” He treated the stock market like gambling. He and his fans see no difference, and they might be right.

Bloomberg and many other media sites gave Portnoy credit for the Robinhood Rally, a nickname for explosive growth in a basket of stocks led by Gen Z and millennial traders via the trading site Robinhood.

A few points worth considering:

- Portnoy actively screams against the establishment, which is perfect for his audience of antiestablishment people in their twenties and thirties.
- He’s raw and unfiltered. He doesn’t care what anyone thinks.
- He produces content every day. He’s always on and consistently there for his audience.
- He is unique, offering different talk and advice than you’d find on other websites. He stands out. Portnoy’s content tilt is the size of Nebraska.

Portnoy creates a specific message for a specific group of people and delivers that messaging consistently. It’s no wonder he’s built an audience of millions in a very short period.

Benu began as an Austrian service that helped consumers find funeral homes. Over time, the company built an impressive opt-in email newsletter with 5,000 subscribers. Readers received information on ways to deal with grief, funeral traditions, and funeral ideas.

The ideas often hit sensitive areas. The solution? Benu consistently checks with small sample groups to see if a specific post crosses the line. Besides a very specific sweet spot, the company's content tilt includes dark humor, which the majority of its audience appreciates.

Benu's approach has become so popular that it now arranges funerals directly, instead of just passing leads to funeral homes.

DO THE WORK

I'm winding down this chapter with an invaluable lesson and quote from Ira Glass, the popular host and producer of *This American Life*. Glass said:

Put yourself on a deadline so that every week you will finish one story. It is only by going through a volume of work that you will close that gap, and your work will be as good as your ambitions. And I took longer to figure out how to do this than anyone I've ever met. It's gonna take a while. It's normal to take a while. You've just gotta fight your way through.

To find your content tilt, you simply have to get started, do the work, and discover the opportunities. Jeff Bullas, the most popular social media strategist in Australia, started his content platform by writing about celebrity news. His first post was about Jennifer Aniston. After months of creating content, Jeff found his groove. Jeff had to do the work to get to the content tilt.

The same thing happened with Jay Baer. Jay initially launched a blog primarily about email marketing. In an interview, he said:

I discovered in about 30 seconds that every time I wrote about email marketing, I got 150 visits to the site, and every time I wrote about social media, I got about 1000 visits to the site. And after that happened

for a while I thought, hum . . . I don't have a degree in statistics, but I see a trend here.

So I said, we're going to write about social media until somebody tells us not to write about that, so I spent all my time writing about that. Then I had done a bunch of social media consulting in the past and said, well, I guess if there's that much demand for this information, then that's going to be the focus of the business, and it was.

Jay would never have discovered this if he hadn't put himself out there, creating content. It's completely acceptable to take your best shot (like Jay did) at a content tilt and start developing your platform. Maybe then you will find the *Content Inc.* niche that will drive your success.

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CHAPTER 7

FINALIZING THE CONTENT MISSION

Everything under the sun has been said. You have to find a new way to say it.

HENRY WINKLER

Time to formalize the process. Let's take that sweet spot and content tilt and construct our content mission statement.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Besides the underlying business model (how the money comes in), there is one thing that media companies do in their content planning that nonmedia companies do not. And that's to formulate an editorial mission statement.

Media companies start their strategies by developing an editorial mission statement that guides their content creation efforts and serves as a beacon for the overall business. I've launched more than 50 media products in my career, from magazines to newsletters, websites to webinar programs. In every one of those launches, I spent the first few days creating and fine-tuning the editorial mission. It is the first step in establishing a successful strategy.

Most businesses today have an opportunity to be publishers. The smart ones follow the basic strategies that media companies have used for years to successfully build their audiences.

YOUR CONTENT MISSION

A mission statement is a company's reason for existence. It's why the organization does what it does. For example, Patagonia's mission is to build the best products, cause no unnecessary harm, and use business to inspire and implement solutions to the environmental crisis. Tesla's is to accelerate the world's transition to sustainable energy. TED's is to spread ideas.

For a *Content Inc.* model, the content mission statement is your reason for existence. It's your why.

I cover the content mission statement in most of my keynote presentations. It's critical to first set the tone for building audiences and then generating revenue from (or because of) those audiences. Marketing professionals, with both small and large businesses, get so fixated on channels—blogs, Facebook, TikTok—that they have no clue why they should use a channel in the first place. The why must come before the what.

Your content tilt must be expressed in a way that lets you communicate with your audience. It's a bold statement when you put your flag in the ground and tell your audience why you exist.

There are three parts to the content mission statement:

- Who is your specific target audience?
- What will you deliver to your audience?
- What's in it for the audience?

Andy Crestodina from Orbit Media calls this the XYZ method: “Our company is where [audience X] finds [content Y] for [benefit Z].”

My favorite mission statement from a traditional media company is from *Inc.* magazine:

Welcome to [Inc.com](https://www.inc.com), the place where entrepreneurs and business owners can find useful information, advice, insights, resources and inspiration for running and growing their businesses.

Inc.'s mission statement includes:

- The specific target audience: “entrepreneurs and business owners”
- The material that *Inc.* will deliver to the audience: “useful information, advice, insights, resources and inspiration”
- The outcome/benefit for the audience: “running and growing their businesses”

Inc.'s mission statement is incredibly simple and includes no easily misunderstood words. Simplicity is key for your content marketing mission statement.

Note that nowhere in its mission statement does *Inc.* talk about how it makes money from its audience. That's where most companies go wrong with their content creation: they talk about what they will sell.

Inc. editor in chief Scott Omelianuk believes keeping *Inc.*'s purpose focused on its audience is the key: “We're talking about everyday survival and how to practice that in less academic or larger-picture perspectives. We're talking to people who are telling us they have been subscribing to *Inc.* for 40 years and it's never been more important to them. It's the difference between day-to-day survival versus long-term survival, and I think we're very much in the trenches with entrepreneurs.”

The content mission is all about the audience, and about getting your team focused on something bigger than just making money (which is important, but always secondary). *You can't make money off your audience until it is actually your audience.*

CASE STUDY: DIGITAL PHOTOGRAPHY SCHOOL

Darren Rowse built two amazingly successful *Content Inc.* models. The first one, *ProBlogger*, focuses on small business blogging. The second, Digital Photography School, is one of the leading sources for beginning photographers on how to get the most from their picture-taking skills.

But it didn't start out that way. He explains:

Previous to *ProBlogger*, I started a camera review blog that was my first commercial sort of blog and that had gotten to the point where it was full time, but it wasn't a very satisfying blog to write. My readers would come for one day to research a certain camera and then disappear and never come back. So I always had this dissatisfaction with it that I wasn't actually building a community. I think that's what really feeds me, having ongoing readers. I always wanted a blog that was a bit more about helping people in a long-term way.

After this initial experiment didn't quite work, Darren came back to photography blogging but changed his content tilt. Darren's "aha!" moment came with his focus on one particular audience.

"I guess one of the doubts I had along the way was around focus," says Darren. He recalls:

Very much early on it was about beginners, so it was very basic content and I had some doubts about whether I should start expanding into more intermediate-level content, but I kind of stuck to that beginner stuff for the first two years and really built the audience there until my audience began to grow into the next level of content. So I didn't expand the expertise too early, which was good in hindsight.

That decision paid off. Darren saw his total email and social audience grow to substantially more than a million subscribers.

Let's take a look at Digital Photography School's initial content mission:

Welcome to Digital Photography School—a website with simple tips to help digital camera owners get the most out of their cameras.

Let's dissect the mission statement:

- The specific target audience: "digital camera owners"
- The material that will be delivered to the audience: "simple [how-to] tips"
- The benefit for the audience: "help digital camera owners get the most out of their cameras"

Darren expands on his mission:

This “school” is not a formal one by any means. There are no classes, no teachers, no exams—rather, it’s a learning environment where I think out loud about what I know and where in our forum we share what we’re learning by showing our photos and ask and answer each other’s questions. Also, unlike most schools, the information here is free.

Since then, the site has grown to include a team around the world writing tips for a community of more than 2 million.

It’s no wonder that beginning and intermediate photographers regularly engage with Darren’s site. Darren’s content tilt is his insight and ability to turn his focus on a beginner audience with helpful, consistent tips that his readers can use immediately. Long gone are Darren’s days of reviewing cameras.

CASE STUDY: SECTIONHIKER.COM

Philip Werner was a product manager in a Boston-based software startup for more than 20 years. His expertise was open-source software, and his boss asked him to investigate building a website on top of the popular blogging software WordPress. It was that blogging capability that ultimately launched [SectionHiker.com](https://sectionhiker.com). Philip explains: “I was just getting back into backpacking after a couple of decades of not doing it. I was hiking the Long Trail in Vermont and decided to blog about it.”

Philip took his 20 years of marketing and product management experience and combined it with his hiking and backpacking experiences to start the blog. After a short period, he was blogging five days a week.

Philip’s audience began as mainly ultralight backpackers, a very small segment of the market. (It always helps to start small and narrow with your audience.) As he became more successful and people began to find his blog, Philip decided to modify the audience and focus the content: “I decided to focus on not just my experience, but more on educational content for people getting into hiking and backpacking. I also have a large regional draw because I hike primarily in New Hampshire, so there’s a whole New England thing.”

Philip's decision to alter the audience worked. In 2018, 2019, and 2020, [AdventureJunkies.com](#) ranked [SectionHiker.com](#) as the top hiking and backpacking blog on the internet.

Philip's content mission statement was core to his success. It looks something like this:

[SectionHiker.com](#)—a website that delivers detailed, how-to information [the content] to beginner hikers and backpackers in and around the New England area [the audience] for consistent, safe and enjoyable hiking experiences [the benefit].

WANTS, NOT NEEDS

More and more, I find that the best *Content Inc.* programs revolve around aspirations more than needs. I've been guilty of telling marketers to "focus on customer pain points" since, well, forever. Focusing on pain points is excellent, but it only gets you to the front door.

To get to the heart of your customers' aspirations, you have to focus on what they want to be and help them get where they really want to go.

WHAT'S IN A NAME?

In 2008, I sat in an American Business Media executive meeting and listened to Peter Hoyt speak. Peter is CEO of Hoyt Publishing, a family-owned media company. Hoyt said that the name Hoyt Publishing limited company opportunities, so the firm changed its name to the In-Store Marketing Institute (renamed later as Point-of-Purchase Institute).

When it made that change, Hoyt's revenues skyrocketed. "The institute really caught on and developed into something much bigger than I thought it would be," Hoyt said. "It has provided millions of dollars in new revenue and profit. Our net operating profit went from 7% to 19% in two years, and we keep reinvesting that yield to further serve the industry."

Hoyt's experiences were a direct reason that I changed our name to Content Marketing Institute. It's not a sexy name by any means, but the

change positioned us as immediate experts. We also didn't have to spend time telling people what we do—they immediately knew.

The moral of the story? Sometimes a boring name that says exactly what you do is better than a brand that you have explain. Digital Photography School and SectionHiker.com follow this model. It works.

Instead of the basics, such as “saving money” and “lowering costs,” let's raise the bar to things like “giving our customers more free time to live the lives they want to” or “being a person that can make a difference in the world.”

Jack Butcher, founder of Visualize Value, has done this with his mission, which is “helping ambitious people master their mental health and build independent income.” A resource for entrepreneurs that focuses on your mental well-being? Now that's a content tilt!

It sounds corny, but it's so critical. To become that one resource that cuts through the clutter, the people in your audience need to believe that your content can *change their lives*.

As Peter Thiel preaches, forget what your so-called competition is creating and distributing to your customers. You are better than that. Instead, create the content that your customers want to engage with over everything else. It's that kind of aspiration that will give you the vision to put a plan and team together that will truly make a difference.

In the kitchen of our house, there is a mission statement on the wall. I refer to it often. So do my two boys, now ages 17 and 19.

The mission statement is our family purpose. It's what we strive to be today and in the future. I believe that mission statement has been crucial to our family's success and happiness.

Here is what it says:

The Pulizzi Mission

As Pulizzis, we hold true the following with ongoing purpose and action:

We thank God every day for our blessings, even on days when we are challenged or face hardships.

We always share what we have with others, and help out whenever we can to whoever is in need.

We praise each other, as we are each blessed by God with unique talents.

We always finish what we start, always try even though we may be afraid, and always give the activity of the moment our full attention.

Short version:

Thank God. Always Share. Say Nice Things. Give Our Best.

When the kids have questions about what they should and shouldn't do, my wife and I refer to the mission statement. The best part? When visitors come into our house, they notice and almost always comment on our mission statement. It's one of those little things that make a difference.

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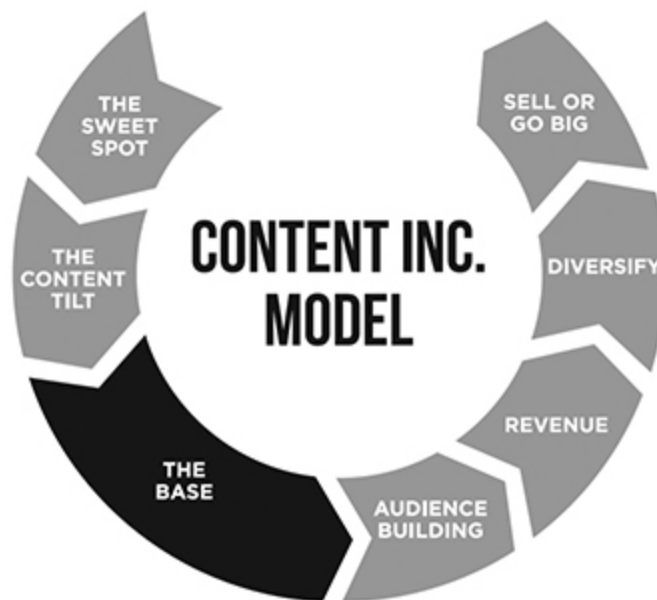
PART 4

THE BASE

It is not the beauty of a building you should look at; it's the construction of the foundation that will stand the test of time.

DAVID ALLAN COE

You've found your sweet spot and identified your content tilt. Now it's time to do the work.



CHAPTER 8

DO ONE THING . . . GREAT

It is those who concentrate on but one thing at a time who advance in this world.

GARY KELLER

The greatest media brands of all time began their journey by leveraging one main platform. This is where all *Content Inc.* models start.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

When the McDonald brothers opened McDonald's restaurant in 1940, they sold everything from barbeque to orange juice. For seven years, the brothers struggled to find long-term success.

In 1948, they analyzed the data and found that 87 percent of their sales (and the majority of their profits) came from hamburgers, french fries, and soft drinks. So they closed for three months, remodeled the kitchen, and reopened with a new, simplified menu.

Business boomed, and the brothers franchised the concept in 1953. Today McDonald's has 40,000 stores in 100 countries and is valued at more than \$150 billion.

If you've completed the work to this point, congratulations. Believe it or not, the strategy behind the *Content Inc.* model is the hardest part. Anyone, anywhere, with almost no resources can create a blog, a podcast, a YouTube

series, a TikTok channel, but it takes research and planning to build a loyal and trusting audience. That audience is what will ultimately power your entire business model.

WHERE TO START?

As Michael Hyatt said in his book and blog, both titled *Platform*, your ideas and stories need a place to live if you are going to succeed. According to Michael, “Without a platform—something that enables you to get seen and heard—you *don’t have a chance*. Having an awesome product, an outstanding service, or a compelling cause is no longer enough.”

The greatest media entities of all time selected one primary channel in which to build their platform:

- *Financial Times*—printed newspaper
- *Fortune*—printed magazine
- TED Talks—in-person events
- ESPN—cable television programming
- *Huffington Post*—online magazine format
- *The Joe Rogan Experience*—podcast show
- *PewDiePie*—YouTube series

As did every one of these examples, you have two choices to make when building your platform: how and where?

- How will you tell your stories? What is your core content type?
- Where will you tell your stories? What channel will you choose to distribute your content?

By mixing this with our content mission, every *Content Inc.* example has four key attributes ([Figure 8.1](#)):



Figure 8.1 A successful base equals one target audience, a strong content tilt, one type of content, and one chosen platform.

1. One key target audience
2. One mission (content tilt)
3. One primary content type (audio, video, textual/image)
4. One core platform (blog/website, YouTube, Instagram, etc.)

Most businesses begin their content creation journey and start slapping content everywhere in every possible format. They create Facebook posts and blogs and podcasts and videos and hope something resonates. This rarely works.

Ann Reardon from *How to Cook That* decided to create consistent videos and distribute them on YouTube.

Philip Werner from [SectionHiker.com](https://www.sectionhiker.com) creates and delivers a text-plus-images blog post every day on his WordPress-developed website.

Wally Koval from *Accidentally Wes Anderson* distributes one image per day on Instagram.

Comedian Jim Carrey talks about the importance of doing one thing consistently over time as “filing down the sharp edges.” When you start, you won’t have the concept exactly right. Practice over time makes you aware of the “sharp edges” that won’t work, so you can ultimately create a truly valuable content asset.

MASTER OF NONE

I have seen the following over the past year:

- A small business, just one month into its new podcast, decided to launch a video series.

- A technology startup that believed it needed to be active on Twitter, LinkedIn, Facebook, Snapchat, and TikTok, spreading its resources across each and making absolutely zero impact.
- An email marketing company launching a “network” of 15 short films, documentaries, and audio shows, all at the same time.

We always want more. We believe more is better. When launching a new content effort, “jack of all trades, master of none” never, ever works. How did Amazon become the most valuable company in the world? For three years the company sold only books. Once they perfected that model, only then did they begin selling other things. The *Content Inc.* model behaves the same way.

Content Inc. initiatives work because they start their journey with one amazing e-newsletter, one amazing video series, one amazing in-person event, or one amazing blog rather than 100 randomized content pieces that don’t inspire any kind of behavior change.

There is something about focus. There is something about being truly remarkable at one thing. The problem is that it requires you to choose. It requires you to stop doing all the little things and focus on what’s really important, what will really move the needle.

CASE STUDY: *THE JOE ROGAN EXPERIENCE*

Following in the footsteps of Howard Stern and his move from terrestrial radio to SiriusXM, comedian, actor, and *Fear Factor* host Joe Rogan agreed to an exclusive deal with Spotify to the tune of \$100 million in 2020.

Joe Rogan began producing his podcast, *The Joe Rogan Experience*, in 2009. It was early days for podcasting in 2009, and the podcast initially launched on Ustream.tv. Rogan says, “We started just doing a show in front of a laptop, taking questions from people on Twitter.”

Rogan finally found a home on iTunes (now Apple podcasts) and delivered an episode a week, which later evolved into twice per week. By 2011, Rogan’s podcast was one of the most popular podcasts in the world.

Once Rogan secured a loyal audience, he began to diversify, first signing a deal for SiriusXM to license the show, and then in 2013 distributing the show via YouTube. To date, *The Joe Rogan Experience* has produced more

than 1,500 episodes and garnered substantially more than 200 million downloads per month.

The key to Rogan's success? He started with one content type (audio) on primarily one channel (Ustream, then iTunes). Once successful, he diversified his offerings and is now one of the most affluent *Content Inc.* examples of all time.

THE KEY SIX PRINCIPLES

Every *Content Inc.* example outlined in this book follows these key principles, as does any credible global media company:

1. Fill a need/want. Your content should answer some unmet desire or question for your audience.
2. Be consistent. Consistency is the great hallmark of a successful publisher. Whether you publish an Instagram channel or daily email newsletter, the content needs to be delivered on time and as expected. This is where so many *Content Inc.* strategies fall down.
3. Be human. Find your voice and share it. If your company's story is all about humor, share that. If it's a bit sarcastic, that's okay too.
4. Have a point of view. This is not encyclopedia content. You are not giving a history report. Don't be afraid to take sides on matters that can position you and your company as an expert. One of the reasons Marcus Sheridan and his company River Pools & Spas have been successful is the emotion and bluntness Marcus and team relay in their content. People appreciate that.
5. Avoid "sales speak." Sometimes there are business reasons to do this, but the more you talk about yourself, the less people will pay attention or value your content.
6. Be best of breed. Although you might not be able to reach it at the very beginning, the goal for your content ultimately is to be best of breed. This means that, for your content niche, what you are distributing is the very best of what is found and is available. If you expect your readers to spend time with your content, you must deliver them amazing value.

In all our *Content Inc.* case studies, these six elements are present. Be sure they are on your mind throughout your process of building your *Content Inc.* model.

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CHAPTER 9

SELECTING YOUR PLATFORM

Subscription companies are growing nine times faster than the S&P 500. Why? Because unlike product companies, subscription companies know their customers. A happy subscriber base is the ultimate economic moat.

TIEN TZUO, AUTHOR OF *SUBSCRIBED*

Don't be tempted to launch into many platforms at once. The key is to stay focused and refine your expertise in one platform before diversifying.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

CONTENT TYPES

According to Content Marketing Institute/Marketing Profs research, the most popular content types used by businesses are as follows:

- Social media content
- Videos
- Blog posts or articles
- Email newsletters
- In-person events

- Webinars/online events
- White papers/e-books
- Print magazines
- Podcasts

This means that most businesses are creating mountains of just about every kind of content type on all sorts of platforms, sometimes simultaneously. Simply put, we need more focus.

The majority of *Content Inc.* success stories fall into the following content types:

- **Articles, blogs, or content-based websites.** When we launched the Content Marketing Institute, blogs were the main platform for building audience. Our blog posts started at three times per week and now run once per day.
- **E-newsletter programs.** One example, author and speaker Ann Handley's e-newsletter *Total Annarchy*, a bimonthly guide on writing better, has garnered more than 30,000 subscribers in just a few years.
- **Videos.** In most cases, this means a regular YouTube series with a show at least once per week, or possibly a regular Twitch stream.
- **Audio podcasts.** Nathaniel Whittemore delivers a podcast on macroeconomics and bitcoin to fans every evening. His is becoming one of the most popular cryptocurrency podcasts in the industry.
- **Instagram.** Quinn Tempest launched her business, Create Your Purpose, on the back of daily Instagram postings.
- **Facebook.** Mette Løvbom from Denmark created SalatTøsen (The Salad Chick) almost exclusively on Facebook. Over the past five years, she has amassed more than 100,000 fans and launched an impressive line of salad-oriented products.

Companies that use *Content Inc.* strategies diversify their content channels into other properties once they attract large enough audiences. In the beginning, it's important to focus on creating amazing and relevant content with mostly one content channel.

TRIAL AND ERROR

At the beginning of the worldwide pandemic in 2020, marketing author, speaker, and entrepreneur Joseph Jaffe launched *CoronaTV*, a live, interactive show with experts in multiple fields about how they are dealing with a life that isn't normal.

Jaffe purposely launched on multiple platforms at once, including Facebook, LinkedIn, Periscope, and YouTube, to see which one would resonate the most.

When I first launched the *Content Marketing Revolution* blog, I also consistently distributed information on Twitter, LinkedIn, and Facebook. I dabbled a bit with YouTube as well. After a few months, once I started to see some results with the blog, I focused more energy there and used the social media channels as distribution points.

You might not know which platform will be the one when you begin your *Content Inc.* journey. There are many pros and cons to consider.

CHOOSING A PLATFORM

Consider three major questions when making a platform decision:

The first question is personal:

- How do you best tell your story? This means you, the human being, with all your gifts and talents.

In some cases, the best way to tell your story for your particular niche audience might be a podcast or a video series, but maybe you have more of a passion for writing or design.

For my *Content Inc.* platform, I believe the best platform would be a podcast, with regular interviews each week. The problem? I am more passionate about writing, so I focused on building the email newsletter as the main channel. How *you* like to create content matters.

The next two questions are all about reach and control.

- What channel offers you the best opportunity to reach your target audience? (*Reach*)

- What channel gives you the most control over presenting your content and building your audience? (*Control*)

Let's look at the chart in [Figure 9.1](#).

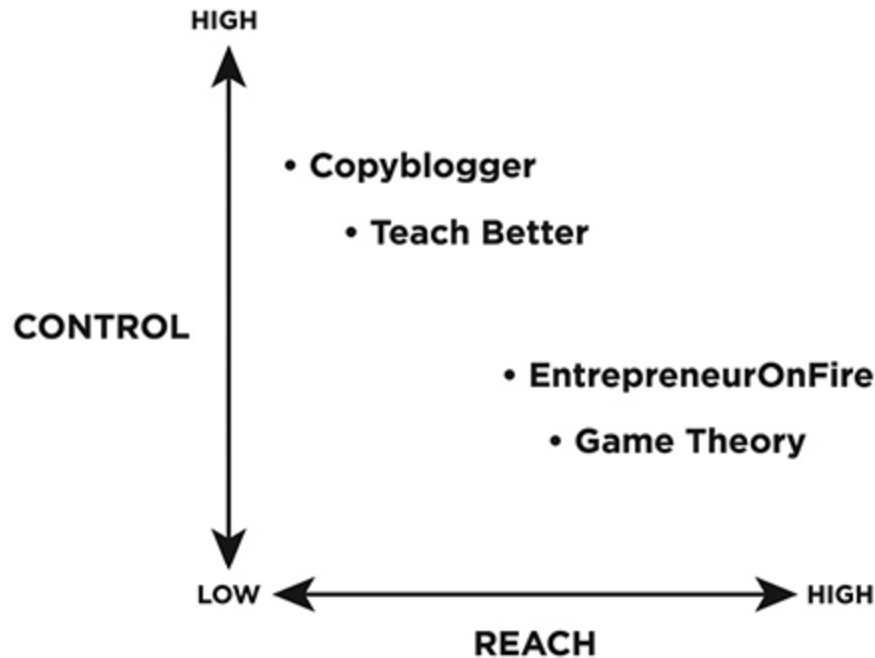


Figure 9.1 Your strategy will differ greatly depending on whether you start with control or reach.

Brian Clark's Copyblogger has almost infinite control over its channel, a WordPress site that it owns. At the same time, Copyblogger needs to build a system to attract people to its content, since its website doesn't reside within another ecosystem that can naturally bring it traffic. The same goes for Teach Better, one of the leading informational sites for teachers. It also launched its platform using WordPress.

On the other hand, *Entrepreneurs On Fire* (EOF, podcast) and *Game Theory* (video) have a greater reach possibility than Copyblogger, since they publish within an environment that has built-in audiences. EOF publishes mostly via Apple Podcasts and Spotify, where millions of people search for new podcasts every day. The same is true for *Game Theory*. Its target audience of gamers is already on YouTube every day. As long as *Game Theory* continues to create compelling content that YouTube will deliver, it should grow an audience there.

The problem with *EOF* and *Game Theory* is that they are leveraging platforms that they have little or no control over. *Game Theory* has more than 13 million subscribers. That's amazing, but technically host and brand owner Matthew Patrick doesn't control those subscriber relationships; YouTube does. YouTube could decide tomorrow that it doesn't want *Game Theory* to have access to those people, or it might decide to publicize other content to Matthew's audience, like *PewDiePie* or *The Joe Rogan Experience*, instead of *Game Theory*.

Consider the example of the duo SMOSH, one of the original YouTube sensations, who built an audience of 25 million subscribers on YouTube. After a few years of regular videos, SMOSH began to redirect the calls to action at the end of their videos, pushing viewers to their own website, [Smosh.com](https://www.smosh.com), where they could sign up people for an email subscription program that they had control over.

If you choose a low-control channel as the main driver of your content distribution, be aware that at some point you'll want to convert the subscribers on that platform to your own subscribers. If you choose a high-control channel, like a website or an in-person event, you'll need to create a more robust plan to drive an audience to those venues.

BEWARE OF SOCIAL CHANNELS

Although social channels, such as TikTok, Clubhouse, Facebook, and LinkedIn, could be great places to build your digital footprint and followers, you ultimately have no control over what those companies do with your connections. Sure, LinkedIn lets your current connections see all the content you publish on LinkedIn, but LinkedIn changes its algorithm constantly. One day you might see thousands of people engage with your post. The next day it could be a few dozen. LinkedIn has every right to do so as a private business, and you, a free member of the LinkedIn community, have very few rights.

Social channels such as Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, Pinterest, Snapchat, TikTok, and Instagram may all be solid possibilities for building a platform, depending on whom you are targeting, but it's important to understand the dangers.

CASE STUDY: TWINSTHENEWTREND

One of the biggest hits of 2020 was Twinsthenewtrend. Just about every day, a set of twin brothers sit and listen to a song they've never heard before, and we get to watch their reactions.

On July 27, the song was "In the Air Tonight" by Phil Collins. I implore you to watch it, especially their reaction at the 4:56 mark.

The song went completely viral, with 4 million views and more than 12,000 comments in just a few weeks.

But as you know, viral happens after delivering valuable content for a long period of time. The twins produced videos on YouTube for more than a year before they went viral. Many of their videos have just a few hundred views. Now the twins have gone internet famous and have amassed almost 700,000 subscribers on YouTube.

THE SAFEST BET

Look at the fastest-growing media companies of today, such as Morning Brew or the Bleacher Report, or more mature new media platforms, such as BuzzFeed. You can even look at a traditional publisher, like the *New York Times*. They are all very good at leveraging social channels and building an audience on those channels, but they *don't* build their main platforms on social channels.

In every case, they build websites, mobile applications, print properties, or event programs (all with subscribers) that they can own, and then leverage other channels to drive people back to the sites they own, so they can convert passersby into an audience they can monetize.

PODCASTING ON A BUDGET

I've been podcasting since 2013. It's hard to believe that includes more than 500 episodes of *This Old Marketing* (with Robert Rose) and the *Content Inc.* podcast.

When I first started, it took about two hours to produce each episode. Today, it takes about 20 minutes. Here are some tips:

1. **Get a great microphone.** This should actually be the first three points. A great microphone can make up for a lot. I use an Audio-Technica AT2020 USB and love it. My *This Old Marketing* cohost Robert Rose owns a Shure SM58, while podcaster Christopher Penn owns an AT2100.
 2. **Record with Audacity.** Audacity is a free recording tool. It's extremely easy to edit and publish. Once you create the file, save it as a .wav file and run it through another free program called Levelator II, which cleans up the sound. If you have an Apple, Garageband can replace Audacity.
 3. **Host with Libsyn.** I'm a longtime customer of Libsyn, a podcast hosting and distribution platform. Robust plans start at \$5 per month. Libsyn will distribute your podcast to Apple Podcasts, Spotify, Overcast, Stitcher, SoundCloud, YouTube, Amazon Music, Google, and more. Other platforms to consider are Buzzsprout, Podcave, Anchor, Podbean, and Captivate.
-

CONTENT TYPE/PLATFORM MATCH

Certain content types and storytelling styles match particular platforms and frequencies. Here are the formulas most used by *Content Inc.* entrepreneurs:

Platform	Content Type	Length	Frequency
Blog	Text + image	500–2,000 words	Weekly or more
E-newsletter	Text + image	500–2,000 words	Bimonthly or more
YouTube	Video	5–15 minutes	Minimum weekly
Podcast	Audio	30–90 minutes	Minimum weekly
Facebook	Text/image/video	Various	Daily
Pinterest	Image	N/A	Daily
Instagram	Image/video	60 seconds or less	Daily
Snapchat	Image/video	60 seconds or less	Daily
TikTok	Video	20 seconds or less	Daily

PLATFORMS IN ACTION

Openview invests in growth-oriented technology companies. Back in 2009, Openview launched a content platform that delivers regular article content to attract subscribers to an e-newsletter offering that now boasts more than 100,000 subscribers (Figure 9.2)—not bad for a venture capital company.

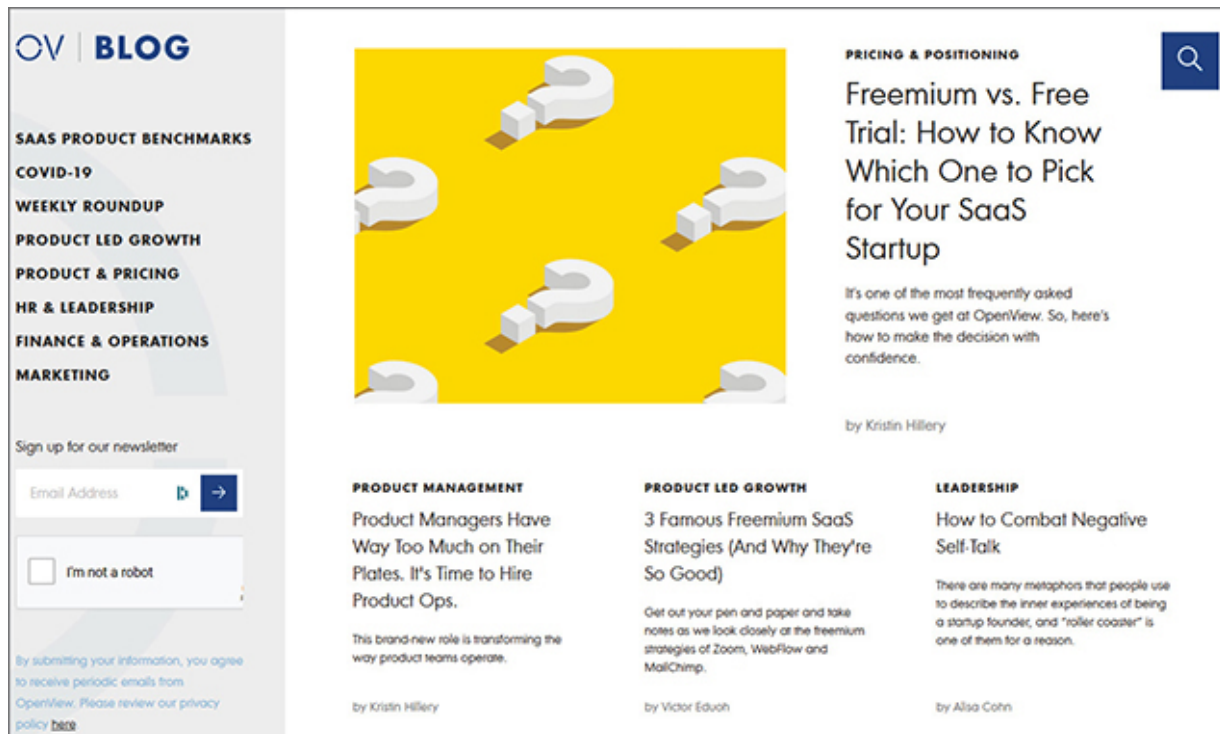


Figure 9.2 It's been 10 years and 100,000 subscribers for Openview's newsletter.

John Deere launched *The Furrow* magazine in 1895 (Figure 9.3). It is still published today in print and digital format in 14 different languages and distributed to 40 countries. *The Furrow* has always focused on how farmers can learn the latest technology to grow their farms and businesses.



March 2020



Feb. 2020



Jan 2020

Figure 9.3 John Deere's *The Furrow* magazine is one of the oldest *Content Inc.* initiatives on the planet.

In the early 2000s, serial entrepreneur Jean-Baptiste Duquesne founded 750g as the leading food-recipe site for French food connoisseurs. Five years after launch, Duquesne expanded to Brazil, the United States, Italy, Spain, and Germany. Today, the community includes more than 4 million followers on Facebook and 400,000 followers on Pinterest, but its main platform is [750g.com](https://www.750g.com).

Hollywood celebrity Gwyneth Paltrow launched her own *Content Inc.* strategy, called Goop. Originally conceived as a weekly e-newsletter of travel recommendations and shopping tips, Goop has evolved into a fully functioning media site with more than 8 million subscribers. It boasts a 40 percent e-newsletter open rate, or about twice the category average.

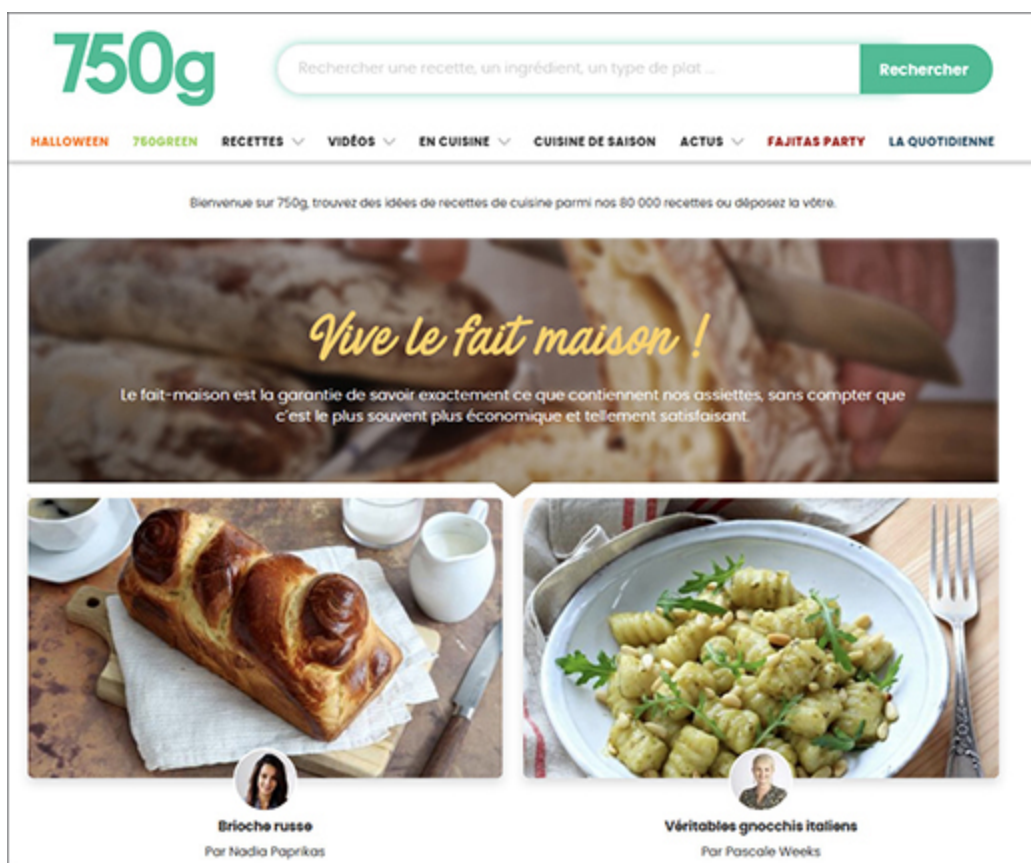


Figure 9.4 750g is the leading food-recipe site for French food connoisseurs.

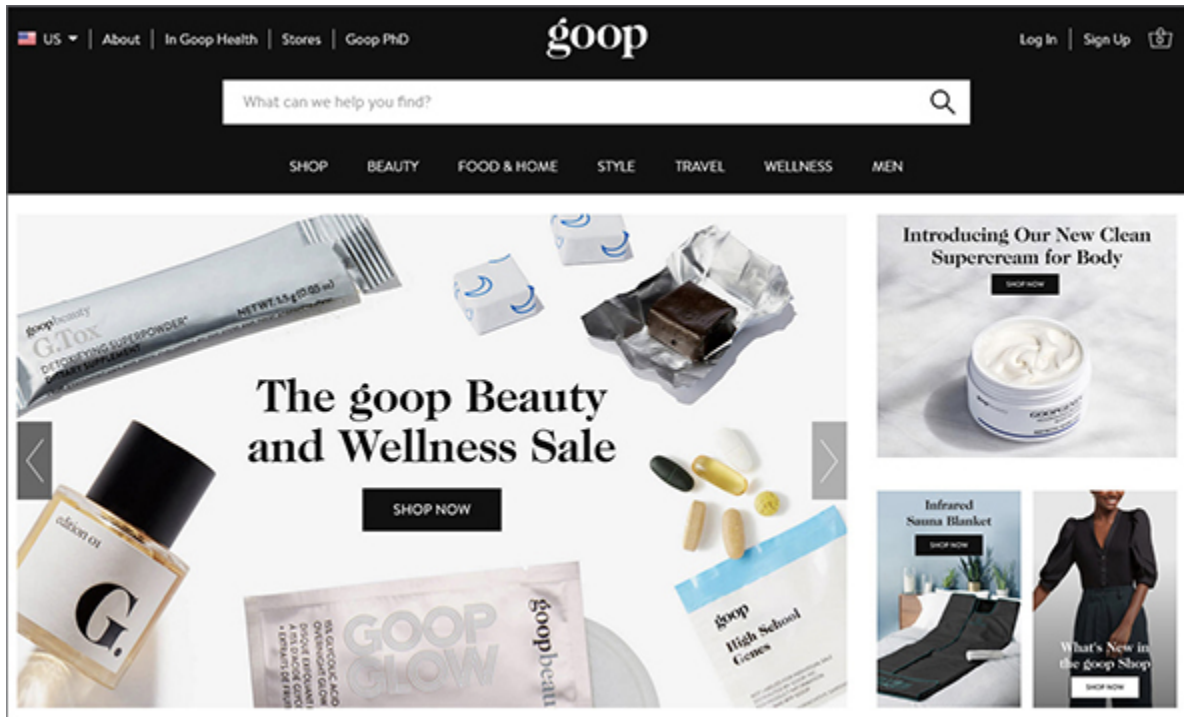


Figure 9.5 Gwyneth Paltrow’s Goop now boasts more than 8 million subscribers.

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CHAPTER 10

COMING UP WITH IDEAS

An idea that is not dangerous is unworthy of being called an idea at all.

OSCAR WILDE

Positive content experiences come from analyzing what you have, mixed with information gathering about your audience. If you don't intimately understand both, success will be challenging.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Ann Handley, author of the book *Everybody Writes*, believes in the *Content Inc.* concept for two reasons. Handley says:

Number one, because it does put the needs of your audience first, in the sense that you see the audience as collaborative with your business. I like that audience-centric point of view.

The second thing is that creating content isn't just for marketing. It's not just an external exercise designed to grow an audience; the beauty of content is that it actually also grows the individual. So it grows the content creator at the same time. That means it almost forces you to evolve your thinking. When you're creating content and you're getting feedback from the audience, it allows you to hone your vision, as well as embed your vision ultimately with whatever it is that you're creating.

Darren Rowse launched a camera-review website (Digital Photography School) that became the leading educational platform for beginning photographers. Kristen Bor started a backpacking blog (*Bearfoot Theory*) that became a world-renowned site about van life. Wally Koval launched a travel bucket list (*Accidentally Wes Anderson*) that became a bestselling coffee table book on photojournalism.

Look at any leading informational resource on the web. The content first developed at launch is usually significantly different from newer material. Over time, the content evolves to better meet audience needs. At the same time, the content creators begin to find their own content tilt (which sometimes takes time to find, as we've discussed).

Finishing races is important, but racing is more important.

DALE EARNHARDT

To get to *Content Inc.* success, we need to do the work. Now that you've identified your sweet spot and determined what differentiates you and your content, coming up with consistently compelling content ideas may seem daunting. Putting in the work makes all the difference.

Most entrepreneurs fail at developing ideas for their content because they fail to plan. If you are sitting in front of the computer waiting for inspiration to strike, you're doing it wrong.

There is no one right way to develop ideas for your content projects, but you do need a process.

THE CONTENT AUDIT

Before you can determine what kind of content you need, you first need to figure out what you have. In addition, you need to determine whether what you have is any good at all or, better yet, whether you have some raw content that is still incredibly valuable that you can leverage throughout your *Content Inc.* strategy.

Why is this so critical? I've worked with hundreds of companies that launched new e-books and white papers and hired freelancers and editors, only to find out midway through the process that much of the content they

wanted had already been created somewhere else in the organization. Conducting even a simple content audit would have saved those companies time and money.

Content audits can be expensive, but probably less costly than spending resources on unnecessary content. There are a number of free content audit templates out there for you to use. For now, let's keep it simple and focus on your core content assets. Your spreadsheet might look something like this:

Content Type	Usage	Quantity	Details
Textual	Blog articles	42	Possible to leverage in a future book
Imagery	Instagram posts	194	Original design pictures. Full rights
Audio	Podcast interviews	34	45-minute interviews with design experts
Video	YouTube how-tos	5	Tutorials on CAD design for engineers
E-book	Research report	2	Proprietary reports on end-user usage

You can go as far down the rabbit hole as you want on this. Many organizations do a full content audit of their websites and analyze every page, using tools such as Google Analytics, Orbiter, and Screaming Frog. Let's save that for later. Right now, we just want to know what we're working with.

50 QUESTIONS

One of the amazing things about Marcus Sheridan's success with River Pools & Spas is that he's never actually installed a fiberglass pool, even though the majority of the world believes he *is* the expert. His secret: "The ultimate content strategy is listening."

Marcus listens to customers, to employees, to podcasts. He's a consummate learner. Then he brainstorms for content ideas. "If you don't come up with at least 50 questions, you haven't tried hard enough," says Sheridan. "If you write two times per week, that's a whole year's worth of content."

Open a notebook and make a list of questions your audience would like answered. (Keep your content mission in mind while you do this.) At this point, there are no wrong answers. Don't stop and correct anything—just

write questions. Finish your list of 50 questions and take a break. After a while, come back to the list to find the diamonds.

LEVERAGING FREEWRITING

Mark Levy (author of *Accidental Genius*) gave me a crash course in something called “freewriting.” Freewriting, also called stream-of-consciousness writing, is a writing technique where a person writes for a set period, without bothering about correct spelling or even staying on topic. Mark uses this technique with his clients to unearth the raw content at the heart of the content creator.

Natalie Goldberg, author of *The True Secret of Writing*, outlines the rules of freewriting:

- Give yourself a time limit. Write for a set period and then stop.
- Keep your hand moving until the time is up. Do not pause to stare into space or to read what you’ve written. Write quickly but do not rush.
- Pay no attention to grammar, spelling, punctuation, neatness, or style. Nobody else needs to read what you produce.
- If you get off topic or run out of ideas, keep writing anyway. If necessary, write nonsense or whatever comes into your head, or simply scribble. Do anything to keep the hand moving.
- If you feel bored or uncomfortable as you’re writing, ask yourself what’s bothering you, and write about that.
- When the time is up, look over what you’ve written, and mark passages that contain ideas or phrases that might be worth keeping or elaborating on in a subsequent freewriting session.

HAVING FUN WITH GOOGLE ALERTS

Google Alerts is a free service (all you need is a Gmail account) that delivers web content to your inbox that’s related to the words you are searching for. For example, if you are interested in content around the

multiplayer game Minecraft, you could ask Google Alerts to send you a notification when Google finds a new page on Minecraft tips or Minecraft releases.

You can receive alerts as they happen, every day, or every week. These articles you are alerted to can become new fodder for your content ideas.

Google Trends is a great resource for this as well.

HASHTAGS

As with Google Alerts, your industry may have a number of hashtags that can be a beacon for new content. For example, there are multiple conversations on the web going on around “business-to-business marketing.” The hashtag for this would be #b2bmarketing. By searching Twitter (via its tool TweetDeck), LinkedIn, Facebook, or Instagram, you can monitor what is going on around the topic in social media. Other paid tools include Brand24, Sprout Social, and Brandmentions.com.

ANALYZE YOUR ANALYTICS

Jay Baer would never have found his content tilt without analyzing his web traffic. After publishing a post about social media, he was seeing double and triple the traffic versus when he wrote about email marketing.

Look at your analytics every week. Find out what people are most interested in and how they are locating your content. It may make sense to create more content around what’s most important to your audience.

There are hundreds of analytics systems. Google Analytics is free and relatively easy to install on your website.

EMPLOYEE DISCUSSIONS

So many employees are afraid to help you create content, because they don’t understand that much of the value is added in the editing process. For your purposes, you want the “raw” content from them—the information that makes them subject-matter experts.

Reassure team members that the copy will be polished during editing. Then get them rolling by offering the following tips:

- **Record it.** As with your 50 questions or freewriting exercise, just have them get it out. Get together for coffee with your employees and record the conversation. Simply talk with them about the challenges they are seeing. Before you know it, you'll have 20 content ideas.
- **Storyboard it out.** If the employees are having a tough time opening up, tell them to visualize what they want to say and write down key phrases or concepts on sticky notes. They can even draw what they're thinking. This is an especially great way to organize thoughts for a longer piece.

ASK YOUR SOCIAL NETWORKS

Although it's important not to abuse this, asking your social networks can be helpful, especially if it's around a specific area. The reason you are reading this book right now is that the idea for *Content Inc.* was far and away the most requested piece of information from my social network.

TALK TO YOUR CUSTOMERS OR PROSPECTS

Hands down, my best generator of new ideas is going to conferences and events and talking directly with my audience of marketers. I generated my 2013 book, *Epic Content Marketing*, almost entirely by chatting with marketers at events.

If you don't have direct access to your customers, try email or a phone call. You'd be surprised how open your customers will be when you are not asking them to buy anything. Just ask "What's keeping you up at night these days?," and then sit back and listen.

HELPFUL TECH

A number of prolific bloggers use Evernote to track their content ideas. Evernote is an app used for journaling. It can sync with all your devices (smartphone, tablet, etc.). Robert Rose, my cohost on our podcast *This Old Marketing*, uses Evernote to track new ideas and news stories.

Some people like to visually track content ideas, using mind-mapping software such as Mindjet (now called MindManager). Newt Barrett, my coauthor on *Get Content Get Customers*, used Mindjet to lay out each book chapter, in addition to the book table of contents and case study details.

Michael Hyatt raves about Scrivener. Scrivener is used mostly by screenwriters, but lately more and more bloggers have taken to the tool.

Personally, I use a Moleskine notebook for all my idea generation.

READ A COMPLETELY IRRELEVANT BOOK

Every once in a while, I dry up creatively. No matter what I do, I just can't get focused on a compelling topic. When that happens, I pick up a book that is completely irrelevant to my content area. I've always found that my best content ideas pop into my head while I'm reading a good book. I highly recommend *Stranger in a Strange Land* by Robert Heinlein and classics like *To Kill a Mockingbird* (Harper Lee) and *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* (Douglas Adams).

If you don't have time to read, you don't have time (or the tools)
to write. Simple as that.

STEPHEN KING

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CHAPTER 11

THE CONTENT CALENDAR

You can have it all. You just can't have it all at once.

OPRAH WINFREY

For a *Content Inc.* program to work, it must always show up and, when it does, be interesting.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

For years, I've talked about consistency in content frequency as being the most important thing in building a content-first/audience-first business. It was true for my *Content Inc.* business, and it's true for every single example in this book.

But in actuality, there are two parts to consistency. Let me explain.

Growing up, every Thursday I watched the NBC hit show *Cheers*, which is about a bar in Boston. One of the main characters is Norm Peterson. Everyone loved Norm—so much so that when he entered the bar, all the other patrons yelled out his name.

Why did everyone love Norm? First, because he showed up at the same time, every day. To be loved, you have to be present. Second, Norm always had something interesting to say. Every. Single. Time.

It went like this:

Norm: Afternoon, everybody.

Everyone in the bar: Norm!

Bartender or patron: How's the world been treating you?

Norm: Like a baby treats a diaper.

He did this 273 different ways—the total number of *Cheers* episodes.

To be great, you have to show up. Then you have to be interesting.

Every. Single. Time.

As you've read, Anthony Fasano built an amazing *Content Inc.* business called the Engineering Management Institute.

Anthony says:

Consistency in content publication is absolutely critical. First of all, consistency in life is critical. I mean, if you go to the gym once a month, it doesn't help you. If you go multiple times a week, it helps you. If you eat well once a month, it doesn't help you. The same thing goes with content. If you do a podcast every so often, whenever you get the creative itch, you're not really helping anyone because it's just too random. There's no strategy around it.

You have to force yourself to do it, because otherwise you're not going to get into a rhythm. Your audience is not going to be feeling that they're getting the value on a consistent basis, and you won't build channels where you can impact and influence a lot of people and help a lot of people.

Think of consistency as rhythm, the rhythm of a heartbeat. It never stops, and it pretty much stays at the same pace. Sometimes it gets a little quicker, sometimes a bit slower, but it always beats.

“Determine how often (rhythm) you want to publish content (consistency) and maintain this (discipline),” says Denis Doeland of NXTLI. “This is the real challenge: the combination of rhythm, consistency and discipline is often underestimated.”

PLAN FOR CONSISTENCY

No matter how good we are at what we do or how many years we've been doing it, we all seek the elusive “better way” to accomplish our everyday

tasks—new tools to explore, new techniques with which to experiment, new information to take into consideration. Innovations are constantly emerging to help people do what they do in less time, with less wasted effort, and with greater success. Reinvention is practically a commodity we trade these days to keep pushing our digitally enabled society forward.

Even the most steady and stalwart of tools in the *Content Inc.* arsenal—the editorial (content) calendar—has transformed itself over the years, from a simple spreadsheet for tracking what we publish to an essential component for managing the entire life cycle of our content program.

All *Content Inc.* creators have one thing in common—they keep and run a content calendar. Let's get started.

THE BASICS

Start by reviewing the *Content Inc.* strategy information on which you will be basing your content creation efforts. You should already have a lot of this information by now, but this exercise formalizes the process.

Your answers to the following questions will help you determine what you need to track in your calendar, as well as help you stay focused on your marketing goals as you plan your content creation.

- Whom are you creating content for? Keeping your target audience top of mind as you create your calendar will be essential for planning how to deliver on its needs through your content marketing.
- Why are you creating content? Your content mission and goals will affect what you publish, where you publish, and how often, as well as how your team prioritizes and organizes its content creation efforts. For the most part, your content's success will be based on getting or keeping subscribers (see the chapters on audience building).
- What resources do you have at your disposal? You might have a dedicated team of writers and videographers, a stable of industry pros looking to share their insights, a handful of reluctant execs who will need some serious content creation hand-holding. Or maybe it's just you. The formats, frequency, and overall work flow you track in your

calendar will likely depend on who is writing and where his or her expertise lies.

- How can you stand out? What unmet industry needs can your content address? What gaps exist in your current content creation efforts—or the efforts of your competitors? What industry events happen throughout the year to which you can tie your content for added exposure? Knowing where you can play a lead role in owning the audience’s attention will help you fill your editorial calendar with effective content that helps you meet your business goals.

THE CONSISTENCY OF MICHAEL SCHØT

The *Ministry of Schøt* (*Schøtministeriet*), a show about political incorrectness, is the birthchild of Danish stand-up comedian Michael Schøt. Every Friday at noon, Michael releases a new episode. He has done this for 350 weeks in a row, gaining him more than 100,000 followers on Facebook.

The format for the show is strict. Every episode of *Schøtministeriet* begins with the same fanfare, the background is the same, and Schøt is always dressed in a white shirt and dark tie, sitting behind a table. Each episode ends with the phrase “And God [God is bleeped out] save my naked butt.” Episodes last between 6 and 10 minutes.

SETTING UP THE CALENDAR

There are a number of paid and free calendaring tools that can help you set up your calendar. A few of these include:

- MS Excel, Google Sheets (or other spreadsheet tools)
- Evernote
- Agorapulse
- Trello
- Loomly

- Sprout Social
- DivvyHQ

Shanna Mallon, a writer for Straight North, offers some suggestions on a quick, easy way to build a content calendar. At the most fundamental level, we recommend that your calendar include the following fields:

- The *date* the piece of content is due for proofing/production.
- The *date* the piece of content will be published
- The *topic* or *headline* of the content piece
- The *author* of the content
- The *owner* of the content—i.e., the person in charge of ensuring that the content makes it from ideation to publication and promotion
- The *current status* of the content (updated as it moves through your publishing cycle)

Depending on your company's content niche and mission, your team's work flow, the formats and platforms with which you plan to work, and the volume of content you will be creating, you may also want to track these elements to help you stay organized and on course over the long term. For example:

- **The channels where your content will be published.** This can include only your owned channels (such as your blog, website, email newsletters, etc.), or you can expand your tracking to include paid and social media channels as well.
- **Content types.** Is it a blog post? A video? A podcast? An original image? To get more mileage from the content you create, you might want to consider recasting that content into other formats at some point. It's helpful to keep tabs on the types of assets you have on hand right from the start.
- **Visuals.** Speaking of assets, it's important that you don't overlook the appeal that visuals can lend to your content, in terms of both social sharing potential and overall brand recognition. Tracking the visual elements you include in your content efforts—such as cover images,

logos, illustrations, charts—makes it easier to ensure that your work has a signature look and cohesive brand identity.

- **Topic categories.** This makes your calendars more searchable. Find topics on which you’ve already created a lot of content, as well as those that you haven’t covered often enough.
- **Keywords, hashtags, and other metadata.** Metadata includes meta descriptions and SEO (search engine optimization) titles (if they differ from your headlines), which will help you keep your SEO efforts aligned with your content creation.
- **URLs.** Archive this information as an easy way to keep your online content audits updated or to link to older pieces of content in the new content you create.
- **Calls to action.** This helps you ensure that every piece of content you create is aligning with your audience acquisition goals.
- **Audience outcome.** Perhaps my favorite part of the calendar, adding an outcome is important if you are working with multiple content creators. Listing the outcome means you are specific with what you want your audience to get from your content. Will people get a better job? Learn a specific task? Live a better life in some way? Listing an outcome helps content creators keep the audience’s point of view in mind.

It may be helpful to have more than one content calendar. For example, you might have a master calendar where you can see everything at a glance and individual calendars for specific activities ([Figure 11.1](#)).

	Author	Headline	Status	Call to action	Category	Notes
Week of November 3						
Monday, November 3, 14						
Tuesday, November 4, 14						
Wednesday, November 5, 14						
Thursday, November 6, 14						
Friday, November 7, 14						
Saturday, November 8, 14						
Sunday, November 9, 14						
Week of November 10						
Monday, November 10, 14						
Tuesday, November 11, 14						
Wednesday, November 12, 14						
Thursday, November 13, 14						
Friday, November 14, 14						
Saturday, November 15, 14						
Sunday, November 16, 14						
Week of November 17						
Monday, November 17, 14						
Tuesday, November 18, 14						
Wednesday, November 19, 14						
Thursday, November 20, 14						
Friday, November 21, 14						
Saturday, November 22, 14						
Sunday, November 23, 14						
Week of November 24						
Monday, November 24, 14						
Tuesday, November 25, 14						
Wednesday, November 26, 14						
Thursday, November 27, 14						
Friday, November 28, 14						
Saturday, November 29, 14						

Figure 11.1 Your content calendar doesn't have to be complex to be effective.

KEEPING YOUR CALENDAR FILLED AND FOCUSED

As discussed in the previous chapter, content ideation is an ongoing and important process. As your content ideas become more refined, add them to your content calendar. Keeping a running list of ideas in your calendar spreadsheet makes it an easy reference tool when you need some inspiration.

Again, the fields you set up in your spreadsheet can vary by need, but at the very least we recommend that you track:

- The topic idea
- The idea's owner
- The target keywords and categories to which the content would map
- Who might be available and qualified to author the piece
- A publishing time frame

Michele Linn, cofounder of Mantis Research, recommends adding additional tabs to your content calendar spreadsheet, including:

- Existing “brick” content (downloadable e-books or white papers used to attract subscribers) that can be used as a call to action in new content pieces
- Ideas for content that can be repurposed into multiple content pieces
- Content that can be compiled and curated

CONTENT VELOCITY

When Facebook expert Jon Loomer started his *Content Inc.* model, he produced 350 posts in the first year. In the second year, he decreased his

output to 250 posts. By the third year, he was at 100 original pieces of content.

The point? As Jon built his audience, he realized he didn't have to create as much content to get the maximum impact. Although this depends on the platform you are building, more content isn't always the best use of your resources.

Our goal should always be to create the minimum amount of content with the maximum amount of results.

ROBERT ROSE

WORKING AHEAD

A common question from entrepreneurs pertains to timing. Exactly how far ahead do we have to plug in our editorial calendar?

While there is no one right way to do this, content teams generally:

- Meet once per year to discuss overall direction and editorial strategy. This gives you a general sense of your content direction as it aligns to your mission.
- Meet quarterly to compile content themes for the upcoming quarter. This takes your general content and gets specific with weekly themes, contributors, and production schedules.
- Meet weekly to make changes as needed. This gives your team the opportunity to take advantage of fresh content that may need to find a home in the schedule or perhaps to take advantage of industry news (called real-time marketing).

The best content teams have a great idea of what they will publish over the next month—and know exactly what they will publish over the next two weeks. If you and your team don't know what content you'll produce, this will lead to lackluster content and process mistakes that will take a toll on your model.

RESOURCES

Interview with Jon Loomer by Clare McDermott, January 2015.

Interview with Michael Schøt by Joakim Ditlev, September 2020.

Interview with Michele Linn by Joe Pulizzi, June 2016.

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CHAPTER 12

FINDING CONTENT HELP

None of us is as smart as all of us.

KEN BLANCHARD

Most *Content Inc.* models begin with content created by one or two people. But as the model grows, you need content assistance. You'll find out where and how in this chapter.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

In almost every interview with entrepreneurs who employed a *Content Inc.* strategy, there was no team. It was just the lone entrepreneur trying to get a business started. This was certainly the case with me and Content Marketing Institute. It was the same with Brian Clark and Copyblogger, Quinn Tempest on Instagram, the Chicken Whisperer, and Anthony Fasano at Engineering Management Institute.

For the platform to work beyond a hobby-based business and blossom into a growth company, scalability is key. You need a team to get you to the next level.

CONTENT ROLES

“What staffing roles do we need to be successful with a *Content Inc.* approach?” I hear this question all the time in companies of all sizes. It’s a critical question, and one that is not easy to plan for. Still, plan we must.

There is no perfect structure for a *Content Inc.* organization. Each one depends on the audience and the content niche. We need to think about filling certain roles now so that success is attainable.

Don’t think of the following as new job titles, per se, but rather as the core competencies that you’ll need to find across the enterprise. As you’ll see, many of these roles can be filled by multiple titles.

CHIEF CONTENT OFFICER (AKA FOUNDER)

This is most likely you. This person is responsible for setting the overall editorial and content mission. As every staff member works to create and curate content, it is the CCO’s responsibility to make sure that the stories remain consistent and make sense to the audience(s).

In addition, the CCO must understand how the stories translate into results that address the organization’s business issues: driving new subscribers, keeping current subscribers, leading the way to revenue, etc.

Sample titles: chief content officer, founder, owner, CEO, publisher

MANAGING EDITOR

Half storyteller and half project manager, the managing editor executes the content plan on behalf of the CCO. Whereas the CCO focuses on strategy (and some content), the managing editor’s job is all execution (including content scheduling), working with other roles to make the stories come alive.

Sample titles: managing editor, chief editor, project manager

CHIEF LISTENING OFFICER

The role of the CLO is to function as air traffic control for social media and other content channels. This person is there to listen to the groups, maintain the conversation, and route feedback to the team members who can engage in appropriate conversations (to you, editorial, or perhaps the sales team).

This feedback mechanism is critical if the content is going to make a difference for your customers. The CLO also needs to keep tabs on how the content is performing on owned media sites (like a blog) and get that intelligence back to the CCO and managing editor.

Sample titles: social media manager, community manager

DIRECTOR OF AUDIENCE

This person monitors the members of your audience, making sure all content creators are intimately familiar with their characteristics and passion triggers, as well as the actions you want them to take. The director of audience is also responsible for building subscription assets (direct mail lists, email subscriptions, social media followers) that can grow and be segmented as your content mission matures and expands.

Sample titles: audience development manager, circulation manager, subscription manager

CHANNEL MASTER

Wherever your content is headed (social media, email, mobile, print, in person, etc.), the channel master is responsible for getting the most out of each channel. What works best on LinkedIn? When should you send your emails and how frequently? What's the appropriate ratio of owned versus curated content your business should distribute on Twitter? Who is keeping track of mobile strategy and execution? Your team will look to the channel master for these and other answers.

Sample titles: e-media manager, director of analytics

CHIEF TECHNOLOGIST

As marketing and information technology continue to merge, you will need at least one individual (maybe more) whose sole purpose is to leverage the proper use of these technologies into the content marketing process. The person in this role will be responsible for your publishing systems, such as website infrastructure and email systems and how they integrate.

Sample titles: e-media manager, IT manager, web services manager

CREATIVE DIRECTOR

The design and look of your content is more critical than ever, especially as visual social channels become an increasingly important way to attract and retain subscribers. The creative director is responsible for the overall look and feel of all your content, including the website, blog, images, photography, and every other piece of collateral you create.

Sample titles: creative director, graphic design manager

INFLUENCER RELATIONS

The role formerly known as media relations has evolved into manager of influencers. This person's responsibilities include developing your "hit list" of influencers, maintaining direct relationships with them, and integrating them into your marketing process in the most impactful ways.

Sample titles: public relations manager, marketing director, communications manager

FREELANCER AND AGENCY RELATIONS

As content demands continue to evolve and increase, your organization's reliance on freelance talent and other external content vendors will grow as well. Organizations need to cultivate their own expert content teams and networks. This person's job is to negotiate rates and responsibilities so that all members of your team are united in their work on behalf of your *Content Inc.* program.

Sample titles: managing editor, project manager

CONTENT CURATION DIRECTOR

As you begin to develop content assets, you'll have some amazing opportunities to repackage and repurpose your content. The job of the content curation director is to continually look at all the content the organization develops and strategize ways to create new pieces of content from what already exists.

Sample titles: social media director, content curation specialist, content director

OUTSOURCING YOUR CONTENT TO FREELANCERS

You may find that you need help developing ongoing content or that you need additional content producers to keep up with the speed and quality of production.

HOW GAME THEORY OPERATIONALIZES CONTENT

Game Theory founder Matthew Patrick, who started from nothing, has developed an audience of more than 8 million subscribers. Matthew gives a detailed look at how he staffs his multiple business lines.

Game Theory operates two kinds of branches that nicely synergize with each other. There is the production component, which is all of the YouTube and creative processes. The biggest property is the Game Theorists, which currently employs around 13–16 people. That includes freelance editors, writers, sales team, etc.

On the production side, [there are] custom videos for video game brands, traditional advertisers and things like that, which live on the Game Theorists channel, that are promoting their product or talking about the service that they offer. I'm writing the copy, I'm the influence or talent in that, and then we're always getting across their messaging points and driving the audience to convert sales.

So in addition to doing just our own standard videos, a good number of those are branded, either by video game companies coming in and asking for a piece of custom content or direct response companies, or just other brands asking for some kind of awareness campaign. That's the production side.

Then there is the consultancy wing. On the consultancy side we operate very much like a traditional consultancy. Our specialty is growing an organic audience in the media space with a specific emphasis around YouTube. And so right now our service offering really ranges the gamut based on what the client needs. We have

everything from full one-day workshops where we will come into your company and basically take you and your team through YouTube 101 to 301; here is everything you need to know about content, what works on the platform, how to optimize your presence using very granular levels of optimizations, and moving forward how can you strategize for success.

And then there are also some longer-term projects. So we have people who are working almost in a full-time capacity with various companies acting as their content managers, as their channel managers.

It's really been a spectrum, but that is all on the consultancy side. That's the fundamental principle: data-driven decision making to help grow an organic audience in the new media space.

How do you go about finding good external content contributors (sometimes called “stringers”)? Should you look for a good writer and teach him or her your business? Or should you hire someone who knows your industry and teach him or her to write? The following are a few tips to consider:

- Remember that expertise is helpful, but lack of it is not a deal killer. You can almost certainly teach someone your business faster and better than you can teach someone to write or produce content.
- Hire right—copywriters, journalists, technical writers, production specialists. Because you've spent so much time on your strategy and process, you should be very aware of the kind of content creator you're looking for. Understand that copywriters work very differently and have very different sensibilities than journalists do. If you're looking for someone to write blog posts for you, a copywriter might not be your best bet. On the other hand, if you're looking for someone to beef up your persuasive call to action for all the great white papers you're putting together, then a great copywriter may be exactly what you need. Even with video production, it's extremely helpful to make sure the members of your team understand the audience first, especially if you don't give them a finalized production script.

- Develop the right business relationship. Understand the elements of your business relationship and write them down. Will there be one content item per week, and will your writer be paid a monthly fee? If so, how will you handle months that have five weeks? Will there be an extra post that week? Will you pay extra for that post? Will short posts pay less than longer posts?
- Given the size of your organization, you need to make clear the invoicing and payment terms—or understand what the writer needs. Make expectations clear. There should be no surprises, no blog posts suddenly going from 750 to 1,000 words or content themes going wildly off topic. Include all this in the final signed agreement and coordinate a user-friendly vendor invoicing system.

Here are some of the things you'll need to communicate to your freelance content creators:

- What content they will produce and where it falls on the content calendar. (Be very specific about when drafts are due. Plan to review them promptly.)
- The goals for their specific contributions (both your goals and the audience outcome). Who will come up with the ideas for content? If freelancers are in charge of idea generation, set separate deadlines for ideas and for the finished content. What expertise or other third-party information will freelancers need to access? Will they interview internal people, bring in external information, or rework existing material?
- Your budget (per piece, hourly, or retainer). Make sure to include the number of content pieces and the estimated length per piece in the agreement. And you should expect to pay more for writers who generate new ideas than for writers who rework existing materials.
- The number of revision rounds for each piece.

There are also a number of excellent services out there that can help you find the right content provider. Some to consider include:

- ClearVoice

- Fiverr
- Upwork
- Textbroker

BUDGETING FACTORS

In the near publishing past, freelancers used to get paid \$1 per word. This still remains true for high-quality and unique content, like that for research reports and white papers. For article content, some services will price your content as low as 5 cents per word. For video services, the range is incredibly vast, from \$15 per hour to \$250 per hour.

Word of warning: You usually get what you pay for. At CMI, we found the most success in the retainer model—that is, creating an ongoing relationship with a freelancer who works on a stated number of content assets over a period of time, then paying a monthly fee for the work. Both sides typically appreciate this arrangement. Both business and freelancer can budget more easily with an agreed-upon range of work.

CONTENT THROUGH CURATION

BookBub, which offers users deals and notifications on bestselling books, realized that its best content creation plan was through external curation. Instead of creating original content, BookBub launched with an email newsletter almost exclusively made up of curated pieces of content from existing books. It worked. Today, with millions of subscribers, BookBub has become an amazing resource for consumers who love to read.

TEST FIRST

With a large supply of content creators in the workforce, there is no need to start with a long-term relationship. Test a creator out with a few stories or videos, and see how that works. Ask yourself: Is the person's style to your

expectations? Does he or she deliver on time? Is the person actively sharing the content via his or her own social network? (Some writers will only share to their social networks if this is agreed upon in writing.)

Once the creator has met your expectations in these areas, set out on a long-term deal. I've seen too many marketers and publishers get their rock star freelancers, only to kill the deal a few months later with neither party happy. Test the fit first so you don't waste your time.

TRY FLEECING THE MASTHEAD

Remember the masthead? It was the place where you found the names of all the writers, editors, and circulation managers that worked at a print magazine. Today mastheads are harder to locate, but they still exist. Once found, they can be extremely useful to your model—you just need to know how to use them.

Opening up the leading trade magazine or visiting a media website in your niche and finding the masthead is a gold mine for discovering competent writers and other content creators. These creators (many part-time) not only understand your customer base but can formulate relevant and original content in a skilled way.

Besides writers, the masthead lists editors who can help turn your raw content into an engaging story, as well as video production and SEO/social media experts.

The masthead also provides information about your audience. It shows circulation and the publishing roles responsible for circulation development, audience building, and subscriber generation. (The publication's media kit is another great place to get information about customer demographics.) This can help you target subscribers, build relationships, and ultimately get people to buy from you.

Design needs? Check the masthead for that as well.

The timing couldn't be better. At many media companies and trade publishers, the business models aren't working. The 2020 recession has led to numerous bankruptcies and divestitures. Even when publications stay in business, raises are harder to come by these days. That leaves the door wide open for you and your business.

WORKING WITH CONTRACTORS

The majority of CMI staff were contractors. These are people who want flexible hours, are looking for options for their life, and do not necessarily want to work 40 hours a week. We found amazing talent and individuals who are looking for this kind of flexibility.

When I started in the media business more than 20 years ago, we contracted with creative designers and freelance journalists from all over the world. We had to do this to find the best resources to complete a particular project.

A lot of owners want their employees doing all the content tasks without worrying about them working for other companies. They feel it is critical to building their company culture. This may work for some, but the cream of the crop in the media industry want more opportunity. A 1099 independent contractor relationship works well in most cases. For our business, and in a few very important situations, we would not have been able to hire the right talent without this type of flexibility.

CONTENT HELP THROUGH REPURPOSING

By Arnie Kuenn, author of *Content Marketing Works*

Developing new material for your content requires a great deal of effort, from researching topics, coming up with ideas and angles, to content creation and promotion. There are often multiple people involved in the process: copywriters, designers, SEO specialists, social media marketers, and others, which can make content quite the investment. Fortunately, great content can often be repurposed into something new and different, continually furthering your investment along the way.

The Benefits of Content Repurposing

Content repurposing requires altering a piece of content to make it fresh by changing the angle or switching up the format. Integrating repurposing into your strategy can lower costs, advance production,

expand audience reach, and provide myriad additional benefits, including:

- **Expanding one idea into several content pieces.** For example, a popular blog post can form the base of a slide show, a video, a free information guide, a white paper, a podcast. You get the idea. Repurposing lets you leverage the research you conducted for one piece of original work across additional content projects.
- **Substantially cutting content creation time.** Elements that have already been created or curated—like images, quotes, or text—can be applied to new works.
- **Serving multiple audiences.** Some people are visual learners, while others may prefer reading a document. Some people love to read in-depth research articles, while others wish to quickly skim blog posts. Content repurposing lets you appeal to multiple audiences with different content preferences. For example, if you've created great video content, your script can be the basis of text documents, such as blog posts or downloadable PDFs. Similarly, you can illustrate statistics, facts, and figures through data visualization and deliver them as infographics or charts.
- **Cross-promoting content.** Through repurposing efforts, you can cross-promote your great content pieces across multiple channels. For example, in a YouTube video description, you may link to a blog post, a slide show, and an infographic about the same topic, which sends traffic to your website or blog. This targeted traffic reinforces branding and increases the likelihood of attracting subscribers.
- **Extending content's longevity.** With so much content being published every day, people are bound to miss a blog post or video once in a while. However, through repurposing, your audience may come across your content, after it has been altered, through a different channel. Additionally, repurposing evergreen content expands the life cycle even further, as it can remain relevant for years to come.

The Content Repurposing Process

Creating a repurposing plan at the beginning of your development will help you brainstorm and produce content efficiently while keeping your repurposing process streamlined and in alignment with your other content efforts.

Consider the following four steps:

1. **Take one story idea.** Begin to think of different ways in which the story can be told. In this initial phase, it is important to consider how one topic can be translated across multiple types of content. For example, if you have a store that sells sunglasses, your topic may be “sunglasses trends for 2021.” Though broad, this topic can be the focal point of many content projects.
2. **Once you have a general topic, think of how it can be altered and applied across content types to appeal to numerous audiences.** In the sunglasses trends example, a few content pieces you can create might include:
 - Blog posts on women’s or men’s sunglasses trends for 2021
 - An infographic illustrating different styles of sunglasses predicted to be popular in 2021
 - A video interviewing your expert employees about 2021 sunglasses trends
 - A slide show featuring images and descriptions of the top sunglasses styles for 2021
 - An e-book on how to choose sunglasses for 2021 that fit your face and style

That’s just the beginning. With a wide-ranging topic like sunglasses trends for 2021, it is easy to see how researching one concept can lead to multiple content pieces. Each piece has a different point of view and is transformed to appeal to a specific audience, but the core idea remains the same.

3. **Now that you have assembled a list of different takes on your core idea, start researching, keeping the first piece you want to create in mind.** Start with whatever piece makes the most sense. If you create a slide show, can you easily adapt it to create an

infographic? Can a video script work as a blog post? The first piece of content you construct will take the most work up front, as it requires the greatest amount of research and development. However, when you've finished researching for your first content piece, you can apply your findings to creating additional content in the future.

4. **After you have created your first piece of content, repurpose your research and other elements from the project to make new works.** You may need to research more specific facets of your core idea as you go, but most of the grunt work should already be completed.

Get the Most Out of Your Content

In summary, content repurposing is a very efficient way to make the most of your content creation efforts. Numerous content pieces can stem from just one main idea, each catering to a different audience in a unique way. The process of repurposing can save you time and money and extend your initial content investment, making it a worthwhile strategy.

THE COLLABORATIVE PUBLISHING MODEL

A Case in Point

Michael Stelzner, on founding the social media marketing education site Social Media Examiner, writes:

I went out to my friends that I had built relationships with. I decided to ask [them] if they would consider writing one article a month until they were bored.

So the five of us essentially each wrote one article a month. Then I got a volunteer and she worked for free as my editor, behind the scenes, putting everything into WordPress.

I'll tell you, in the first couple of weeks the thing exploded. We had 10,000 e-mail subscribers literally in like 2½ months.

What do these companies have in common: Forbes, Content Marketing Institute, Social Media Examiner, Copyblogger, HubSpot, MarketingProfs, *Huffington Post*, and Mashable?

They all use a collaborative publishing model. Instead of having a core set of writers and journalists employed by the brand (the model used by traditional publishing), these brands reach out to their community to recruit relevant content to publish on their platform.

They all are extremely successful businesses!

WHY CONSIDER COLLABORATIVE PUBLISHING?

As a business model, collaborative publishing is the idea that the business actively recruits outside contributors to build a platform and an audience. Once the platform is built and sees some success, you have an opportunity to bring in thought leaders and community experts to fill content holes.

Outside the benefit of covering content areas that may be difficult for you to do yourself or by paying for the expertise through freelancers, the biggest benefit to a collaborative model is the opportunity to attract a new audience to your content. Contributors have their own followers and subscribers, who, if things are done right, can be added to your audience.

Many traditional media companies showcase employed talent only. They do not encourage members of the community to contribute stories. This presents a clear opportunity for you.

The *Huffington Post* was founded in 2005 by a number of investors, including Arianna Huffington, a spokesperson for the political left in the United States. In 2011 the *Huffington Post* sold for more than \$300 million to AOL and is now one of the crown jewels of Verizon's media network.

The *Huffington Post* has hundreds of niche, targeted sites, where thousands of contributors around the world publish content for free, in exchange for the opportunity to be published. The *Huffington Post* employs

a collaborative publishing model. Sure, it hires some amazing journalists, writers, and content producers, but thought leaders and active members of the community produce much of what you see on the site.

THE PROCESS

There are a number of ways to identify contributors to develop the collaborative model, but the key to making the model work is as much about the process as it is the talent.

The first imperative is to set strict guidelines and expectations with your contributors. If you are lax about the content you allow on your site, you'll never be the leading informational expert in your niche.

Once you have a set number of contributors, the process can get extremely complex. It's important to keep open communication with all your contributors. When you receive an inquiry to contribute to your site, follow these steps:

- **Email #1.** Send out confirmation of the submission receipt and what the contributor should expect around the general timing of the process.
- **Email #2.** Notify regarding approval or rejection of the post. If confirmed, there is typically a request for revisions.
- **Email #3.** Send a preview of the post. Once the article has been finalized and set up for production, your blog editor sends a preview of the post, as well as the likely publication date and ideas on ways the writers can share the article with their own audience.
- **Email #4.** Notify the contributor of any blog comments. Once someone's first comment comes in, the blog editor or social media manager will forward that to the author and request that he or she engage and respond (some writers don't read comments, so you may need to communicate that they should pay attention to the comments of their article/content in advance).
- **Email #5.** Send notification of top post. If the article is performing well, you'll want to let the contributor know and keep in contact with him or her. This means that the contributor is someone of value. You

may want that person to develop another article at some point or to become a regular contributor.

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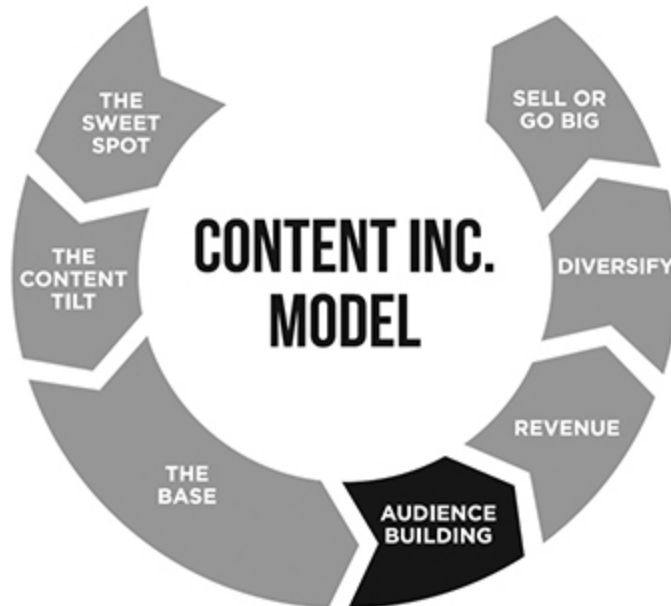
PART 5

AUDIENCE BUILDING

You can only build something massive by starting with something small to effectively close the distance.

DANNY INY

You've chosen your platform and developed assets and a publishing schedule that attracts a niche audience. Now it's time to create a system that builds a valuable subscriber base for your company.



CHAPTER 13

THE METRIC THAT DRIVES THE MODEL

When you give your ONE Thing your most emphatic “Yes!” and vigorously say “No!” to the rest, extraordinary results become possible.

GARY KELLER

Though activity metrics are critical to measure the success of your content, your ultimate goal should always be to get and keep an audience. A laser focus on that makes all the difference.

If you’ve got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Now that you’ve selected your content type and platform, your sole focus is on one simple metric: the subscriber. When you go to sleep at night, you should be thinking of attracting subscribers. When you wake up in the morning, you should have subscribers etched in your brain. The *Content Inc.* model only works if you can build a loyal audience of subscribers over time. Period.

This means that regardless of where you build your base as part of the *Content Inc.* model, you still need an email offering. Now’s the time. As Andrew Davis says, “Focusing on creating a subscriber database is

developing a customer database before you actually have customers to sell to.”

Like a subscription to Netflix or (in days past) a newspaper subscription, your goal is to deliver such amazing value through content that your audience is willing to give some piece of personal information up as a value exchange (email address, home address, etc.). The only difference is that you are giving your content away for free, so that you can monetize that relationship later.

John Jantsch, founder of Duct Tape Marketing, followed a *Content Inc.* strategy, including a community blog and book series, to grow a multimillion-dollar consulting practice. But John’s lightbulb moment came when he added a “sign my guestbook” area to his website in the early 2000s. Instead of just looking at website traffic analytics, John was beginning to build a subscriber database. Those subscribers gave John the ability to launch his consulting network and build a multimillion-dollar platform in the process.

The Tonight Show host Jimmy Fallon is one of the subscription kings of media. After every show, you’ll see multiple clips from the show shared around social media to promote (you guessed it) subscriptions. After every short clip, you’ll see a humorous clip of Jimmy Fallon asking his audience to subscribe.

CASE STUDY: CHARLOTTE LABEE

Charlotte Labee, former Miss Universe Netherlands, struggled to make a living after her brief stardom in 2015. Struck with some major health issues a few months later, Charlotte discovered something called “right brain balance.” Charlotte says, “All the things that we do, learn, eat or drink is because of our brain and how it’s wired. It’s the basis of our human system. When I figured that out I was like, ‘Amazing, why don’t we hear about that at school?’ If our brain is not in balance, we can’t handle all the changes around us.”

Charlotte made communicating about this issue her focus, dedicating her Instagram channel to brain fitness. In three years, that channel has grown to garner more than 50,000 followers. The key to her current success? Her weekly email newsletter, which has exceeded 25,000 subscribers in two

years. Among her achievements are multiple book deals, speaking engagements, and a successful portal called Your Brain Balance, and the key is clear. The email newsletter drives the model for revenue success.

QUICK-QUILTING CAPITAL OF THE WORLD

Courtesy of Andrew Davis

If you're not a quilter, this may be the first time you've heard of the town Hamilton, Missouri: the quick-quilting capital of the world. The moniker was earned thanks to a down-to-earth, engaging quilt shop owner and her custom-made YouTube video quilting tutorials. Jenny Doan is the cofounder of the Missouri Star Quilt Co., a quilt shop in Hamilton that boasts the largest selection of precut fabrics in the world.

During the great recession, Hamilton was hit hard. Residents Jenny and Ron Doan had raised their seven children on Ron's income as a machinist for the *Kansas City Star*. Many residents were laid off from their jobs, and Jenny and Ron's kids were concerned about their parents' financial future. To stay busy, Jenny sewed quilts for family and friends. Though she sewed together the fabric pieces to make a beautiful quilt herself, Jenny needed someone who had a long-arm sewing machine to add the batting and backing, then quilt together the resulting fabric sandwich. Demand was so great that it could take nine months to a year to secure a spot. That gave Jenny's son, Al, an idea.

Al and his sister Sarah invested \$24,000 into a sewing machine, a dozen bolts of fabric, and a building in Hamilton to sell quilting supplies and machine quilting services. The family worked two years on the business without ever bringing home a paycheck. It was challenging to grow the business in a town of just 1,800 people. Al decided they needed a website. As we all know, just because you build it, does not mean they will come.

The Doans knew they had to do something different to attract web visitors and drive more online sales. Al suggested Jenny create quilting video tutorials to post on YouTube. With Jenny's natural and engaging camera personality and Al's amateur behind-the-scenes abilities, the Missouri Star Quilt Co.'s YouTube channel was created.

The channel received 1,000 subscribers in its first year, 10,000 in year two, and today has more than 650,000 subscribers. Jenny's 350+ tutorial videos have been viewed more than 100 million times. The videos have driven new traffic to their website, fueling more than 2,000 online sales per day and making them the world's largest supplier of precut fabrics. Jenny receives emails from individuals all over the world who love watching her videos. From war-torn Iran to South Africa to across the United States, Jenny's fans love her.

The Doans don't necessarily know where the company will go from there, especially as the town's tourism was hit hard by the COVID-19 pandemic. Their focus is on making the best quilts and providing the best products for their customers. In the meantime, they are changing lives and rebuilding a town, one quilt at a time.

What does all this have to do with email? While Jenny was building her *Content Inc.* base on YouTube, Missouri Star Quilt amassed 50,000 members in its private forum. How do you become a part of that community? That's right. An email address.

Oh, and here's the punch line. According to *Forbes*, Missouri Star Quilt generated over \$40 million in 2019.

THE SUBSCRIBER HIERARCHY

As we discussed, your goal is to build content assets where you have the maximum amount of control. This is especially true in attracting a desirable audience. While I believe that any fan, follower, or subscriber can be a good thing, they are not equal in value.

For example, let's say that you build your platform on Facebook. You've been able to attract 50,000 fans on that platform via a business or Facebook group.

Over the past few years, Facebook has made drastic changes to its platform to hide posts from pages, including:

- Posts that solely push people to buy a product or install an app
- Posts that push people to enter promotions and sweepstakes with no real context

- Posts that reuse ad content exactly
- Posts that direct people to an outside website

This makes sense for Facebook's business model, but it also means that Facebook has the right *not* to show certain posts. As the US elections of 2016 and 2020 have taught us, people on Facebook see their own personal feed. Facebook is in control and may show your content—or not.

According to the Netflix documentary *The Social Dilemma*, Facebook's algorithm drives content consumption, whether it's real content or misinformation. The algorithm's goal is to increase engagement, and it will show you whatever it needs to make that happen.

Because of that algorithm, some businesses have seen organic reach (traffic that you don't pay for) on Facebook fall to 1 percent or less. At the same time, Scott Linabarger, former content marketing director at Cleveland Clinic, says that some posts still perform well organically on Facebook. It really doesn't matter. You should leverage Facebook however you can, but you need to know that Facebook controls the ultimate reach, not you.

As you analyze your digital footprint and begin to build your audience, your focus needs to be at the top of this hierarchy ([Figure 13.1](#)). Simply put, it comes down to the amount of control you have with the platform and your communications with fans and subscribers.

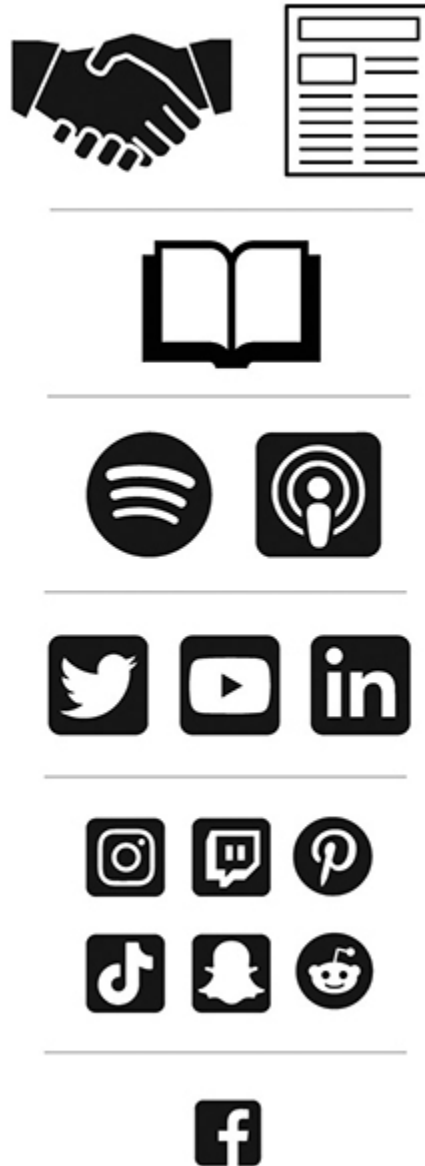


Figure 13.1 Our goal should be to continually move our subscribers up the hierarchy.

Starting at the top, the hierarchy consists of:

- **Membership.** This includes ongoing online training or membership in a private community group/discussion forum where you receive an email address for the service you provide. This type of subscriber is hard to beat.
- **Email newsletter subscribers.** A high amount of control. Extremely helpful and relevant emails will break through the clutter.

- **Print subscribers.** Subscribers generally trade vast amounts of personal information to receive a print magazine or newsletter. Communication is never instantaneous, and feedback is difficult. There are cost challenges due to print and postal charges.
- **Podcast subscribers.** Full control over the delivery of audio content, but Apple Podcasts, Spotify, Overcast, and Stitcher do not tell you who subscribes to your content.
- **Twitter followers.** Full control over what you send to followers, but messages have a limited life span, so it may be challenging to reach an audience regularly.
- **YouTube subscribers.** Some control over content, but YouTube can decide to hold some of your content back if subscribers aren't engaging enough with your content (called "subscriber burn").
- **LinkedIn connections.** Full control over what you send to followers and connections, but the channel is very congested, so it may be challenging to break through with a consistent message. LinkedIn's algorithm shows what gets engagement, so content that doesn't perform might not be seen.
- **Instagram followers.** Full control over your content, but Instagram's algorithm will show engaging content (which again means that your content may not be seen).
- **Twitch followers.** Almost exclusively for streaming video games. Play the right game for a long period of time and you can win a following. (The average stream time is three to four hours per session.)
- **Pinterest subscribers.** Full control over delivery of content. Users will see your content if they choose to. No ultimate ownership over platform.
- **TikTok fans.** Right now, TikTok owns the world's best algorithm. Quality content can perform well, even if you don't have a large following.
- **Snapchat followers.** Users spend more than 30 minutes a day on Snapchat and open the app more than 25 times per day. If you target a younger audience, you might need to test it out.

- **Reddit followers.** The Reddit community is extremely loyal to the platform. Posting consistently helpful content builds a following. Reddit is best as a secondary subscriber choice.
- **Facebook fans.** Facebook continually modifies its algorithm, which is out of your control. Fans may or may not see your content, depending on this algorithm, although quality, helpful, interesting content has the best chance of breaking through. Facebook almost always shuts down promotional content.

Though you have more control with certain subscription options, Jeff Rohrs, author of *Audience*, is adamant that no company “owns” its audience. “The reason that the audience is in different places is that no audience is owned. Regardless of whether you’re a major television network, pop star, or professional sports team with rabid fans, you simply do not own your audience. They can get up and leave—mentally or physically—at any time,” he says.

This is exactly the reason that amazingly helpful and relevant content is the only way to keep our audience connected to us, regardless of which subscription options you choose to leverage.

YOU NEED AN EMAIL OFFERING

Whether you are a YouTube star or a pool guy, you need an email offering to attract subscribers. BuzzFeed, the media entertainment and news site, gained its popularity due to social sharing on Facebook and Twitter. While Facebook and Twitter subscribers are important to BuzzFeed, every page on its site has a promotion designed to move email subscribers to its daily e-newsletter ([Figure 13.2](#)). At present, BuzzFeed’s business model starts and ends with opt-in email newsletters.

BuzzFeed Quizzes TV & Movies Shopping Videos News Testy Sign In

Prime Day Deals Please Just Vote Harry Potter Quizzes Latinx Heritage Month The Best Of TikTok

Newsletters

Please enter your email address below:

Sign up

Select the newsletters you'd like dropped in your inbox.

By entering your email and clicking subscribe, you're agreeing to let us send you customized marketing messages about us and our advertising partners. You are also agreeing to our [Terms of Service](#) and [Privacy Policy](#).

Trending Newsletters

Keep up with trending buzz you'll want to share with friends.

BuzzFeed Daily 5 updates a week Keep up with the latest daily buzz with the BuzzFeed Daily newsletter!	BuzzFeed Quizzes 5 updates a week Binge on the latest quizzes delivered right to your inbox with the Quizzes newsletter!	Tasty 4 updates a week Recipes, food quizzes, & cooking hacks.
As/Is 3 updates a week	Nifty Home 3 updates a week	News 5 updates a week

Figure 13.2 BuzzFeed's business model runs on email.

Let's look at the *Content Inc.* example at [TeachBetter.com](https://www.teachbetter.com) (Figure 13.3). Although it offers subscriptions to its Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, YouTube, Instagram, and Pinterest pages, most of the energy goes to gathering teachers' email addresses through free courses, reports, and templates.



Figure 13.3 Teach Better gives away hundreds of courses and e-books in exchange for an email address.

As you employ your *Content Inc.* base strategy, you need some kind of email offering. This could be a:

- Daily email newsletter based on your original blog
- Daily email newsletter curating the best information from the web
- Weekly email newsletter or weekly report offering original industry insight
- Report offering a fresh idea to your audience every month

Over the past few years, private membership groups (some paid and some free) have exploded in popularity. To support his medical marketing communications business, Joe Hage launched the Medical Devices Group in 2011 on LinkedIn, growing it to more than 300,000 members in just a few short years. In 2018, LinkedIn began to change what a group owner could do, including no longer sending email to members.

Joe says: “To save the value of the [LinkedIn] group, I created a workspace on Slack called MDG (Medical Devices Group). I saw my subscribers as unpaid customers.” Through the Slack group, Joe is able to communicate directly with his “members,” who in most cases pay him a small monthly fee through the service. He no longer has to worry about LinkedIn’s additional changes.

THE EMAIL RELATIONSHIP

When I tell people that unless something changes, email is still the best subscriber option, they often scoff. They will tell me how much spam they receive every day, and how many email newsletters they delete as soon as they open their inbox.

Then I say, “I’m sure you get a lot of spam, but don’t you have one or maybe two email newsletters you receive that you rely on? One or two emails that you always read and would never think of deleting?”

After they agree with me, I say, “Be one of those.”

Ann Handley has taken this approach with her popular writing newsletter, *Total Annarchy*. Ann says, “I am not a brand communicating with an audience, but I am Ann, one person communicating with one person.” Ann has it right, and businesses that continue to send out irrelevant, untargeted emails will continue to lose audience.

Subscribers sign up and share the newsletter with their colleagues in many cases because of their personal relationships with Ann. “When someone signs up for my newsletter, they get an auto-generated email from me that asks, ‘Why did you subscribe and what is it you hope to learn here?’ I track that and it clues me into what people expect from me so that I can create content that matches their needs. I love it when people respond to those questions and tell me who they are and what brought them here. Then I write back to them and they’re always like, what? Holy wow.”

AUTORESPONDERS MATTER

Most email programs include autoresponders, which are emails automatically generated based on subscriber behavior. Most autoresponders

occur after the initial subscription. For example, this might be a “Welcome to my community” letter. Oftentimes, open rates are high with these types of emails, so you have to make them count.

One of the best autoresponders I’ve seen comes from the business and technology newsletter *Morning Brew*. Over about a three-week time period, I became an avid reader of the newsletter. Then I received an email from the CEO of *Morning Brew*, shown in [Figure 13.4](#). Tactics like these don’t take much effort, but they have to be planned.

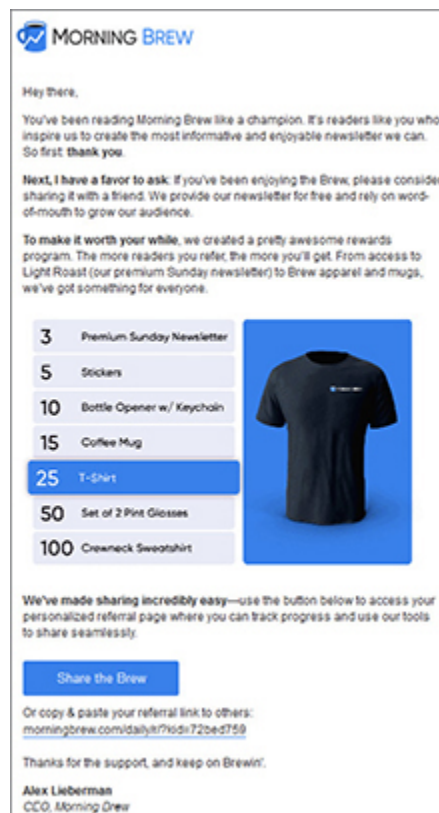


Figure 13.4 *Morning Brew* sends an automated email to subscribers who open a certain number of emails.

Other ways to enhance your subscription opportunities include:

- Ask only for an email address, or just a name and email address, for starters. Asking for too much information at first will damage your ability to gain subscribers.
- Promote subscriptions on your website and social platforms.

- Place subscription options in the footer of your email signature line. Do the same for all your employees.
- Don't clutter up your marketing by pushing possible subscribers to 15 different ways to connect. Focus on your email offering only, and put it everywhere that makes sense on your site and your social channels.

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[OceanofPDF.com](https://oceanofpdf.com)

CHAPTER 14

MAXIMUM FINDABILITY

The true delight is in the finding out rather than in the knowing.

ISAAC ASIMOV

While setting your content to be found is not rocket science, most companies don't do the small things necessary to be found by search engines and social media.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Matt Cutts, Google's former search evangelist, declared: "I firmly support the idea that people should have a diversified way of reaching their audience. So if you rely only on Google, that might not be as strong of an approach compared to having a wide variety of different avenues by which you can reach people and drive them to your website or whatever your objective is."

According to the Content Marketing Benchmark research from Content Marketing Institute and MarketingProfs, more marketers are focusing on content promotion than ever before. Why? Companies of all sizes are spending vast amounts of money on content creation, only to find out that no one is engaging in that content. Developing ongoing content without a clear strategy for content findability is no plan at all.

TAKE ADVANTAGE OF SEARCH ENGINE OPTIMIZATION

Getting your content found through search engines is the king of content findability. “Google is still my main acquisitor for audience,” says Philip Werner (SectionHiker.com).

For the *Content Inc.* model to be successful, you need to focus on search engine optimization at all times. When we started CMI, I believed that if I understood the basics of SEO and created valuable, shareable content, the content would be found in the organic search rankings. Although respectable traffic was coming to our site from search engines, getting more serious about SEO doubled our search results—and doubled our business in the process. Better yet, the majority of new subscribers came in through search engines rather than any other source. Needless to say, SEO is critical for your survival.

YOUR “HIT LIST” OF KEYWORDS

Every month CMI reviewed a “rolling list” of our top keyword phrases (like “content marketing” and “how to curate content”). For each phrase, we monitored our placement in Google ([Figure 14.1](#)), checked how we were doing against competitors, and determined how we were trending from the previous month (were we doing better or worse?).

CMI Editorial - Master Tracker									
File Edit View Insert Format Data Tools Add-ons Help All changes saved in Drive									
Google Feb. 2015 Rankings									
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1	UPDATED 1/15/15	Google Monthly Searches	Notes	Google Rankings - May 2014	Google Jan. 2015 Rankings	Feb. 2015 Rank	Google March 16, URL		
46	content ideas	179	new	10	14	18	14	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
47	content job	30	Original	6	3	2	2	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
48	content map	480	Original	5	6	3	4	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
49	content mapping	390	Original	2	2	2	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
50	content marketing	40500	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
51	content marketing agency	1200	Original	2	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
52	content marketing best practices	140	Original	1	3	1	2	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
53	content marketing blog	480	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
54	content marketing book	90	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
55	content marketing calendar	140	Original	4	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
56	content marketing guide	110	Original	6	4	6	5	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
57	content marketing job	60	Original	2	3	3	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
58	content marketing jobs	320	Original	2	2	2	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
59	content marketing news	210	Original	2	4	5	7	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
60	content marketing plan	480	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
61	content marketing process	70	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
62	content marketing role	140	Original	1	1	1	3	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
63	content marketing strategies	200	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
64	content marketing strategy	2400	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
65	content marketing tools	390	new	5	5	7	3	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
66	content optimization	390	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
67	content plan	390	Original	1	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
68	content planning	210	Original	2	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
69	content producer	590	Original	38	97	>200	>200	none	
70	content publisher	110	Original	9	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	
71	Content publishers	60	New	3	1	1	1	http://contentmarketinginstitute.com	

Figure 14.1 CMI tracked a rolling list of 50 keywords and the ongoing progress with each.

Your goal is to drive subscriptions from every page of content. Treat every page like a landing page, and monitor top pages for ways to increase traffic to a specific page, as well as increase the conversion of readers to subscribers.

How do we build a strategy for this concept? Mike Murray, president of Online Marketing Coach, explains how to integrate searches in the *Content Inc.* model.

If half of your traffic comes from organic search, where does the other half come from? Here are a number of tactics you should consider as part of your model.

12 KEYWORD SELECTION TIPS FOR SEO

By Mike Murray, Online Marketing Coach

Small business owners and entrepreneurs can ill afford to operate in the dark when it comes to keyword selection if they want to build an audience from search engine traffic.

Too often, owners take wild stabs with their keyword choices. Sure, they can occasionally guess well. But how often are their efforts a waste of time?

The good news is that you can attract some search engine visitors by constantly creating content even without an SEO strategy. With keywords, you could rank for an article or page because search engine algorithms value content.

You need to be realistic. Not every page or blog post will take you to the first position on Google (or other search engines). Maybe a keyword phrase with 10,000 searches a month will be out of reach. You can still get more out of SEO with just a bit of extra effort.

You can reference the following checklist as you consider what keywords to play up in your new content. Don't overlook opportunities to also update older articles and pages about your company.

- 1. Have I explored keyword research resources?** Check out Google Search Console, Google Trends, Soovle, Serpstat, Keyword Tool, and Ubersuggest. Even if you don't advertise on Google, get a Google Ads account to access the Keyword Planner. Paid tools include SEMrush, Moz Keyword Explorer, Wordtracker, KWFinder, and Ahrefs Keywords Explorer. I often use SEMrush, which suggests possible keywords that you may not have considered. It analyzes more than 200 million keywords in its US database, including data about competitors. Within a few minutes of using SEMrush, I can have an Excel spreadsheet filled with 30,000+ keyword variations (to help with content ideas).

You can make a list of keyword phrases, but search counts matter. Sometimes you can go after a keyword phrase that's the subject of 1,000 Google monthly searches. Quite often, you may want something less competitive. I don't rule out keyword phrases that are the subject of 50 searches a month. Many businesses sell products and annual services that cost \$10,000, \$25,000, \$50,000, or more. A keyword phrase with 50 monthly searches could be a real winner.

Keep in mind that every website has a sweet spot: the ranking zone where your website is likely to maximize its ranking. You can find that spot by correlating keyword rankings and average Google search volume for the same keywords you're using. In other words, if you typically rank in the top 10 positions on Google for keywords that have 100–500 monthly searches, that's your sweet spot. Why would you invest much time in keywords that are searched far more often? Target keyword phrases that are within striking distance.

- 2. Is the keyword phrase relevant?** Does the keyword phrase really match your products, services, and target audiences? Keyword specificity is paramount. Keep in mind that the keyword searches you discover may include unusual keyword combinations, such as "soccer uniforms youth." You can see how they rank, but proper sentence structure will force you to switch the order of the words. You can probably use two different spellings in some cases, but

avoid doing that on the same page. “Swing set” and “swingset” are one example.

Searcher intent also relates to relevance. Keyword phrases with words like “shipping” and “what are . . .” may indicate whether someone is close to buying or just seeking information.

3. **Am I buying this keyword phrase through paid search?** If you’re spending money on paid search (pay per click), the performance data can be helpful. But paying for those clicks won’t guarantee organic success for your small business. Only some of the keywords may do well. Depending on the conversions, you may see value in keeping a keyword phrase for both paid and natural search. Research what keywords competitors use for paid search as well. Use tools like SEMrush, SpyFu, and iSpionage.
4. **Am I already ranking for the keyword phrase?** Are you among the top 10, top 20, top 30, or far out at 99? Use tools like SEMrush, Advanced Web Ranking, and Moz to get ranking data. *Enterprise SEO Tools for Content Marketing, Search Intelligence, UX and More: A Marketer’s Guide* (Tenth Edition) explores different platforms that help manage, track, and optimize thousands of keywords (some are expensive, but some packages are affordable).
5. **Will my new page adequately mention the keyword phrase?** Although search engines detect themes or concepts, the outstanding content should still include your most strategic keyword phrases. Rankings will also be heavily influenced by the page title, page header, the number of pages, inbound links from other websites, and many other factors.
6. **How much traffic is my website receiving for the keyword phrase?** Unfortunately, Google started becoming encrypted in 2011, so Google Analytics conceals the actual keywords and phrases. But you can get considerable data from Google Search Console. I also track top landing pages in Google Analytics and compare them to custom ranking data in SEMrush to get a sense of how keyword phrases perform. Maybe someone searches for “Cleveland accounting firms,” but data analysis may prompt you to look at “accounting firms in Cleveland” or “Cleveland Ohio CPA firms.” You can work those phrases into existing content or new pages.

I always look at multiple keyword phrases that rank high on search engines. You may find that a single page could support “heating and cooling Dallas” and “Dallas heating cooling.”

However, you may need to create a new page for each phrase.

7. **Am I refining my keyword set?** Even after you create your keyword set, you should evaluate it based on your new keyword ideas, industry trends, the competition, your analytics, keywords you see on social media, and other sources. Don’t just make a note of words you come across. Think of variations as well.
8. **Is this keyword phrase (or similar phrases) already converting to a sales or sign-up page?** You can track keywords through your website analytics and conversion funnels, including e-commerce (connecting keywords and landing pages with product sales). Some businesses gain additional insights with call tracking services such as those offered by CallFire, CallRail, Marchex, and others.
9. **Are there calls to action on the page?** If you want a keyword phrase to pay off for your *Content Inc.* strategy, make sure the page has a compelling call to action. Can a visitor call a toll-free number, request a demo, download a guide, or request more information?
10. **Are there related pages that could support an internal link strategy?** A single page can rank well, but sometimes it helps to create several related pages, so search engines can determine that you’re emphasizing a similar set of keyword phrases. Cross-link the strategic keywords on several of your similar pages or posts.
11. **How will this keyword phrase choice fit into future content?** Your keyword selection options should be based on planned content for the weeks or months ahead, not just the content you already have. With a content calendar, consider any number of keyword possibilities before writing an article or creating a blog post.
12. **Is the keyword phrase in my domain name?** In 2012, Google decided to downgrade the importance of low-quality, exact-match domains for websites (meaning their rankings could be affected). I’m sure Google wanted to deal with domains such as the pretend site seocontentmarketingtipsforsmallbusinessmarketers.com that are used as clickbait sites only. However, for most websites, the

domain name still seems to have a positive effect on search engine rankings.

MAKE GUEST APPEARANCES IN OPC

OPC is short for “other people’s content.” The more your thinking gets spread around in OPC, the more chances you will have to attract new people to your site and build subscribers. As you develop better relationships with influencers (sites where your audience hangs out), one of your goals is to find the opportunity to help those influencers with their content. That could mean developing a guest blog post for them or guest-starring in a webinar for their audience.

For the past decade, I’ve written original or repurposed articles for more than 500 different websites. At the same time, I’ve participated in 20 to 30 outside webinars a year. These two activities have been critical to my success. How do I know? Readers come to the CMI site from more than 3,000 different places every month. Much of that diversity is because we share content on other people’s sites.

CREATE MORE LISTS WITH YOUR CONTENT

Though overused in industry articles, lists get found and shared. As a result, more people blog and link to that content, making it easier to find the content in search engines. CMI’s best-performing content is almost always a numbered list ([Figure 14.2](#)).

Current Hits	All Time Hits
	9 Little-Known Font How-Tos for Instagram Stories August 31, 2020
	How to Create Pillar Content Google Will Love August 10, 2020
	10+ Buzzwords to Banish From Your Content Marketing Vocabulary August 6, 2020
	2021 B2B Content Marketing: What Now? [New Research] September 30, 2020
	8 Habits You Should Have for Quality Content Marketing September 3, 2020
	How Content Marketing Can Save Your Digital Marketing Strategy August 3, 2020
	6 Things to Improve Your Content Performance July 15, 2020

Figure 14.2 Like it or not, lists and numbers work in articles and blog posts.

CREATE UNIQUE RESEARCH

It's not even close. Original research specific to your target audience is like cheese to a mouse. If this could be an opportunity for you, be sure you plan your research as an ongoing series, like quarterly or annually. That means every time the research is released, you may have something new to talk about.

ANSWER QUESTIONS AT QUORA

Quora is a question-and-answer platform. Most likely, possible subscribers are asking questions that you may be able to answer, again showing your expertise and driving people to your website.

SYNDICATE YOUR CONTENT

Syndicating your content means you actively place your articles on other people's sites. In the past, many have thought that search engines like Google penalize your site for duplicate content. Google says this isn't true, saying "Let's put this to bed once and for all, folks: There's no such thing as a 'duplicate content penalty.'"

Michael Brenner, author and marketing speaker, believes that content syndication is an untapped opportunity. He says:

At SAP, I built an award-winning content marketing hub and started it with little budget. How do you build a content hub on a small budget? You need an army of volunteer content contributors.

I did this by syndicating content from other experts (mostly employees, to start) with their permission. When I started showing business results and my budgets increased, I added licensed content as well as additional paid original content.

Licensing your content to other sites (syndication) may make sense as a way to give you the added distribution you need. Even though I believe original content creation is the number one option for *Content Inc.* models to grow, syndicating other people's content may be something to consider until your content factory is in full gear.

LEVERAGE HARO

Help a Reporter Out, or HARO, is a site for journalists and reporters looking for expert content sources. I've used HARO for the past few years and received placement in the *New York Times* because of it.

MAKE SURE MOST OF YOUR CONTENT IS UNGATED

A few years back I conducted a workshop for some of the leading trade associations in the world. The majority of them were struggling with getting their content found on the web. Why? Because 90 percent of their content was only accessible to members, who had to log in to access the content.

This means that 90 percent of their content went unnoticed by search engines, and users who liked the content couldn't share it on social media.

According to noted author and speaker David Meerman Scott's personal statistics, a white paper or e-book of his will be downloaded at least 20 times more and up to 50 times more without a gate in front of it. You get better results without a lead form in front of downloadable content.

Yes, you want certain content assets with a form in front of them to grow your subscriber lists (such as content that people would gladly pay for), but the vast majority of your content needs to be easily accessible to your audience, enhancing both search and social media sharing opportunities.

TRY BRANDSCAPING

Brandscaping, according to Andrew Davis, is “a collection of brands working together to produce great content.” Think of an example where you have great content, but you need additional marketing exposure. Or possibly someone in your industry has some amazing research that you really want to share with your audience. In these cases, perhaps a partnership makes sense.

When I first launched my *Content Inc.* business, I barely had an audience. I reached out to a large media company and a large association, with promises to do a research report if they would send it out to their audiences. Today that little research project is in its fifteenth year of existence and has generated millions in revenue.

TEST YOUR TITLES

Upworthy, one of the fastest-growing sites on the web, focuses on sharing and curating content that (it believes) uplifts humanity. Upworthy has more than 16 million subscribers and upward of 125 million monthly video views.

What accounts for the extraordinary number of visits? According to Upworthy, “It was because millions of members of the Upworthy community watched the videos we curated and found them important, compelling, and worth sharing with their friends.”

How does Upworthy get people to open its emails to watch the videos and then share them with friends? The Upworthy staff is meticulous about its headlines. For each article, Upworthy writes a minimum of 25 different headlines. Then the company does various A/B tests with its subscription lists to see which headline led to the most email opens and the most shares. Once Upworthy finds the best performer, the company distributes that winning headline to the entire email database.

CONSIDER PAID CONTENT DISTRIBUTION OPTIONS

Before you gain organic (nonpaid) search traction and build a massive audience of subscribers, your content may need a boost to gain readership. Paid content distribution strategies are a completely acceptable way to acquire new subscribers. Here are a couple to consider:

- **Pay-per-click.** Until you can be found via target keywords on search engines, it may make sense to pay for promotion. Pay-per-click (PPC) lets you promote your content on search engines, paying Google, Bing, or another search site every time someone clicks on your link. PPC charges can range from 5 cents for less popular keyword phrases up to \$10 per click for popular searches (like “mesothelioma”).
- **Content discovery/recommendation tools.** Services like Outbrain/Taboola and nRelate form partnerships with media and blogging sites. For a fee, they will promote your content on the sites of your choosing. As with PPC, the service charges you every time someone clicks on your story. The biggest difference between PPC and content recommendation tools is that the content *has* to be in the form of an interesting story in a recommendation tool, or the services won’t show it. Content recommendation tools have received some bad press in the last few years (because of clickbait stories), but as always, quality content prevails.

ADVERTISE ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Almost every social website, including Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, and Instagram, accepts advertising. Each service lets you target very specific audiences with your content.

Just before I published this book, my goal was to significantly increase the number of subscribers to my personal email newsletter. After a very successful Facebook advertising program for my novel, *The Will to Die*, I decided to create a free book for marketers called *Corona Marketing*, which directed interested marketers back to my website (Figure 14.3). In exchange for the book, I asked visitors to sign up and try out my email newsletter.



Figure 14.3 There is nothing wrong with leveraging social media advertising, as long as the content giveaway is truly valuable.

I ran a 10-second video explaining the importance, paying for it to run on Facebook in August 2020. The paid results from running the advertisement included:

- 787 confirmed emails added to the mailing list at a cost of \$0.96 each.
- 2,957 emails added at a cost of \$0.26 each.
- 476,000 new people reached.
- 5,400 landing page views at a cost of \$0.14 per view.

These are all good numbers, and the 787 emails added to the subscriber list at less than \$1 each was a steal. Advertising offers can work if the content giveaway is a real value and you are up front about the trade you're offering subscribers.

USE NEWS RELEASE SERVICES

Services such as Cision and Marketwire will take your press release and distribute it to the media sites you choose for additional promotion. Remember, there is no set format. You can be as creative as you can to get attention among the thousands of other releases sent out that day. Tell the story you want to tell, and target it at the media sites that make the most sense.

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CHAPTER 15

STEALING AUDIENCE

Influencer marketing is getting others to share your story,
generate interest, and make your case.

ARDATH ALBEE

Most businesses that leverage an influencer strategy do not have a defined process. When you execute your influencer strategy, do it with a specific group and cadence of content sharing. Why? You want the influencer's audience to be your audience.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Some marketing professionals might call this chapter “influencer marketing,” but I’d rather just tell it like it is. The goal of building a relationship with an influencer (an influence is the place where the people in your audience are hanging out on the web if they are not on your site) is to steal the influencer’s audience and make it yours. (I say this in the nicest way possible.)

Right now, the people who make up your audience are not just standing around waiting for your content. They are actively involved and engaged in mobile, video, audio, and textual content for informational or entertainment purposes. If you are going to break through, you need to take that attention and direct it toward your content. This is not an easy task.

This chapter is all about helping you do just that: steal audience!

MAKING THE CASE

It's a pretty straightforward concept when you think about it:

- Influencers have a *preestablished audience* that is already receptive to their ideas and recommendations. Your target audience values them.
- Influencers have a built-in level of *trust* with their readers. The hope is, these influencers will help you build credibility.
- They can help you *create the content* that really meets your consumers' needs, because they have on-the-ground experience and perspective.
- By partnering *with them*, you're able to get your content and messaging out in the right way, at the right time, to the right people.

The ultimate goal is to build and expand your own audience.

WHAT'S YOUR GOAL?

Just as you need a strategy for your *Content Inc.* program, you also need a strategy for your influencer marketing program. Before launching your influencer program, you need to clearly understand and document what you specifically want to accomplish. How will your influencer program help you achieve your business goals, and how will it lead to audience building?

Some potential objectives to consider as a starting point to build your own list of goals:

- **Brand awareness.** How many people viewed, downloaded, or listened to this piece of content because of the influencer?
- **Engagement.** How resonant is this content, and how often is it shared with others? How is the influencer helping to increase sharing?
- **Lead generation.** How is the influencer helping to convert people into valuable subscribers?
- **Sales.** Did you make money because of this content shared by the influencer? What revenue or ROI (return on investment) can you

apply to this program?

- **Customer retention and loyalty.** How can an influencer help retain a customer?
- **Up-sell or cross-sell.** Is there a way to use an influencer to help someone become more invested in your business?

IDENTIFY INFLUENCER TYPES

The type of influencer you need depends on your specific objective. For example, if your aim is awareness and a broad reach, you may choose a larger number of influencers to work with who can all produce “bite-sized” pieces of content to increase your share of voice. But if you are looking to retain customers or up-sell, you may want to use other clients as influencers.

HOW CAN YOU IDENTIFY THE RIGHT INFLUENCERS?

Influencers can come in many different forms. From inside your organization outward, they can take the form of:

- Bloggers
- Social media celebrities (industry specific)
- Customers
- Members of a purchasing group
- Industry experts and analysts
- Business partners
- Internal team members or experts
- Media sites

From these groups you will form your influencer hit list.

HOW TO MANAGE THE PROGRAM

Now that you've established what you're trying to achieve with your influencer marketing program and whom you'd ideally like to reach, you will have a better understanding of whether or not you have the right resources in-house to do the work needed. Some things to consider:

- How much capacity does your internal team have for taking on a pilot group of influencers?
- Do you have any tools available in-house (ones you use for social listening, content management, etc.) that you can leverage for an influencer marketing program? See the following sidebar “Recommended Listening Tools” for suggestions.

When you fully understand your internal capabilities, you'll be able to determine what size program you can manage and identify what other resources you'll need to engage and deploy the program that will meet your objectives.

RECOMMENDED LISTENING TOOLS

- Agorapulse
- BuzzSumo
- Sprout Social
- SparkToro

CREATE CONTENT WORTH SHARING

In order to get influencers to work with you, to truly *partner with you*, in amplifying your content, you're going to need something crucial: *compelling and relevant content*. Time and time again, influencers will push back on brands for forcing overly promotional messages onto their hard-earned sites, because authenticity is the piece that keeps trust between them and their readers. No one—not even your brand—is worth jeopardizing

that. As Andy Newbom says, “Create something for influencers to influence on.”

BUILD YOUR HIT LIST OF INFLUENCERS

Does your influencer marketing program ever feel like a spiraling rabbit hole? It’s because there are so many potential paths you can take, and the potential pool size of influencers to tap into can feel somewhat overwhelming. Here’s what typically runs through an entrepreneur’s mind when beginning such a program:

- To whom do we even reach out?
- How do I know “who’s good” and who has powerful influence?
- How do I manage influencers once I start working with them?

These unknowns can feel daunting for any team, of any size and any level of experience. To help get you started, these are the next *three steps*:

1. Build a small pool of potential partners and learn more about them.
2. Begin your influencer outreach.
3. Test, assess, and optimize.

The first thing to do in building your pool of influencers, after setting your objectives and identifying the influencer “types” with whom you want to work, is to *sit back and listen*. Sounds pretty passive, but taking the time to truly understand what your potential influencer’s focal points are will be crucial in understanding how you can work together.

To start, consider building a template that will help you keep track of the top people with whom you’d like to work. It’s likely you already have some kind of list, but having a consistent way to keep track of them and assess them is an important place to start.

Your scoring can be a little bit more “gut based” as you read through the influencers’ work. This brings up a very important part of this process: *read your potential influencers’ work!* Read their articles, see how they respond to comments, review their tweets/posts, and really get a sense of what

matters most to them. To gauge the level and extent of their influence, you can also see who is responding to their work and following them—all good things to incorporate in your spreadsheet as well. Their audience members may be potential influencers, too.

WAYS TO IDENTIFY POTENTIAL INFLUENCERS

Amanda Maksymiw from Fuze suggests these steps to build your list of influencers:

- Use your listening tools to identify people talking about certain topics based on keywords.
- Ask your customers or others in your industry (never underestimate the power of word of mouth).
- Search on social media platforms, especially LinkedIn.
- Network like crazy. Attend events in different areas—get out of your bubble. Talk to customers, partners, and salespeople.
- Ask peers in your marketing, product development, or sales teams.
- Ask other influencers. You'd be surprised about how many of your top-tier influencers work together and recommend each other.
- Get involved in the forums and discussion boards/groups discussing your content. Joining Twitter chats, participating in webinars, and even reading through the latest industry reports or blog posts can quickly make you aware of the key players in your space.

HOW MANY INFLUENCERS SHOULD YOU ADD TO YOUR POOL?

The answer to this question will depend heavily on how you respond to the earlier “How to Manage the Program” section. But to start, and for efficiency, most people lean toward 5 to 10 influencers as a manageable starting point.

BEGIN OUTREACH

Once you've identified a potential pool of influencers and you've spent enough time reading through their work to want to take the next step toward outreach, take a few minutes to consider:

- How will you reach out to this person?
- What can you offer that is valuable?
- What exactly are you looking for from this relationship?

This is where all that time spent reviewing the person's work will pay off. Sending a generic, impersonal request to a top-tier influencer will be ignored. Remember, this is a two-way relationship. Gone are the days when companies could throw money or samples at bloggers and expect them to fawn over the brand. Influencers have the ability to be much more selective, and they expect to be respected for the talent (and audience) they bring to your projects.

SOCIAL MEDIA 4-1-1

Social Media 4-1-1 is a sharing system that helps a company get greater visibility with social influencers. I recommend using this as a first-approach method before directly emailing an influencer. Here's how it works.

For every six pieces of content shared via social media (such as Twitter):

- Four are pieces of content from your influencer target that are also relevant to your audience. This means that 67 percent of the time you are sharing content that is not yours—and calling attention to content from your influencer group.
- One piece can be your original, educational content.
- One piece can be your sales piece, such as a coupon, product notice, or press release.

The numbers don't have to be exact. It's the philosophy that makes this work. When you share influencers' content, they notice. You should share

without asking for anything in return (for a month or so), so that when you do need something, the influencers are more likely to say yes.

Consistency is key to making this work. Take your pilot list of 5 to 10 influencers and share each influencer's content at least once a day for a month.

MAKING THE FIRST CONNECTION

There are a few ways you can start to make connections with your target influencers:

- Give them some social media love, either through a reply, retweet, or mention (use the Social Media 4-1-1 plan).
- Provide *thoughtful* comments on their blog posts.
- Connect with them on LinkedIn, introducing yourself and explaining why you'd like to connect.
- When it makes sense, shoot over an email with your partnership idea.

I've found that if you continually share and reply to someone on his or her social channels (say, for 30 days or more), that person will be receptive to more direct contact. The key to your outreach is not to seem like you're asking for a favor, but rather to suggest a collaboration that takes into account the person's skills first and your needs second.

NURTURE INFLUENCER RELATIONSHIPS

After you've started making connections with your targeted influencers, you may feel more comfortable asking to work together in different ways, such as:

- Requesting that they cocreate content *with you*
- Requesting custom content created exclusively for your platforms
- Asking influencers to share your content on their platforms

Here are some potential projects to work on with your new influencers:

1. Ask for a quote for an article.
2. Request to speak at a conference.
3. Ask to join or be a guest on a Twitter chat or webinar.
4. Provide a quote for an e-book.
5. Gather responses on a specific topic for a crowdsourced blog post.
6. Request permission to share some of their content inside one of your e-books or white papers.
7. Request information or data for a case study.
8. Ask to write a guest blog post or be featured in one.
9. Include them in an expert panel at an industry event.
10. Ask to be a guest on a podcast.

If none of this works for you, simply start mentioning the influencer inside your blog posts, podcasts, research reports, videos, etc. The best way to get influencers curious is by not asking for anything. Just let them know you've included them in your content if they'd like to check it out. They usually do.

HOW FAR CAN YOUR CONTENT GO?

Consider the scalability of the content you're creating together. Just as you execute with your *Content Inc.* strategy, your influencer program needs legs that extend beyond a single point-in-time campaign. For example:

- Consider rounding up monthly guest blog posts into quarterly e-books.
- If you've had a series of influencers host webinars or podcasts, gather those into robust resource guides.
- Put together a collection of quotes or insights from your influencers, and consolidate those quotes and ideas into best-practice articles or roundtable posts.

Nathaniel Whittemore owns one of the largest podcasts in the cryptocurrency space. A partnership with a media company made all the difference in growing his audience.

Coindesk, one of the leading crypto media companies, was considering building out a podcast network at the same time Whittemore launched his daily podcast, *The Breakdown*. The two entities formed a partnership where Coindesk sold ad placements and also distributed the show across the Coindesk network. “For me, the partnership was largely about building bigger distribution from day one,” says Whittemore.

Since the partnership started, downloads have grown more than a thousand percent, and the platform has more than 300,000 monthly downloads. On growing the podcast, Whittemore recommends consistency and differentiation:

First, doing a daily [podcast] has definitely been differentiating for the show, and it’s surprising to me just how many people listen every day. Second is that I think content creators in general don’t spend quite enough time really figuring out their exact differentiation or niche. *The Breakdown* is the only podcast of its type in crypto or macro that is primarily based around me just talking directly to the mic, without a guest. I never have more than 2–3 guests a week and there are 7 shows a week, so understanding that thing that made it different was really important.

ASSESS AND OPTIMIZE THE PROGRAM

Although it will take time and effort on your part, eventually you get to a place with your influencers where a true relationship exists. Asking for content sharing will no longer feel like a favor, because you put in the effort to show that you truly respect and value their contributions beyond their audience reach. Now is the time to throw in some relationship-building efforts to further solidify your loyalty. For example, you can invite your influencers to an exclusive event, ask for input on a new product or service before anyone else, crowdsource ideas with them as a pilot group, or send them small tokens of appreciation, like a gift card for coffee or handwritten thank you notes.

These actions will make them feel as valued and unique as you already know they are. (It never hurts to remember their birthdays, too.)

MEASURING THE PROGRAM

Here's an idea of how to set up your KPIs (key performance indicators) depending on the objectives you established at the onset of your program:

Objective	Possible Metrics
Brand awareness	Website traffic Page views Video views Document views Downloads Social chatter Referral links
Engagement	Blog comments Likes, shares, tweets Forwards Inbound links
Lead generation and nurturing	Form completions and downloads Email subscriptions Blog subscriptions Conversion rate
Sales	Online sales Offline sales Manual reporting and anecdotes
Customer retention and loyalty	Percentage of content consumed by existing customers Retention and renewal rates
Up-sell or cross-sell	Sales for new products or services

Regardless of what you choose to measure, be on the lookout for areas of potential improvement, especially in the beginning. No program is perfect, and the ability to grow a truly robust influencer marketing program takes a lot of time and effort. By showing more than just your superficial successes, you'll demonstrate the thoughtfulness you put behind growing these working relationships into something meaningful for your company. It's not always pretty and, like any relationship, can mean some give-and-take for everyone involved. But in the end, these strong voices, projecting your company messages for you, without solicitation, will have an ROI that far exceeds that from many of the other programs in your marketing mix.

Riot's 2020 launch, Valorant, a first-person shooter game, debuted on April 7. That day alone it hit 1.7 million concurrent views. Since then, the game has set the Twitch record for 34 million hours watched in one day.

Here's how Riot made it happen:

One platform. Instead of making the Valorant feeds available on all sharing channels, the company focused only on Twitch. Riot put all its energy into one channel.

This is exactly what you should do with your content creation and distribution. Focus on being great on one channel first.

Long-term influencer relationships. Riot Games has been focusing on its influencer relationships for years. It's maybe the most important thing the company does (besides the game). For the launch, it reached out to influencers with large audiences and also ones with small, loyal subscribers. The company offered no payment, only the chance to play the game early.

So many companies focus on their influencers only when they need them. Riot communicates with them consistently and truly tries to build a relationship with them. For Riot, biggest isn't always best. It focuses on smaller influencers as well.

Access for watch time. In order for noninfluencers to get a beta key to play the game, they had to log a certain amount of watch hours of Valorant on Twitch. My son watched for more than 50 hours and finally got his key (don't judge!).

This is from my son: "Riot Games partnered with multiple hundreds of streamers to have them stream the closed beta, and then after watching for a certain period of time, one could be eligible for a beta key themselves, though pretty random. So the top streamers will keep streaming this game, because the viewers are watching to get a key, and you can flip that around. The game broke a ton of records, and the game feels relatively exclusive to play as well. It's pretty interesting."

What a reward for your best customers! Those that watched the most got access to the game. Any company could do something like this for

loyal subscribers.

MY FIRST INFLUENCER PROGRAM

Just like for any other *Content Inc.* program, I had an audience of zero when I started my base, a blog called the *Content Marketing Revolution*. To start to build an audience, I began by trying to form relationships with key industry influencers.

To give these influencers visibility, we created a list we called “Top 42 Content Marketing Blogs.” Initially, this list was made up of influencers we found by tracking keywords (like “content marketing”) in Google Alerts, authors in industry trade publications, those that were talking about the topic on Twitter, and other bloggers that we just found interesting. The initial list, as its name indicated, included 42 influencers.

GETTING THE ATTENTION OF INFLUENCERS

Influencers are important people. They generally have real jobs and are extremely active on social networks, spending their time sharing content and blogging. Getting on their radar is not easy. So to get their attention, we gave away content gifts. We did this in a few different ways.

First, we used the Social Media 4-1-1 method described above. We executed this program for months. Our team continually added to and amended our top content marketing blogger list. We then decided we could get better visibility with influencers by actually ranking them publicly and sharing the rankings with the masses. This was an incredible success.

We hired an outside research expert to put together a ranking methodology for the top bloggers, looking at areas such as consistency, style, helpfulness, originality, and a few other details. Then each quarter, we publicized the list, showcased the top 10, sent out a press release, and made a big deal out of it. Needless to say, the top 10 and the honored top 42 loved the list. Not only did most of this influencer group share the list with their audiences; approximately half of the top 42 influencers placed our widget

(with personal rank of that particular influencer) on their home page, linking back to our site. Not only were we building long-term relationships with these influencers, but we were getting credible links and traffic as well.

In addition to the top bloggers list, we started to put together large educational e-books showcasing the influencers' work: for example, the *Content Marketing Playbook*. The playbook included more than 40 case studies about content marketing, with many coming directly from our influencers. We made sure to note which examples came from which influencers.

When we released the playbook and let the influencers know about the publication, the majority of influencers we highlighted in the playbook eagerly shared the content with their audiences. It's important to note that all the information we shared in the publication was either "fair use" material and properly cited or used with the influencer's permission.

Since then, most of the people on our original influencer list have become active contributors in the CMI community. Some started writing blog posts, others participated in our weekly Twitter chats, others became speakers at our events, and still others went on to write books and e-books for us. Maybe the best part, half of our original top 10 influencers are now good friends of mine. Needless to say, it's been an incredible success.

Who says stealing doesn't pay?

RESOURCES

Interviews by Joe Pulizzi:

Adam Pulizzi, September 2020.

Nathaniel Whittemore, October 2020.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 16

SOCIAL MEDIA SELECTION

Social media is not about the exploitation of technology, but
service to community.

SIMON MAINWARING

You don't have to be active on every social channel. At the start, choose the best two or three and put resources behind just those.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

For a time, social media and content creation may have seemed interchangeable, but they are actually quite different. Though there can be quite a bit of overlap, the easiest way to think about their relationship is that content is needed to drive social media, while social media is most essential during two key content marketing processes:

- Listening to the people in your audience to understand what they care about, so you can create content that they will find engaging and relevant
- Distributing content from your business, as well as from others—i.e., the Social Media 4-1-1 approach

You really can't have one without the other.

If you are just getting serious about your social media distribution efforts, it's best to start small. Consider the top social platforms used in your industry niche (Instagram, Pinterest, YouTube, etc.), and see where the largest concentration of your target audience members is congregating.

FOCUS

B2B companies are traditionally hesitant about, say, Pinterest; yet if you really double down and focus on Pinterest as a key strategy, I'm absolutely sure you can make that work. It's just a question of where are you going to direct your resources best for having a real potential to engage with the community better.

TODD WHEATLAND, MARKETING AUTHOR AND SPEAKER

Choose the channels where you can build and engage with a genuine community, and focus your attention on those. Study what others are doing in this space, so you can learn what people respond to the most favorably. By "others," I don't mean your competition, but rather anyone who may be taking your audience's attention away from your social media content (such as your influencer group). Ask yourself how you can be more useful or entertaining than other content providers.

TEST

While it makes sense to choose the primary channels you will focus on, the landscape is changing quickly, and it's important to experiment to keep your social media content efforts fresh and current. As Airbnb's former chief marketing officer Jonathan Mildenhall told us at Content Marketing World, "If you don't have room to fail, you don't have a way to grow."

It doesn't make sense to start using a platform simply because it's become trendy or because your competitors have a presence there. But don't let fear of failure stop you from trying something new. Follow these recommendations to guide you in your decisions:

- *Don't* sign up for an account without having a plan for what you will do there.
- *Do* prioritize the channels you want to experiment with, and spend a dedicated amount of time to test out what works and learn from what doesn't. You may discover something new about your audience, or you may learn that it's not a priority channel for your business.
- *Less is always more.* Be great at one or two channels instead of mediocre at four or five.

CUSTOMIZE

A Facebook post should be very different than one on Pinterest, or Twitter, or LinkedIn. For many creators, though, it's just "Ugh, just put it all out, because you've got the tool, so you do it and you hit send so it goes to all your channels."

MICHAEL WEISS, SPEAKER AND CONTENT MARKETING STRATEGIST

The easiest way to turn off your community members is to broadcast the same message across multiple channels. Instead, determine the kind of content that interests the members of your community in a way that is useful to them. Plan ahead to make sure you are leveraging your content assets in multiple ways, but are still communicating it differently on your preferred distribution channels.

SOCIAL AND OTHER CHANNELS

Here's a quick overview and my recommendation for each major social media channel. Remember, you should leverage social media to develop audiences, but you do not get direct access to them. That's the domain of the platform, such as Facebook or YouTube. You should be using social media to ultimately drive people back to content offers, so you can grow your email subscription lists.

In most *Content Inc.* examples, the business has the base plus two or three social channels that drive interest in them, and thus back to the base. For example, Joe Rogan built his base as an audio podcast, with active engagement on YouTube, Twitter, and Instagram. He ignored TikTok.

Many social media platforms are available. The ones I've noted are far and away the most important global examples.

FACEBOOK

As of the second quarter of 2020, Facebook had more than 2.7 billion users, making it the largest social network on the planet. Facebook matters. Most likely, a large portion of your audience uses Facebook.

That said, Facebook is my least favorite platform for secondary audience building. *Content Inc.* superstars Electric House (United Kingdom) and SalatTøsen (Denmark) built their audiences on Facebook years before Facebook started fiddling with its algorithms. It's much more challenging today.

The biggest potential is from Facebook groups, which Facebook has been pushing over the past few years. The best-case scenario might be to forgo building your personal audience on Facebook and instead build an ultraspecific group as a gathering place for your community.

Alessandra Torre created the Facebook group Alessandra Torre Inkers, which now boasts more than 11,000 members. Even an average group question gets up to 100 comments. The group has been key to Alessandra growing her online training offerings and in-person/virtual events.

TWITTER

Twitter has become the official broadcasting tool of the web. How do you make your story stand out on Twitter? Here are some tips to follow:

- Tell a story through your tweets. Present a consistent voice to tell the story of your industry and your brand. Each post should be compelling in its own right, but be sure to use a consistent voice. In addition, many people tell a longer-form story through Twitter by breaking up tweets (usually by numbering them).

- Make use of hashtags. Including one to three relevant hashtags with your tweet makes it simple for people to find your content. (For example, CMI uses #cmworld to tag content all year long.)
- Use it as a testing ground. Tweet your original content, and keep tabs on which pieces of content get more shares. Use this information to direct your future content efforts.
- Cover industry events. Tweet live coverage of events to offer insights in real time to your audience. That way, your brand can act as the eyes and ears for individuals who can't make it to the events.

Jack Butcher from Visualize Value dominated Twitter in a very short time ([Figure 16.1](#)). He writes continually on the platform, and it has paid off, with more than 50,000 followers. He sometimes reaches 1 million impressions from just one tweet. Every other day people will tell Jack that they signed up for his paid service because of his tweets.



Figure 16.1 Jack Butcher has built a loyal audience on Twitter with short, consistently thoughtful tweets.

LINKEDIN

LinkedIn has become so much more than a company Rolodex. It is perhaps the most powerful business publishing platform on the web ([Figure 16.2](#)). Anyone on LinkedIn can publish short updates (like those on Facebook) or

full-scale articles that, if they are compelling, have a strong chance to go viral (again, depending on the algorithms).



Figure 16.2 Since starting to publish on LinkedIn, I've increased my followers by more than 200,000.

Here are some tips if you intend to publish:

- Understand what audience you'd like to target on LinkedIn, and publish content there to attract that audience to your subscription offerings.
- Take full advantage of your profile by embedding your LinkedIn SlideShare (like PowerPoint) presentations and YouTube videos. Link to all your content resources.
- Do an audit of your team's profile to make sure each employee is representing the company properly.

LinkedIn groups are still very compelling, but have fallen to a distant second place behind Facebook's group innovations.

INSTAGRAM

Instagram is the most dominant image-sharing social media site, with more than 1 billion users. The original platform launched as a photo-sharing site, but by adding Instagram Stories in 2016, the company has supercharged the platform. Per Hootsuite, Instagram Stories are “a camera-first full screen visual format that disappears after 24 hours, modelled after Snapchat, that doesn’t show up in the Instagram news feed. This means that users can post easily and rapidly to their followers without worrying about overloading them.” According to Instagram, 500,000 people use Instagram Stories every day.

In addition, Instagram recently launched Reels, specifically to compete with TikTok. Reels gives users the ability to create 15- to 30-second video shorts with music.

Quinn Tempest has developed an amazing education and consulting business targeting women entrepreneurs on Instagram ([Figure 16.3](#)). “They’re looking for inspiration and they’re looking for education. [I use Instagram to] not only inspire them to build momentum and to dig deeper into their why and their purpose, but give them tactics and education as well as the mindset shifts they need to embody in order to create their purpose. I do a series called Tip Tuesday every week where I do a little educational tip.”



Figure 16.3 Quinn Tempest has earned a loyal following in a short period of time through consistent, focused Instagram posts.

Quinn has slightly more than 10,000 followers on Instagram, and proves that you don't need a huge audience to be successful with *Content Inc.*

PINTEREST

Pinterest is an extremely popular photo-sharing site with more than 330 million users. It lets you actively manage your own photos, plus share images and videos from others. The posted pictures are called “pins,” and there are currently more than 200 billion pins on the platform. It's been extremely popular in the retail space (25- to 34-year-old women represent the largest audience group), and it has started to grow into other areas over the past few years. Interested in seeing if Pinterest can work for you? Here are some ideas that will help:

- **Post videos, not just images.** Videos are powerful (and pinnable). If you have a strong repertoire of video content, use Pinterest to drive traffic back to your website or YouTube channel.
- **Show your customers some love.** Strengthen relationships, highlight success stories, and drive more traffic by creating a board showing off the achievements of your customers. It's a great way to illustrate your work without much braggadocio. Remember to leverage your hashtags when you do.
- **Share your reading list.** Share book recommendations that are relevant to your audience to establish a stronger bond. Leveraging books that you've actually read helps demonstrate your brand's commitment to constant improvement.
- **Show your company personality.** Instead of a lone product image or a posed staff picture, show your product or team in action for an image with more personality. Action shots help the people in your audience imagine themselves as a customer or client.

Kristen Bor, founder of *Bearfoot Theory*, says that after Google, Pinterest drives the second most traffic to her website ([Figure 16.4](#)). “We make sure we have a nice-looking Pinterest image in every blog post, refreshed periodically as well. We just did a full rebrand on our site. We're

now going back and making new Pinterest images for a lot of our popular content.”

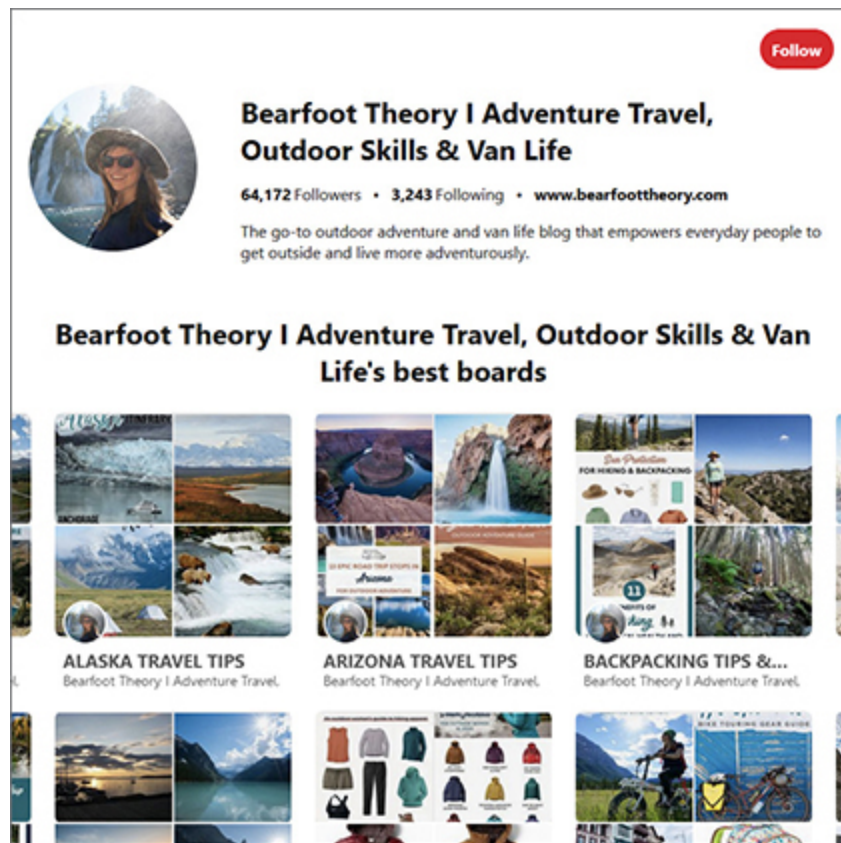


Figure 16.4 Pinterest is an incredibly powerful social media tool that most entrepreneurs overlook.

YOUTUBE

I’ve listed YouTube here because it is indeed a social media network, but I believe the best opportunities on YouTube are as a platform, as we’ve seen with Matthew Patrick and Ann Reardon. If you choose to share content on YouTube outside the platform model, consider the following:

- YouTube is the number two search engine in the world, so developing content specifically for search findability is something you need to focus on.
- Whatever content you decide to publish on YouTube, do it consistently, just as you would on any other platform. The majority of

companies publish without any particular schedule, which never works in building an audience.

While searching for possible keynotes for our event Content Marketing World in 2016, I stumbled on comedian Michael Jr.'s YouTube platform. I was immediately drawn to his comedy, which focuses on discovering your life's purpose through funny stories.

“We use comedy to help people understand that even their setbacks in life can be used as part of their setup, so they can deliver what they're called to deliver,” says Michael. How does he present this online? Through YouTube (Figure 16.5).

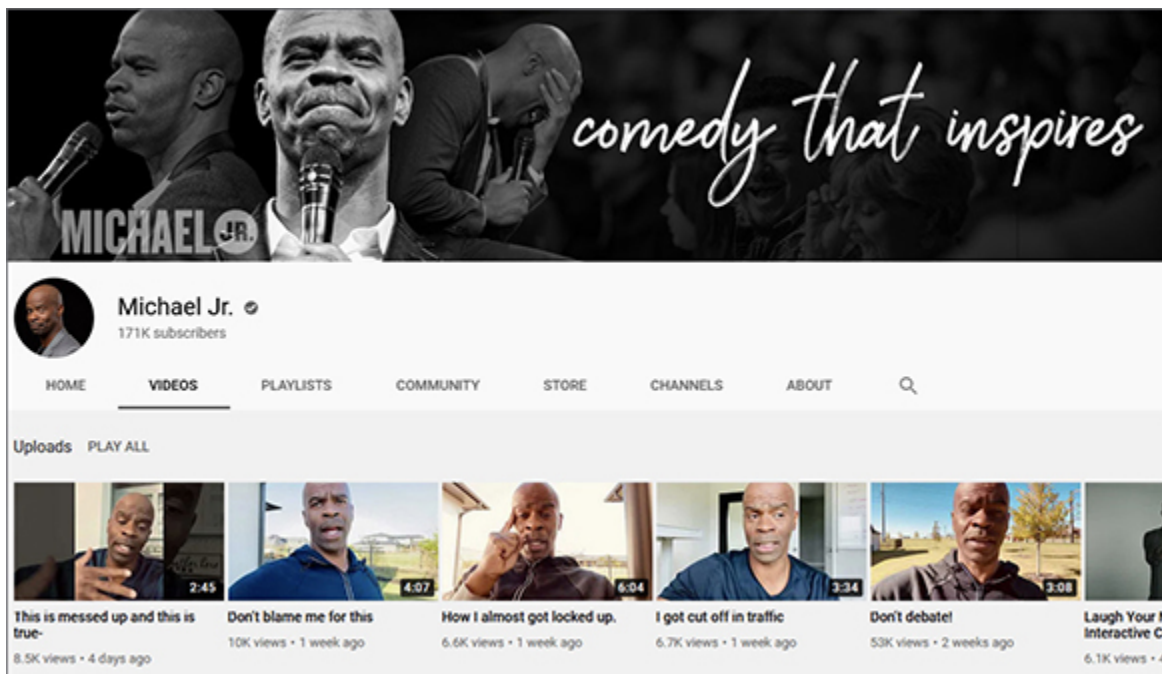


Figure 16.5 Michael Jr.'s short and simple YouTube posts have generated him over 170,000 subscribers.

Michael started a YouTube comedy show called *Break Time* in 2015. From there, he's diversified his channel offerings to include his stand-up short videos ("How to Turn on an Apple Computer" and "How to Erase a Whiteboard"), posts his *Off the Cuff* podcasts, and posts a regular series called *I Was Wondering*, each one with its own dedicated section on his YouTube page. All in all, Michael Jr. has grown his YouTube channel to nearly 200,000 subscribers.

Michael Jr. is now going big with his movie, called *Selfie Dad*, and his online comedy courses called Funny How Life Works. Michael Jr.'s YouTube leverage made this possible.

MEDIUM

In 2012, Twitter cofounder Evan Williams launched a publishing site called Medium. Medium's objective is for individuals anywhere to be able to share their perspective with others in a meaningful way. It is perhaps the best place to create content and get ongoing community feedback within the content itself.

Medium shows an interesting trend around the number of thought leaders that repost their blogs or e-newsletters on the site. For example, NYU Stern School of Business professor Scott Galloway has a very popular email newsletter called *No Mercy No Malice*. Each week, in addition to sending the email to subscribers, he posts it onto Medium, easily getting more than 300 reactions per post. This drives traffic back to Galloway's email newsletter signups or his podcast.

Vlogger Tom Kuegler uses Medium as his core platform, publishing an educational blog post on the platform every day. He's been consistently posting for three years and now has almost 50,000 followers, which lets him support himself financially ([Figure 16.6](#)).

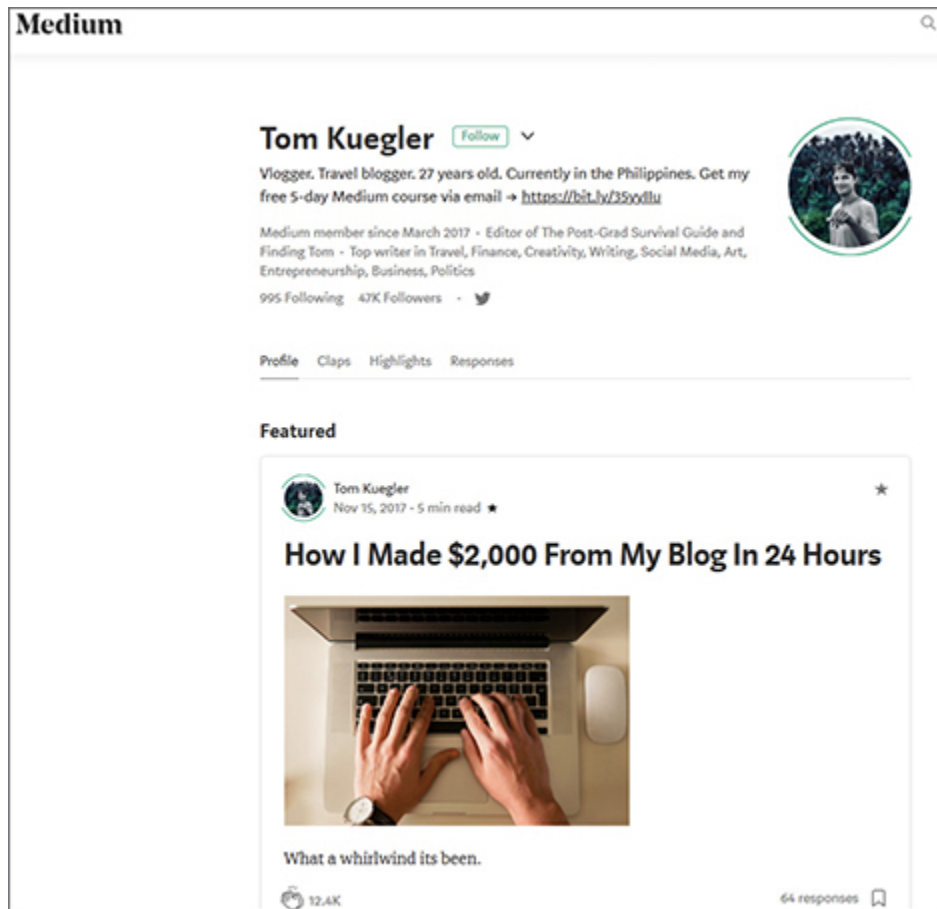


Figure 16.6 Tom Kuegler has dedicated himself to Medium, and it's paid off.

Medium has noticed the number of thought leaders reposting their email newsletters. It recently launched its own email newsletter service directly from the platform, making it a truly powerful social media tool.

SNAPCHAT

Snapchat, with more than 200 million daily active users, originally gained popularity with younger users due to its chat/photo-sharing functioning where messages are only available for a short time (later duplicated by Instagram Stories). Initially, Snapchat was focused on person-to-person communications, but it has since created a Discovery area where individuals, brands, and major publishers can create short-form content.

As of January 2020, 90 percent of Snapchat users were between 13 and 24 years old, so if you are targeting teenagers and young adults, you should

consider Snapchat as a platform. Serial entrepreneur Gary Vaynerchuk has built a huge following on Snapchat by talking about entrepreneurship to young adults. A few months before this book was published, my teenage son asked me if I knew who Garyvee was. (I've spoken at a number of the same conferences as Vaynerchuk.) Apparently my son had been watching Garyvee's short videos on Snapchat and became a follower.

TIKTOK

With approximately 1 billion users (slightly more than 100 million in the United States), TikTok is one of the fastest-growing platforms on the planet. TikTok began as mostly a short-form video-sharing platform catering to younger users, but over the past few years it's been gathering users of all ages. As of 2020, though, about 80 percent of users are age 39 and younger.

Marcus Bridgewater, who goes by the name "Garden Marcus" on TikTok, has built a following of 700,000 followers, just by posting about how to take care of plants using compassion and mindfulness. In a little more than a year, Garden Marcus averages 50,000 video views per post and has garnered multiple sponsorship deals, such as "Mindfulness with Marcus" presented by Greatist.

Initially the majority of TikTok celebrities were Instagram stars diversifying onto the TikTok platform. Today you can become a viral sensation directly on TikTok, due to its proprietary algorithm. Unlike other platforms' algorithms, TikTok's rubric seems to only care about quality content, so even if you have just a few followers, your content can spread quickly if it's good.

TWITCH

Twitch, acquired by Amazon in 2014, is a livestreaming platform focused on video games. As of February 2020, there were approximately 4 million unique broadcasters and 140 million users total on the platform.

The average Twitch user watches 95 minutes per day. If you are a gamer building your *Content Inc.* platform, Twitch is the place to be.

Tyler Blevins, aka Ninja, became a Twitch celebrity by livestreaming his play of the popular video game Fortnite. According to CNBC, his 15

million-plus followers help him earn approximately \$15 million per year.

The key to Twitch success seems to revolve around focusing on one game and consistently streaming every or nearly every day. Newcomers have hit it big in Twitch by streaming immediately after the release of a new game (like Valorant) or a new version of an existing game (like NBA2K). Those without followers can slowly build a following by becoming an active member of a Twitch celebrity's channel.

REDDIT

Although Reddit looks and feels like a social media site, it works vastly differently. With 430 million users (it's larger than Twitter and Pinterest), the platform is made of so-called subreddits. A subreddit is a community devoted to an individual topic. The platform contains more than 2 million different subreddits.

There are few casual Reddit users. My colleagues and friends who use the platform are extremely active in one or multiple subreddits. In many cases, it's their number one site for news and information on a particular topic. For example, if you are a fitness instructor, you could become an expert on /r/fitness or more niche subreddits such as r/StrongLifts5x5. The key? You need to be a true expert, and you can't directly sell. Reddit users are ruthless and can smell a sales pitch a mile away.

SLACK AND DISCORD

I'm including Slack and Discord because they can be powerful, secondary ways to build a platform. Slack is a paid collaboration/messaging hub with more than 12 million users. Many businesses, such as Joe Hage's Medical Marcom Group, have moved away from LinkedIn and Facebook groups to create a better environment for a unique user experience.

Discord can be thought of as Slack for gamers. For *Content Inc.* models on the gaming side, it would make perfect sense to leverage Twitch as a primary platform and Discord as a secondary platform, to create a private-group experience. Discord is the platform my two teenage gamer sons use most. One son uses it for discussions around the game Valorant; the other son uses it for having Minecraft discussions and facilitating coding workgroups.

SOCIAL AUDIO AND CLUBHOUSE

Social audio community Clubhouse emerged onto the scene in 2020 and caught fire by the beginning of 2021. Clubhouse is a free, voice-based social media app where users can discover topics and rooms with only audio through an iPhone. It's similar to going to an in-person event, where you can attend whatever session you want and, if interesting, even ask questions or be asked to present.

The social audio space is quickly becoming crowded. Twitter has already developed an audio competitor to Clubhouse called Spaces, while Facebook is currently working on a challenger as well.

I've been using Clubhouse to promote parts of this book, covering different chapters and holding discussions. Each time, well over 100 people attended. I've been pleasantly surprised.

Depending on the audience you are targeting, Clubhouse may be an option, especially if you are looking for first-mover advantage on a social platform.

THE KEY ELEMENTS OF A SOCIAL MEDIA CONTENT PLAN

As I've mentioned, for best results you need a dedicated plan for every channel on which you intend to distribute social media content. Just because you *can* share something on every channel doesn't mean that you should. To start, it may be helpful to look at how and where most marketers in your industry are distributing their content.

To create a basic social media plan, answer these questions for every channel you are considering.

WHAT IS THE GOAL OF THIS CHANNEL?

You need a reason to be on every channel you choose. "To gain followers" is not a viable reason in and of itself, but "to gain followers on Facebook to drive traffic back to our website to enlist subscribers" is. The important part here is that your content on the channel serve as a method to convert viewers to taking the next step in your *Content Inc.* process—i.e., move

them from Facebook follower to website viewer, email subscriber, event attendee, or however you monetize the platform.

WHAT IS THE DESIRED ACTION?

Similar to the previous point, figure out what you want someone to do in each channel. Share? Comment? Visit your website? Register for something?

WHAT SPECIFIC TYPE OF CONTENT DOES THE AUDIENCE WANT IN THIS CHANNEL?

Customize the content you distribute on each channel. Consider what messages are appropriate for each channel, and create a message you think will resonate with that specific audience. Think about the kind of informational needs people in this channel have and how you can help. Will you primarily publish text, images, or video?

WHAT IS THE RIGHT TONE FOR THIS CHANNEL?

As you consider topics and content formats in each channel, it's critical to determine what the overall tone for the channel should be. Friendly? Fun? Conversational? Professional?

WHAT IS THE IDEAL VELOCITY?

It's a smart idea to understand how often you want to publish content in each channel. How many posts do you want to publish per day or week? What time of day is best? You'll have different cadences depending on whether you are sending or responding to tweets, updating your Facebook status, or publishing YouTube videos. Every company is different, so you want to spend some time determining the schedule that's likely to work best for you and your customers.

Let your goals dictate the decisions you make around social media content. For example, since the goal of your *Content Inc.* plan should be to increase email subscribers, would it really make sense to broadcast all your

blog posts on Facebook and Twitter? What reason would readers have to subscribe to your email program if they can get the same information on the social channels they already visit regularly? Think about what Jack Butcher does leveraging Twitter. He posts amazingly interesting quotes and visuals multiple times a day on Twitter. Followers then check out his additional work on his website.

Think about how you can tweak and repurpose the content you share on your social networks, as it applies both to your goals for the channel and to your overarching business objectives.

A NOTE OF CAUTION

The previous version of this book included multiple sections on Google+, Google's social media platform that no longer exists. Keep in mind that a social network can sell, alter its mission, or go bankrupt at any time (see MySpace). Leverage the platform of your choice, but also remember that the platform may not be around in a year or may change its rules along the way. At the end of 2020, TikTok, a Chinese-owned company, fought with the United States on multiple occasions and was nearly shuttered for good. In early 2021, Facebook banned all media companies from its app in Australia. The benefits can be there, but watch for pitfalls.

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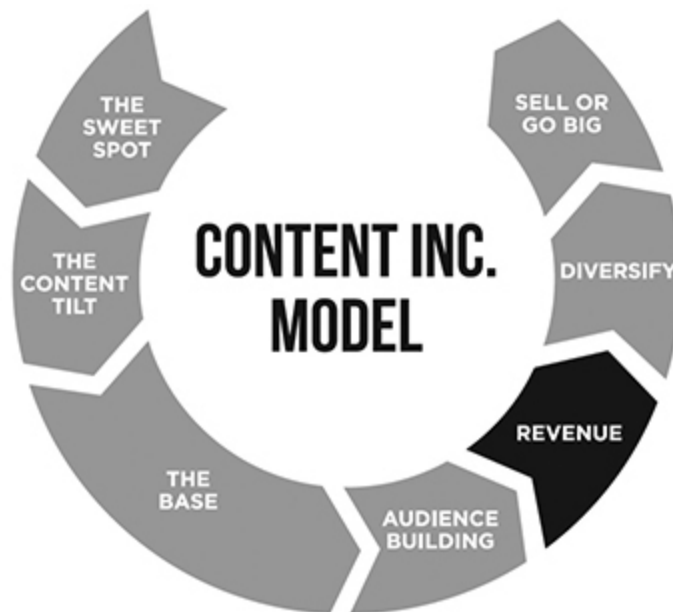
PART 6

REVENUE

I will tell you the secret to getting rich on Wall Street. You try to be greedy when others are fearful. And you try to be fearful when others are greedy.

WARREN BUFFETT

You've created a relationship with a loyal audience. Now is the time to reap the rewards.



CHAPTER 17

SURVIVAL MONETIZATION

Ma'am, I don't doubt the steak was overcooked, but did you have to eat it all before you complained about it?

DAN FROM THE MOVIE *WAITING*

It will take time to find the right monetization model for your business. In the meantime, begin to experiment with different ways to make money from your content asset.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

According to Copyblogger founder Brian Clark, *Content Inc.* models can monetize when they get to their MVA, or minimum viable audience. He says, "An MVA is the point when your audience starts growing itself through social sharing and word-of-mouth. Even better, it's also when you start getting the feedback that tells you what product or service your audience actually wants to buy."

Successful *Content Inc.* companies don't just get to an MVA point or specific number of subscribers and then decide to sell a product. All along the way, these savvy entrepreneurs are leveraging creative thinking to sustain the business model while it's under development.

As you know by now, *Content Inc.* models take time. That said, you and your family need money to pay the bills. This chapter reveals how I made it through the lean times and began monetizing our audience.

IN SEARCH OF MONEY

When I launched my *Content Inc.* business, I didn't have a sustainable income source. While we built the business, I did consulting work for media companies and associations on the side.

One association in particular, a small nonprofit focused on mechanical engineers, needed to develop strategies for generating new revenue streams from its publishing portfolio. The advertising revenue from its magazines was slowly deteriorating. At the same time, the association had major challenges trying to increase digital revenue from sales of online banners and buttons. Adding to the challenge was the association's fear that without increased sales, major layoffs were in the works.

After a few hours analyzing the association's media information and interviewing its sales and marketing teams, I found four key issues:

- The salespeople were accustomed to and focused on selling print advertising. Selling online products was completely foreign to them.
- The association's core advertisers were just dipping their toes into buying online advertising.
- The association had no digital sales strategy. The salespeople were winging it.
- Traffic on the website was still nascent. It was a major challenge to sell digital products, because the association's website didn't have enough eyeballs on the content (yet).

It looked like a long road ahead. Normally this would be fine, but my contact said we simply didn't have the time to wait for the traffic to increase. We needed new revenue now to survive.

From this desperation, we developed the limited-inventory model.

If you understand the life of a print advertising salesperson, there is always inventory. You can always add another form (more pages) to a magazine to accommodate an ad. The magazine publisher will gladly add more pages if new revenue is on the way. Sure, we have sales targets and anticipated folios (the magazine's page count), but we can always sell more ads.

This is exactly how the salespeople were selling digital. They were selling unlimited space availability to a finite group of online readers, and no one was buying.

We developed a new limited-inventory model that looked like this:

- We didn't call it advertising. We called it sponsorship.
- We limited the number of available sponsors per month, from unlimited (in theory) to six sponsors.
- The sponsors' logos were placed at the bottom of every page, and the sponsors were listed as "Association Partners."
- Each sponsor was allotted a digital advertisement that was promoted to one-sixth of all the site visitors.
- We significantly increased the cost of the sponsorships, versus what the former display advertising cost.
- We offered category exclusivity for a 50 percent increase in investment.

At first, the members of the sales team detested the idea. They believed that limiting the products they could sell would hurt their livelihoods. In addition, they didn't like the "six-sponsor" concept because it could shut out some advertisers, and if that happened, the association could take a credibility hit for not being open to all supporters.

Fortunately (or not), we didn't have a choice. We had less than three months to turn things around, or people were going to lose their jobs.

The next week, we sent out an email simultaneously to all possible advertisers about the opportunity. Once the email was sent, the salespeople called their best customers and talked through the opportunities, basically saying "When they're gone, they're gone, but I want to give you first crack at the opportunity."

Inside a week's time we had confirmations for the next six months. Yes, we sold out of inventory. From a revenue perspective, it was a 500 percent increase in digital revenue from the previous year.

From that moment on, all digital products were sold on a limited-inventory basis, including webinars, e-book and white paper sponsorships, and specialized directory listings.

THE BENEFACTOR MODEL

Why is this story relevant? As we've discussed, the *Content Inc.* model, the informational annuity that it is, takes time and patience to work. If you are in a situation similar to what I was in, you probably need a source of income until you build your audience and find your ultimate product.

This is the position I was in just a few months after that association consulting engagement.

My wife, an accomplished social worker, left her job a few years before I started the business to stay home with our two toddlers (now teenagers). We needed an income to survive. Sure, we cut our expenses down to the limit, but we still had a mortgage, a car payment, and two kids to feed. The consulting would have worked fine on its own, but since we were investing so much in our future product (a content marketing matching service), there wasn't enough to support the family. By 2009, we were bleeding cash as an organization.

The core matching service wasn't growing at my projected pace, because the financial model was flawed. The more I scrutinized the model, the more negative my thoughts grew. After multiple conversations with my wife, I was very close to closing down the business and finding a job.

It was then that I remembered the limited-inventory model.

MAKING THE PIVOT

After weeks of thinking about whether to double down or jump ship, I went back and analyzed the audience we had developed through our blog (the base).

- What were the biggest pain points?
- What were people asking to buy?
- Were we missing some low-hanging fruit in revenue opportunities?

The majority of people in our audience were asking for training and tools to help them succeed at content marketing. It was no wonder we were

seeing massive requests for consulting and speaking. Their need wasn't vendor selection; it was education. This insight was a game changer!

We decided to change the revenue model around sponsorship and events. The problem: we needed revenue now.

Enter our limited-inventory model: the benefactor package. I immediately began calling and emailing our best supporters, offering them an opportunity to fund our new direction. This included opportunities for just 10 companies, where each "benefactor" received 10 percent of our site promotion and the opportunity to include content on our site (approved sponsored content).

Within a few weeks we were sold out. This strategy let us fund the model and keep going. The following year, we made the Inc. 500 as one of the 500 fastest-growing private companies in North America according to *Inc.* magazine.

GENERATING REVENUE UNTIL THE PRODUCT IS IDENTIFIED

If you are like most *Content Inc.* entrepreneurs, you need to identify revenue opportunities throughout the process to keep paying the bills. CMI did it through the benefactor model. Digital Photography School did it through affiliate sales. *Game Theory* did it through YouTube advertising. Electric House did it by producing custom content. Copyblogger did it through royalties from partner product sales.

Today all these companies are multimillion-dollar enterprises growing at some of the fastest rates around.

In the next chapter, we'll go through all the opportunities for you to build and sell products on top of the platform. Until you get to that point, think creatively about how to keep paying the bills like other successful *Content Inc.* entrepreneurs.

WHEN SHOULD I START MONETIZING THE PLATFORM?

I regularly meet with entrepreneurs, and they often ask when they should start monetizing their products or services. My answer is always this: “Today!”

For *Content Inc.* to work, you don’t have to go through each of the first four stages and then think about revenue. You need to be thinking about making money from your platform from day one. For CMI to work, I sold the dream of what it would eventually be to our sponsors. That revenue let us build out the platform.

Ardath Albee, author of multiple books, including *Digital Relevance*, believes that the best place to start a content approach is with your most important relationships. The same holds true for your *Content Inc.* monetization model. If you’ve been working your influencer channels properly, those same people should be your first options for locating revenue.

RESOURCE

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CHAPTER 18

BUILDING THE REVENUE MODEL

A successful man is one who can lay a firm foundation with the bricks others have thrown at him.

DAVID BRINKLEY

Some of the best *Content Inc.* models use multiple ways to make money from their audiences. Here are 10 for you to choose from.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

According to *Entrepreneur* magazine, the majority of people make money in very few ways. Individuals who collect a salary from a business generally have one or maybe two sources of income (their paycheck and possibly an investment account). Perhaps you know many people in this situation. They go to the same job every day, work to pay off their bills, and don't have much left for savings or investment after each month.

Millionaires, on the other hand, have multiple sources of revenue coming in, whether that's through multiple businesses (and multiple products and services within those businesses), real estate transactions, countless investments, or more.

That's exactly the type of thinking that surrounds entrepreneurs who engage in a *Content Inc.* strategy.

Musician, YouTuber, and *Content Inc.* example Rob Scallon describes it this way: “I’m always trying to think up new ways to diversify and have more streams of revenue. My band recently had a song licensed for a national TV ad, which was really exciting. I would love to do [more] licensing. I would love to do merchandise too . . . there are a whole lot of different revenue streams around my YouTube channel that I do take advantage of and I do get excitement out of.”

Whether you are an entrepreneur in a startup environment or are running a *Content Inc.* program in a large organization, you should always be thinking of how many ways you can monetize the asset of content you are consistently creating.

REVENUE RIPPLES

Doug Kessler, cofounder of Velocity Partners, discusses “ripples” within a content program. For the most part, marketers measure content programs by increasing sales, saving costs, or creating more loyal customers. These are the obvious objectives, with their associated metrics. But Kessler believes that there may be a more important metric, the one that he calls “ripples.”

Ripples are the unexpected benefits that come from a *Content Inc.* approach, like an invitation to speak at an event, someone spreading the word about your expertise, or other unanticipated benefits of becoming a leading expert in your field.

When it comes to revenue for your *Content Inc.* program, it’s all ripples. When we begin a *Content Inc.* approach, we are most likely unsure what the revenue possibilities could be. For example, River Pools & Spas had no idea that its *Content Inc.* revenue line would be through manufacturing. Matthew Patrick didn’t think that YouTube would call him up for his expertise.

We need to go through the process to get there . . . but when we do, the benefits are powerful.

WHY MORE THAN ONE

There is nothing wrong with having one or two sources of revenue, but it can get you into big problems if something goes wrong.

*And something always goes wrong. And then, there's copper,
which is the only pipe I use. It costs money. It costs money
because it saves money.*

FROM THE MOVIE *MOONSTRUCK*

The most innovative companies in the world, such as Amazon, Disney, and Google, have six or more revenue streams.

It's almost impossible to create six or more revenue channels without a growing, vibrant subscriber audience. Now is the time to start preparing your business model to level up.

CASE STUDY: CHEF MICHAEL SYMON

Michael Symon is perhaps the best-known celebrity chef from Cleveland, Ohio. Michael's entrepreneurial journey started in a fairly typical way (for a restaurant owner) with a restaurant in Cleveland and one in New York. He was slowly growing, adding more restaurants, but it wasn't until Michael appeared on *Iron Chef America* that everything changed. From there, he continually starred on Food Network shows, culminating in a lead spot on *The Chew*, a daily, syndicated talk show on ABC.

Michael is seen by millions a day now on various network shows, but the key is that he's converted that into an audience of more than a million social media fans in just a few short years.

Michael's restaurant business is thriving, including the launch of gathering spots like Bar Symon and amazing burger joints like B Spot. As of today, Michael is involved in dozens of profitable restaurant ventures, but it's his ancillary activities that are most worth noting. Michael has built a platform from which he now derives additional revenues including:

- Books—*Michael Symon Live to Cook*, *The Chew: What's for Dinner?*, *Michael Symon's Fix It with Food*, and *Michael Symon's Playing with Fire*

- Licensing of specialty food items at multiple airports and sporting venues
- Paid appearances, including as an Iron Chef on the Food Network, and appearances on his own show, *Burgers, Brew & 'Que*
- His own brand of signature knives

The list goes on. What works for Chef Symon and other celebrities that build a *Content Inc.* platform is deriving multiple revenue streams from the content. A shortsighted business model may only look at the added attention to generate more restaurant sales. Michael Symon has taken his audience and generated dozens of different ways to make money.

CONTENT INC. REVENUE EXAMPLES

Here are some *Content Inc.* examples and how they monetize their audience.

Michelle Phan, the YouTube beauty star (more than 1 billion views), generates revenue from:

- YouTube advertising royalties
- Book royalties
- Paid appearances
- A music label she launched called Shift Music Group
- A beauty subscription service she founded called “Ipsy” (exited in 2017)
- A startup company she founded called Thematic, which specializes in licensing music

Andy Schneider, the Chicken Whisperer, monetizes his platform through:

- Event sponsorships
- Paid magazine subscriptions
- Magazine advertisers

- Podcast sponsors
- Paid appearances
- Book royalties
- Website sponsors

Darren Rowse at Digital Photography School grows his platform with:

- Affiliate programs (paid royalties from promotion on-site)
- Purchased e-books and tutorials
- Paid online training programs
- A job board
- Online advertising

UNDER THE HOOD: CONTENT MARKETING INSTITUTE

In 2010 we officially launched the Content Marketing Institute as an education and training organization for enterprise marketers, focusing on content marketing. That first full year, we generated a little less than \$60,000 in total revenue (not profit, just revenue). By 2016, CMI revenues were in excess of \$10 million at a healthy 25 percent net profit margin. My wife and I sold it the same year (more on that later).

The model itself was pretty simple: we built a loyal audience of marketing professionals from just a few thousand in 2010 to well over 200,000 (by 2015) and monetized those relationships in dozens of ways.

We broke down revenue into three different buckets: events, digital, and insights.

Note: I officially left CMI at the end of 2017, and my information was current then. As of this writing, CMI is still a robust and growing community, but I do not have insight into the everyday operations.

EVENTS

The largest and most profitable part of CMI's revenue model was in-person events.

Content Marketing World

Content Marketing World, our flagship event, attracted 4,000 delegates from 70 countries to Cleveland every September. The event offered 100 individual sessions for conference attendees, as well as a large exhibit hall featuring the latest in content marketing technologies.

The average attendee paid \$1,295 to attend the main conference. About 25 percent of attendees purchased all-access passes, which got them two workshops and videos of all the presentations. This cost about \$2,500. The average sponsor invested approximately \$15,000 for a booth or other sponsorship option, spending between a few thousand dollars and \$100,000. About 70 percent of the total event revenues came from attendee fees, with the other 30 percent coming from sponsorship fees. Content Marketing World produced a gross margin in excess of 40 percent.

Other Events

CMI produced a range of other smaller events as well, from workshops in New York to content technology events in San Francisco.

DIGITAL

Benefactors

The "benefactor" sponsorship was the first CMI revenue generator (see the previous chapter). It was a combination of advertising, sponsorship, and content for companies that wanted to reach CMI's target audience via the website, which attracted substantially more than 1 million visitors every year. The first year, we charged \$15,000 for an annual sponsorship. A few years later, we charged \$40,000 and limited the opportunity to 10 sponsors per year.

A benefactor sponsorship included:

- Ability to author educational blog posts on CMI online (with CMI editorial staff approval)
- 12 months of online banner display advertising (10 percent of all advertiser impressions via a 250 × 250 creative unit)
- Ad inclusion in weekly CMI e-newsletters and daily blog alerts (minimum 40 per year)
- Branding on the footer of every CMI website page
- First chance at special partnerships and opportunities

Podcast

In 2013, CMI launched the podcast *This Old Marketing*, where Robert Rose and I critiqued the marketing news of the week. We stole the show's format from ESPN's *Pardon the Interruption* program.

That first month we generated 1,000 downloads. Four years later we were generating approximately 100,000 downloads per month.

Each episode had one main sponsor, which submitted a piece of educational content for Robert and I to discuss and promote. Monthly revenue ranged from \$6,000 to \$10,000. (At times, CMI had two sponsors an episode.)

Email List Rental

Many of CMI's opt-in email newsletter subscribers also signed up to receive relevant partner messages. Every Thursday, a CMI partner purchased the CMI email list to promote a white paper, e-book, or some other valuable piece of information for marketers. CMI delivered this on the partner's behalf and charged around \$300 per thousand addresses.

Webinars

Every month, CMI produced three sponsored educational webinars for the CMI audience. Each webinar attracted between 500 and 1,000 registrations, of which approximately 40 percent attended the live event. CMI worked with each sponsor to make sure the webinar content was aligned with the attendee's needs as well as the sponsor's goals. The average webinar sponsorship cost \$19,000.

Virtual Event

CMI produced a live, free virtual event called ContentTECH, where the spotlight was on the latest in content marketing technology. ContentTECH had 4,000 registered attendees and 12 sponsors, bringing in more than \$100,000 in total revenue.

INSIGHTS

Online Training

CMI launched an online training program in 2015 specifically to deliver education and training to marketing professionals who could not attend one of CMI's in-person events. CMI University was open for enrollment four times per year (as quarterly semesters) and required an annual investment of \$995 per person. In addition, CMI sold corporate packages to companies that wanted to educate their entire marketing departments.

Advisory Services

Although CMI delivered educational content every day, some companies required a hands-on approach. CMI worked with companies including AT&T, Petco, the Gates Foundation, Capital Group, Citrix, SAS, Dell, Adobe, Abbott, and more on customized training sessions. These in-person advisory sessions were priced between \$15,000 and \$45,000 per engagement, depending on the deliverables.

Research

More websites linked to CMI's original research than anything else CMI had ever produced. In 2010 CMI partnered with MarketingProfs to create and distribute an annual benchmark study, with research fielded in June every year. We released the initial results during Content Marketing World (September) each year and then released subreports for the next 12 months, including B2B, B2C, nonprofit, enterprise, small business, manufacturing, and more.

Each report became a 40-page e-book and was sponsored by a CMI partner at approximately \$15,000 per report. In addition, CMI produced

small research projects for leading brands where we fielded the study to the CMI audience and then created and distributed the report. These sponsored reports cost from \$20,000 to \$40,000 per project.

Content Marketing Awards

In 2014, CMI purchased the Magnum Opus Awards program and renamed it the Content Marketing Awards. More than 400 organizations submitted more than 1,200 entries to 100 volunteer judges in 75+ content marketing categories. The program generated approximately \$400,000 in total revenue, as well as countless content creation opportunities and amazing industry insight.

To sum up, Content Marketing Institute had been able to monetize its loyal audience in multiple ways at a high growth rate. At the same time, each initiative worked to help market other profitable CMI offerings. The webinars promoted the in-person events, the in-person events promoted the awards, etc. CMI believed that once a loyal audience was created and nurtured, nearly any relevant product or service could, in theory, be launched as a profitable venture, as long as CMI continued to deliver on its promise to readers.

REVENUE OPTIONS

Once you've developed a loyal audience, you can focus on ways to monetize that audience. As [Figure 18,1](#) shows, there are 10 distinct revenue sources: 6 direct sources and 4 indirect sources.

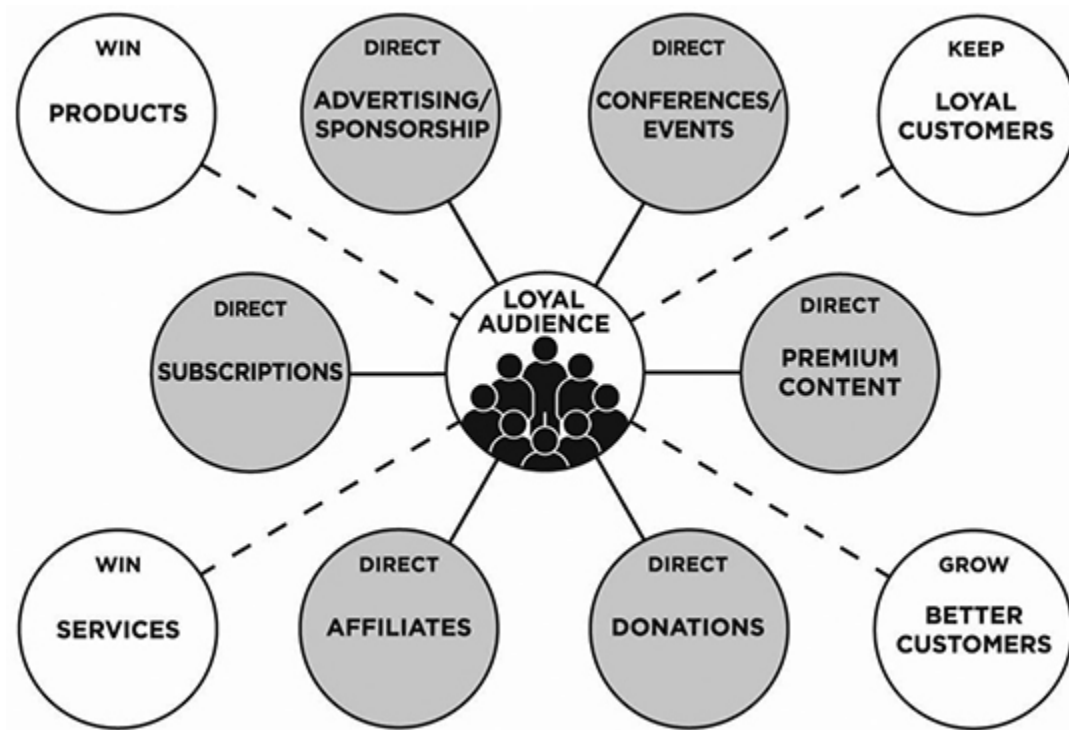


Figure 18.1 There are 10 different ways a *Content Inc.* model can drive revenue.

DIRECT REVENUE OPTIONS

The six different methods by which companies can directly generate revenues from an audience group include advertising/sponsorship, conferences and events, premium content offerings, donations, affiliate sales, and subscriptions.

Advertising/Sponsorship

The most popular method of driving direct revenues is through advertising and sponsorship programs—companies willing to pay you for direct access to your audience.

Traditional Advertising Tested by time, traditional advertising still works very well.

- **How to Cook That.** Ann Reardon, the YouTube baking queen who now has more than 4 million subscribers to her YouTube channel

How to Cook That, makes the majority of her revenues from YouTube advertising royalties. With very few resources, Ann was able to differentiate her message by focusing on what she calls “impossible food creations.”

- ***Morning Brew***. The *Morning Brew* is a daily email newsletter built for millennials that combines business and lifestyle content with a quirky attitude. Each newsletter includes content-based advertising from brands written in the same style as the newsletter. Since its launch, the *Morning Brew* has added a number of targeted email newsletters and podcasts, increasing revenue from \$3 million in 2018 to more than \$20 million in 2020.

Sponsorships While an advertisement generally involves interrupting a user’s experience with a product or content promotion, a sponsorship entails underwriting a piece of content, generally by one company. The benefits of sponsorships include getting leads (through a sponsored download) and/or achieving brand awareness (by sponsoring a podcast or television program).

- **Content Marketing Institute**. CMI favored a sponsorship model over an advertising model for the majority of its products. This included sponsored research reports, e-books, and webinars.
- **Media Voices**. UK-based Media Voices started as a weekly podcast designed for publishers in 2016. After launching at approximately \$600 per sponsorship, it has evolved the model and charges about \$3,000 per sponsorship today.

Conferences and Events

According to CMI/MarketingProfs research, approximately 7 in 10 enterprises create and manage their own events. Some of these are small client gatherings, while others are full-scale events with exhibition halls and concurrent sessions. Revenues are mostly driven through paid event registration or sponsorships, such as parties or exhibition space.

- **The Chicken Whisperer**. Andy Schneider grew the Chicken Whisperer platform into a book, a magazine (with more than 60,000 subscribers), and a radio show, which has now run for more than

seven years with more than 20,000 weekly subscribers. But sponsored road shows are a core part of his revenue mix.

- **Inkers Con.** After launching multiple bestselling books and a popular book publishing training course, Alessandra Torre created the event Inkers Con Authors Conference. “If you can make it through that first year, the second year [is] so much easier. We made all of our mistakes in the first year, and it still ended up being a fantastic event,” says Torre. The 2019 physical conference sold 400 tickets, while the 2020 virtual event sold 750 tickets at \$245 per person.
- **Lennox Live.** Lennox is one of the largest manufacturers of heating and air-conditioning equipment in the world. Every year, the event attracts the leading contractors and distributors from across the United States, offering education around technology, marketing, and business practices. Exhibiting partners include companies such as Honeywell, Cintas, and Fluke. Lennox generates revenue directly from attendee fees, as well as from more than a dozen manufacturing and service partners.

Premium Content

Premium content packages come in a number of forms, including direct-for-sale content products and syndicated content opportunities.

Content Products

- **Digital Photography School (DPS).** Darren Rowse launched DPS as the leading source for beginning photographers, showing them how they can get the most out of their picture-taking skills. DPS generates millions per year by developing premium e-books and specialty reports for direct sale. DPS’s premium content sales have become core to the company’s monetization strategy.
- **BuzzFeed (Tasty).** One of the ways BuzzFeed monetizes is through customized cookbooks. BuzzFeed launched *Tasty: The Cookbook*, a hard-copy book that buyers can customize to fit their tastes. Just a few weeks after initial launch, BuzzFeed sold more than 100,000 copies of the cookbook.

- **Marketing Showrunners.** Jay Acunzo launched Marketing Showrunners as a media and education company. Short-run digital workshops are one of his most successful revenue-generating products. These eight-week classes require four to six hours of time per student. Students pay \$1,500 for the class, which includes:
 - A personal, one-on-one strategy session with Jay
 - Live discussions with world-class podcasters, creators, and marketers to dive deeper into specific skills and topics, such as premise development, interview technique, and narrative-style show production
 - Recurring office hours to work through specific challenges with Jay

To Jay, it's not about how many, but how the shows resonate. In 2020, 100 percent of Jay's business came from people who first listened to his show—and he's never cracked more than 300 downloads an episode.

Syndicated Content Content syndication happens when third-party websites pay a fee to publish original created content.

- **Red Bull.** Red Bull's "Content Pool" contains thousands of videos, photographs, and pieces of music to which media companies and content producers can purchase rights, directly from Red Bull.
- **Scott Adams.** The *Dilbert* creator is now a multimillionaire who draws revenue through speaking and writing books, in addition to comic strips. Adams got his start by syndicating the popular *Dilbert* cartoon to newspapers and websites around the globe.

Donations

Generally, donations to subsidize an organization's publishing work best for not-for-profit and cause organizations.

- **Pro Publica.** Pro Publica is a nonprofit organization that uses its funding to develop investigative journalism. Founded by Paul Steiger, former managing editor of the *Wall Street Journal*, Pro Publica employs more than 50 journalists and received its major funding from

the Sandler Corporation, which committed funding for multiple years at Pro Publica's launch. Pro Publica also accepts ongoing donations from anyone that believes in the organization's cause.

- **Mother Jones.** Like Pro Publica, *Mother Jones* receives most of its funding through direct reader donations (Figure 18.2), and it includes a call to action at the end of every article.



Figure 18.2 *Mother Jones* drives the majority of its revenues through direct donations.

- **Cards Against Humanity.** In 2013, the card game ran a “Give Cards Against Humanity \$5 Sale,” where they asked their audience for 5 dollars in exchange for absolutely nothing. They made over \$70,000 without selling a thing.

Microfunding

- **Kickstarter/Go Fund Me.** Retired US Army officer Brian Stehle dreamed of writing a children's book, but he needed funds to pay for the up-front production. Brian turned to Kickstarter, asking friends and family to donate the \$4,200 in startup costs. It only took a few days for Brian to achieve his goal. Now his children's Christmas book, *One Day Off*, is a reality.
- **Creator Coins and NFTs.** Creator coins allow the content creator to build an economy through their network. Companies like Rally.io and Roll (tryroll.com) mint a coin on the Ethereum (ERC-20) network and then give access to the owner to share the coin with their

community. We've already had great success with this, minting our own coin (\$TILT) at Rally.io (<https://rally.io/creator/TILT/>). We reward community members when they share our content or emails, and in exchange we offer exclusive content and perks.

Related, NFTs (non-fungible tokens) took off in 2021. Artists now sell exclusive versions of their content (see SuperRare and MakersPlace) and musicians (like Kings of Leon) sell album art and fan packages.

Affiliate Sales

Products—Affiliate Sales

- ***Entrepreneurs On Fire (EOF)***. EOF is the popular podcast series run by John Lee Dumas. John promotes a number of companies that pay an affiliate fee to John on either click or actual product sale. EOF publishes revenues and profits every month. Its affiliate income for August 2020 was \$21,557.

Affiliate income works like this: if you click on my affiliate link and sign up for the products and services I recommend, then I earn a commission.

The breakdown of affiliate income for EOF for August 2020 looked like this:

Resources for Entrepreneurs: \$13,703

- Audible: \$102
- Click Funnels: \$13,395
- Coaching referrals: \$148 (email me for an introduction to a mentor for overall online business or a podcast-focused mentor)
- ConvertKit: \$58

Courses for Entrepreneurs: \$6,820

- Knowledge Broker Blueprint by Tony Robbins: \$3,761
- Create Awesome Online Courses by DSG: \$97
- Crush It with Challenges by Pedro Adao: \$2,962

Resources for Podcasters: \$536

- Podcasting Press: \$73
- Splasheo: \$198
- Libsyn: \$210 (Use promo code FIRE for the rest of this month and next free)
- UDEMY Podcasting Course: \$55

Other Resources: \$498

- Amazon Associates: \$116
- Other: \$382
- **The Wirecutter.** The Wirecutter, the gadget and deal listing site, was purchased by the *New York Times* in 2016 for \$30 million. The site makes a little bit of money every time it sells a product recommended on the site. These deals add up. In 2015, it generated more than \$150 million from affiliate revenues.
- **BuzzFeed.** According to the *Wall Street Journal*, BuzzFeed collected more than \$300 million in 2019 solely from affiliate links.

Subscriptions

Subscriptions differ from premium content in that subscriptions, paid for by the consumer, promise to deliver content over a period of time (generally a year).

- **Copyblogger.** After selling its software products division, Brian Clark focused Copyblogger's revenue on education and training, creating Copyblogger Pro, an annual membership program that includes foundational training, monthly advanced marketing master classes, and ongoing coaching for \$495 per year.
- **Agency Management Institute.** Owner Drew McLellan has a number of revenue drivers for his business, including sponsorships and events. The main lever is an annual membership where agency owners get the opportunity to meet with other agency owners in private meetings throughout the year. There are multiple levels of membership, with the highest at \$3,000 per year.

- **The Hub.** Launching the site initially as a UK Facebook group, Laura Moore and Laura Davis created The Hub, a membership site for social media managers. “We targeted 50 members for the first three months, but exceeded 100,” says Moore. They completed their first year as a membership site with approximately \$300,000 in income.
- **Nathan Tankas.** Nathan started building his following online in 2015, but always tried to find a traditional job. Recently he pivoted his content tilt into covering monetary mechanics. When he found a number of unanswered questions on the topic, Nathan launched an email newsletter (called *Notes on the Crisis*) during the COVID-19 crisis, racking up 450 subscribers at \$1,000 per subscriber. He believes he can make another \$20,000 from speaking and writing projects.
- **Substack.** Substack is an email newsletter provider, initially a free tool for writers to develop an audience. Once a writer builds an audience, Substack lets that person sell paid memberships (of which Substack takes a percentage). Twitter recently purchased a similar service to Substack, called Revue.
 - Josh Sternberg, the former media and technology editor at *Adweek*, lost his job during the COVID-19–induced recession. Shortly after, Josh launched an email newsletter covering the media industry (called *Media Nut*) through Substack. In a short period of time, Josh has developed a loyal, growing audience. He’s also set himself up for revenue generation.
 - Emily Atkin charges \$8 per month (\$75 per year) for her climate science newsletter *Heated*.
 - Jacob Cohen Donnelly launched *A Media Operator* in August 2019, covering the business of media. He charges \$100 per year for a subscription.

Substack competitors include Campaignzee (from Mailchimp), Patreon, Buy Me A Coffee, and Revue (owned by Twitter).

INDIRECT REVENUE OPTIONS

While direct revenue options have been traditionally considered part of the media company model, indirect revenues fall under the approach known as content marketing. This means you don't make money *directly* from the content, but from the effect of the content over time.

Win Revenue

Win revenue includes creating and distributing content with the goal of selling specific products or services.

Products

- **Chili Klaus.** Claus Pilgaard, aka Chili Klaus, is one of the best-known celebrity figures in Denmark, all because of the extraordinary way he talks about chili peppers. Claus's YouTube videos have garnered millions of views, including one where Claus conducts the Danish National Chamber Orchestra playing "Tango Jalousie" while eating the world's hottest chili peppers. That video alone has seen more than 5 million views.

From this success, Claus has launched a suite of successful products under the brand "Chili Klaus," including chili chips, chili sauce, chili licorice, and dozens of other products.

- **Indium Corporation.** Indium, a global manufacturing company headquartered in upstate New York, develops and manufactures materials used primarily in electronics assembly. At its core, the company develops soldering materials to keep electronic components from coming apart.

Rick Short, Indium's director of marketing communications, knew that Indium employees had more knowledge about industrial soldering equipment than just about any other company in the world. This makes sense. Soldering is the knowledge area where Indium manufactures most of its products. Indium believed that if it published its expertise on a regular basis, it would draw in new customers and have opportunities to sell more products. Today Indium's blog *From One Engineer to Another* is the company's leading driver of new product sales.

- **Missouri Star Quilt Company.** Jenny Doan is the cofounder of the Missouri Star Quilt Company, a quilt shop in Hamilton that boasts the largest selection of precut fabrics in the world. To spur sagging sales, Jenny created quilting video tutorials to post on YouTube. The videos have driven new traffic to the shop's website, gaining an average of 2,000 online sales per day and making it the world's largest supplier of precut fabrics.
- **The Boutique Hub.** Canadian Ashley Alderson has transformed The Boutique Hub into the leading digital resource for boutique owners. In 2017, she developed The Boutique Awards, which exploded in popularity. The company now services all 50 of the United States, Canada, and Australia with its awards program.
- **MrBeast.** After developing one of the most successful YouTube channels in history with over 50 million subscribers, MrBeast (aka Jimmy Donaldson) launched MrBeast Burger in over 300 locations simultaneously.

CASE STUDY—SLIKHAAR

It was 2009 when twin brothers Emil and Rasmus Vilain Albrechtsen shared the mutual goal of creating an online business. At the time, they were university students in Aarhus, Denmark. Emil was studying international marketing and sales, while Rasmus focused on marketing management and entrepreneurship.

They were both interested in hairstyling and saw the potential in selling hairstyling products online. Soon they launched their online shop in Danish, which quickly expanded to the international domain slikhaarshop.com. But they had ambitions beyond a simple online store—they wanted to create their own hairstyling brand when the time was right.

Emil recalls:

Three months after we opened our shop, we had some sales, but we also realized that we did not differentiate ourselves from other online shops. We had to switch to a more creative approach. Rasmus created a video using his MacBook webcam. The recording was mirrored, the sound was bad, but it was authentic. We launched Slikhaar TV on YouTube

and placed the video there. We got a lot of free views from YouTube at that time and soon we started to see international comments.

That was the first step in Slikhaar TV's journey to what today includes more than 350 million video views and 2.1 million subscribers. It took 10 to 20 videos for the brothers to see that the videos really resonated. The amount of feedback from all over the world motivated the brothers to create more videos. To Emil and Rasmus, YouTube was not only a media channel, but also a search engine, so in the early years they focused on how-to videos. They experimented to find the format that would get the most views.

The brothers finished their studies and evaluated their business venture. They were doing well and wanted to continue. They rented a store on the main pedestrian street in Aarhus, Denmark's second-biggest city, transforming the store into a hair salon and an office. That gave them the perfect stage for content production, plus an additional revenue stream from hairdressing. They hired talented hairdressers who would not only cut customers' hair, but also be part of new video content. The brothers prioritized content production over cutting hair and called the salon Slikhaar Studio.

Slikhaar TV was well received. This was in 2012, when the financial crisis was still very much alive and bold moves from young entrepreneurs were not everyday news.

From here, the content production evolved, and the audience became a growing part of the process. Emil and Rasmus increasingly included the community, asking that viewers tell them what subjects they'd like to see addressed. The feedback gave them ideas for their editorial plan. Armed with audience suggestions, they built a list of the most wanted haircuts, found a hair model, and arranged a cut with one of the hairdressers at the studio.

Emil notes that the key is to determine what works:

I am not a big fan of target audiences. Depending on where you are in the world, some people would like haircuts like soccer players', others like a Bollywood actor's or a K-pop star's. We look at user feedback when planning our videos, but we are also looking at things like trending topics and the quality of our thumbnails. When we publish a

“Cristiano Ronaldo Haircut” video, we are up against a lot of competition. The algorithm on YouTube will look at the click rate for each of the videos, among many other details. The content game of today is more about knowing the algorithm and finding out what works, so we spend a lot of time analyzing and experimenting.

Emil looks back on the early years on YouTube, when there was less competition. YouTube offered organic reach and a huge number of views. But the brothers knew that they couldn’t rely on YouTube as their only channel. They added Facebook to their media mix, but it wasn’t until 2014, when Facebook really started to focus on videos, that Facebook got Slikhaar’s full attention. Today the company has 2.3 million fans on Facebook and has diversified to Instagram.

Emil explains:

Growing an audience on Facebook was fun as long as it lasted. Now it’s like if we had a shop on a very busy street and all of a sudden a bypass opens, and the traffic goes somewhere else. Organic views are decreasing to almost zero, so having the right mix is crucial, and it changes all the time. The opportunities are still there if you are aware. Instagram Reels looks very promising, and we were among the first brands to get access to Instagram TV for longer videos. The tech platforms want to promote their new products, so there are a lot of early mover advantages that we need to pursue, because our audience is there.

Evolving isn’t easy. The social media landscape keeps changing. Keeping up with it requires an experimental approach where you try out new formats while continuing to develop what you are good at. For example, Slikhaar could have done more on TikTok, but the brothers believe Instagram works better for their company. The days of free exposure are over. You have to pay for a higher reach today. Because it experiments with different platforms and algorithms, Slikhaar doesn’t set up goals for a number of followers on each channel.

Instagram Stories and Snapchat are parts of Slikhaar’s marketing mix today. So is email marketing, which it primarily uses for staying in touch with customers.

When Slikhaar TV's audience exceeded 100,000 subscribers, the brothers were working with various hair care brands to expand their business. Their videos helped them increase demand, and they had established good reseller deals with most brands. They had their eye on one particular brand that was featured a lot in their videos. After building a distributor network and attending a big expo in London, however, they saw that things were not quite as friendly as they seemed. The brand had a clear message for the brothers: stay away from the United Kingdom.

Remembering what happened and how they dealt with it, Emil says:

We spent so much money, time, and energy on that. The brand was the most exposed on our videos, and then we got treated like that. We were like, "Either we can set up a fight, or we can follow our dream from the beginning and develop our own products." We chose the latter, and soon we found a local producer, with whom we worked to build our own hairstyling brand, By Vilain.

The first product was ready for sale in the online shop around nine months later. That had a big impact on the business. Rather than driving demand for hundreds of brands and getting a small margin when someone made a purchase at slikhaarshop.com, subscribers would now primarily buy the brothers' own products. In May 2013, the first By Vilain products went live, and online sales (and profits) skyrocketed.

Today the product assortment includes 10 different hair styling products and 7 hair tools. On special occasions, the brothers launch limited editions with special fragrances and colors.

The limited editions also work well for e-commerce events like Black Friday. Instead of offering a huge discount and devaluing the brand, Slikhaar introduces a limited edition on Black Friday. Subscribers have a one-time chance to buy the limited edition.

Today the company is focusing on a few key markets, including the United States, United Kingdom, Germany, Vietnam, and Denmark, as well as Amazon, whose unique approach is like entering another country.

Overall, the business is going well and has been profitable since 2013. In some of the best years it had an annual profit of more than \$1.6 million. Slikhaar currently has 11 employees. Most important of all, the brothers and their team are having a good time.

Emil sums it up this way:

We keep going on as long as we are having fun. We have no exit plans at this stage. Personally, I do not find motivation in exiting, and I have everything I need, including a Lamborghini in the garage. We would rather scale up even more, and we've talked about an IPO or selling a part of the business to a major brand in the industry.

Services

- **Game Theory.** Today Matthew Patrick's *Game Theory* brand has more than 8 million subscribers. From this success, Matthew launched Theorists Inc., a specialty consulting firm that works with large brands that want to be successful on YouTube. Theorists Inc. has been hired directly by some of the biggest YouTube stars on the planet to help them attract more viewers, as well as has been hired by a number of Fortune 500 companies. Even the mighty YouTube itself hired Theorists to consult directly on helping YouTube retain and grow its audience numbers.
- **Smart Simple Marketing.** Sydni Craig-Hart launched Smart Simple as a marketing consulting firm with her husband, Will, in 2006. Today Smart Simple is one of the leading marketing agencies focused on diversity issues. How did it get there? "We've actually produced 439 [content-based] programs over the last 14 years," says Sydni. That kind of consistent delivery led to a weekly email newsletter with more than 30,000 subscribers:

That newsletter was one of the top three ways we got clients, because it was so consistent and so practical. That's where I learned that consistency trumps everything. People would read it for three or six months, or a year or two years. I had a woman write to me who said, "I've gotten your newsletter every week for two years. I thought you were like the rest of them, but you're consistent and your content is always good. I need a coach and I'm ready to work with you."

Keep Revenue: Loyal Customers

Of all the revenue drivers of this approach, loyalty is the oldest of them all, and it is still extremely important today. Organizations of all sizes originally launched print magazines to keep customer loyalty over time.

- **John Deere's *The Furrow* magazine.** John Deere launched *The Furrow* magazine in 1895. It is still published today, produced in print and digital format in 14 different languages and distributed to 40 countries. *The Furrow* has always focused on how farmers can learn the latest technology to grow their farms and businesses. Over the past 100 years, just a handful of the articles have been about John Deere products and services.
- **Harley-Davidson's *The Enthusiast* magazine.** Harley-Davidson Motorcycles has one of the most loyal followings in the world. One reason is its print and digital magazine, *The Enthusiast* (formerly *HOG* magazine). The magazine, first published in 2016, is now sent every quarter to 650,000 customers.

Grow Revenue: Better Customers

Once acquiring a customer, innovative companies leverage customer data to deliver targeted and consistent publications to, in essence, create better customers over time.

- **thinkMoney from TD Ameritrade.** Some investing services are conservative and buttoned-down, especially in complex derivatives markets, but thinkMoney follows a different approach. It takes the subject of investing seriously, but it doesn't take itself with the grim seriousness of many Wall Street firms. Instead, thinkMoney embraces a "sophisticated simplicity" approach that's edgy without being flippant, and witty without being irreverent. Research from T3, thinkMoney's publisher, found that those who read the magazine trade five times more often than those who do not.
- **Fold Factory.** Trish Witkowski, CEO of Fold Factory, has become a celebrity in the direct mailing industry through her regular video show, *The 60-Second Super Cool Fold of the Week*, where she details amazing examples of print direct mail. In 2020, Trish hit the 500th

episode of the series, which marked 10 years of production and the creation of 500 different T-shirts, which she sells.

The Fold Factory videos have been directly responsible for more than \$750,000 in revenue.

Trish says that “one other interesting thing is that the series has been directly linked to driving business to the companies who have been featured on the show, and to even influencing print industry equipment sales by creating awareness and driving demand for different print techniques.”

The most successful entrepreneurs leverage not one, but multiple streams in the *Content Inc.* revenue model. Just as an investor diversifies a portfolio with multiple stocks and/or mutual funds, entrepreneurs need to diversify the revenue streams generated from their content and audience building.

WHAT IF YOU ALREADY SELL SOMETHING?

If you're a mature company with multiple products or services, you monetize your content by answering this question: “What is the difference between those that subscribe to my content and those that do not?”

Let's look again at River Pools & Spas. Before launching its *Content Inc.* approach, the company installed fiberglass pools. By monitoring the engagement of its blog content, River Pools found that those audience members that engage in at least 30 pages of content and request a sales appointment will buy 80 percent of the time. The industry average for sales appointments is 10 percent. So in this particular case, there is an 800 percent increase in the likelihood of a sale.

River Pools also looks at particular articles and their performance. In using a marketing automation system (the company uses HubSpot), River Pools has found that its blog post entitled “How Much Does a Fiberglass Pool Cost?” has resulted in more than \$15 million in sales. How's that for a return on investment?

If you are trying to find the impact of your content, here are a number of questions to consider:

- Are subscribers more likely to buy?
- Are subscribers more likely to buy new products?
- Do subscribers stay longer as customers?
- Do subscribers talk more about us on social (word of mouth) than nonsubscribers?
- Do subscribers close faster than nonsubscribers?
- Do subscribers buy more on average than nonsubscribers?

A yes answer to any one of these can justify the investment behind a *Content Inc.* approach.

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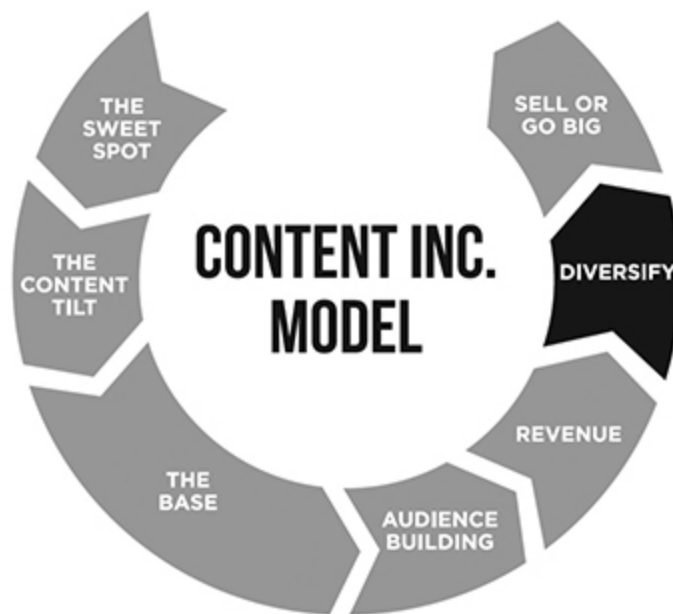
PART 7

DIVERSIFY

Career diversification ain't a bad thing.

VIN DIESEL

You built the model and are reaping the rewards with new subscribers and audience loyalty. Now is the time to diversify your portfolio and stake your claim as the leading voice in the industry.



CHAPTER 19

BUILDING OUT EXTENSIONS

Without continual growth and progress, such words as improvement, achievement, and success have no meaning.

BENJAMIN FRANKLIN

Once you've built the base and started to drive revenue, you need to lower the overall risk in the model. Now it's time to diversify into other channels and build extensions.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

When Walt Disney started his theatrical film business, it was an amazing content business, and also risky. Over the years the company diversified into television, books, comic strips, music, and then into the theme park business, leveraging each brand extension to help push the next one forward.

A few years back, the folks at Disney realized that they needed to further diversify, since the lion's share of Disney revenues and profits came from their theme parks: almost 40 percent of total revenue.

What if, say, a worldwide pandemic hit us?

Disney, once a diversified set of media assets, was now not as diversified as it needed to be due to the growth of the parks. It became too risky. What would Disney do? In 2019, Disney launched Disney+, which now has more

than 60 million paid subscribers. This saved the company, since theme park revenue in the year 2020 is down 85 percent.

In October, Disney announced that its proprietary streaming services would now be the focal point of the entire company strategy. This would have never been possible without diversification.

I'm part of a Facebook group of marketing speakers. For many in this group, speaking is their sole income. Some earn in the mid-five figures, while others rake in \$1 million per year speaking at events.

The global pandemic rocked this group more than most. Huge international conferences like South by Southwest and Salesforce's Dreamforce were canceled. Adobe and Facebook and thousands of other companies canceled their events as well.

For speakers who had just one source of revenue (speaking), this was devastating.

The "one-source-of-revenue" business model doesn't just impact speakers. It affects most businesses. Cruise lines, airlines, bookstores, musicians, and restaurants were all jolted by the virus.

One of my close friends owns a comedy club/restaurant in downtown Cleveland, Ohio. Three months after COVID-19 hit, I asked him how business was going. He said, "If I close the doors full-time, I lose \$50,000 per month. If I'm open, I lose \$40,000 per month. It hasn't been great."

When a crisis arises (and it always happens at some point), companies with a one-revenue business model oftentimes can't survive the panic.

At the same time, having just one audience-building platform is also risky. What if YouTube goes away? What if TikTok gets banned? What if Google+ closes shop? (Oh, that already happened.) Diversification becomes key to both your audience growth and revenue growth.

A WORD OF WARNING

In the last chapter we talked about the 10 different ways to generate revenue. Most *Content Inc.* businesses start with just one revenue source. This makes perfect sense.

But to take your business to the next level, you need to start building extensions beyond the base that create new revenue opportunities, but with

a warning. If the audience for your base hasn't had enough time to truly trust you and your content, quickly building out an extension can be catastrophic.

When I first began my publishing journey, I was put in charge of a project called B2B Showplace. B2B Showplace was the first-of-its-kind virtual event, where you could attend an online presentation and virtually go to a sponsor's booth.

The concept was initially tested in the heating and air-conditioning industry, at a show aptly named HVACR Showplace. Before HVACR Showplace was even launched, sponsorship sales went gangbusters. The product was new and different, and the sponsors wanted to be first in on this new technology.

Once the management team got wind of how the sales were progressing, it ramped up the extensions, adding another 13 different marketplaces to launch immediately after HVACR Showplace.

It was a catastrophe. The rush to get the product out caused a number of technology issues. At the same time, most of the markets weren't ready for this kind of product (they were much further behind in technology adoption).

Even though HVACR Showplace started off strong, the weight of the other failed extensions (and lack of focus on being great at one) killed them all.

The point is this: definitely launch brand extensions with new revenue opportunities as quickly as possible, but not until you believe your audience will support it.

THE BOOM IN SMART SPEAKERS

As of the beginning of 2020, there were 157 million smart speakers in US households (NPR/Edison Research). In the near future, almost every household will have at least one smart speaker.

That means that more people are asking their Amazon, Google, Apple, and Baidu devices questions that, in the past, they asked by typing them into a computer. DBS Interactive found that nearly one in three Americans currently use voice search.

What do these devices need to survive? Content, and lots of it. Google and Bing need audio content to answer search questions. Amazon and Apple need music, podcasts, and audio shorts for entertainment needs.

When you are building out your extensions, it will be valuable to take a long look at audio.

GETTING STARTED

Andy Schneider (the Chicken Whisperer) initially built his platform by doing in-person meetups (monthly gatherings with his audience in Atlanta) and home shows. That transformed into his very popular radio show, *Backyard Poultry with the Chicken Whisperer*. Andy then published the book *The Chicken Whisperer's Guide to Keeping Chickens*, followed by the print magazine, *The Chicken Whisperer Magazine*, sent to 60,000 subscribers.

Scott McCafferty and Mike Emich launched WTWH Media with one platform, Design World Online, as the go-to online product resource for mechanical engineers. Shortly after, the partners launched *Design World* magazine (print). Then they launched both a customer event and an industry event for mechanical engineers.

This was just the beginning. Scott and Mike have now launched additional platforms into several associated industries, including renewable energy, fluid power, and medical design. Today, with millions of registered users, WTWH has gone from nothing to over a \$10 million business in less than 10 years.

CHOOSING THE RIGHT EXTENSIONS

There are two different ways to launch additional platform extensions:

- Adding channels within the same platform. For example, Matthew Patrick believed he could capitalize on the success of his Game Theorists YouTube channel with new extensions focused on the same

concept (“overthinking your favorite things”), but moving from gaming into film and food. The Film Theorists now has more than 9 million subscribers, and The Food Theorists jumped to 2 million YouTube subscribers in just a few months.

- Extending the current brand into new platforms. This is the Andy Schneider example of taking the in-person platform and launching a radio show, a book, and a magazine.

The standard *Content Inc.* model is already going to have an online platform (a website, podcast, YouTube channel, blog, etc.) and an e-newsletter offering to build the subscription list.

From that, the most common brand extensions within the model are:

- **Books.** *Accidentally Wes Anderson* parlayed the success of its Instagram channel into a bestselling book, *Accidentally Wes Anderson—the Book*.
- **Podcasts.** The Engineering Management Institute’s success began with a podcast targeted to civil engineers. From there, EMI diversified into a network of podcasts called CEMENT (Civil Engineering Media and Entertainment Network), which includes six different podcasts, including *This Week in Civil Engineering* and *Women in Civil Engineering*.
- **Email.** The Cleveland Clinic already had a powerful email newsletter (sent three times a week). During the COVID-19 crisis, it added a new email newsletter, called *Know Before You Go*, about what patients need to know before heading to the hospital. Even better, the email newsletter came directly from the CEO.
- **Events.** After growing the Alessandra Torre Inkers Facebook group to more than 10,000 members, Alessandra diversified into the extremely successful annual event Inkers Con.
- **Virtual events.** Almost every media company on the planet has diversified into some kind of virtual event. This could be an ongoing webinar series (45-minute to 1-hour sessions) or a full-blown virtual event using platforms such as Hopin, Zoom, Bizzabo, Cvent, GoToMeeting, or ON24.

- **Magazines.** Yes, print still has a role. After focusing on a world-class blog for three years, Content Marketing Institute launched the print magazine *Chief Content Officer*. CMI research showed that CMI's best customers (those that spent the most money with CMI on an annual basis) subscribed to the magazine.

CASE STUDY: QUEEN

I love Queen. I remember the first time I heard “Another One Bites the Dust.” I was seven years old, and my life changed. Then I listened to “Bohemian Rhapsody.” Wow!

Queen is, arguably the greatest rock band of all time. How did the band do it?

A few months before this book was released, I watched *The Show Must Go On: The Queen + Adam Lambert Story* on Netflix. I loved it. I may watch it again.

In the documentary, Taylor Hawkins of Foo Fighters talks extensively about what made Queen great. In it, Hawkins says that while other bands were churning out music like their last album, Queen tried to hit a home run every time with something truly unique. That's how hits like “Bohemian Rhapsody” happened. Every album, Queen took it up the proverbial 11 and did something most other bands could never dream of.

Queen only produced 84 songs over the band's career, and yet almost 20 were top-10 UK hits. That means 25 percent of the time Queen had a major hit.

Queen built one of the largest audiences in the world by producing relatively few, yet amazing songs consistently over a long period of time.

There was a discussion in the documentary about what Queen had to do to keep growing its audience after Freddie Mercury passed.

All the consistent, home-run hits built Queen's audience. Freddie Mercury died in 1991, but here, 30 years later, Queen not only kept its audience intact, but grew its audience.

Enter diversification.

Let's detail this a bit.

- **Content syndication.** Queen licensed its songs to multiple movies, including hits like *The Knight's Tale* with Heath Ledger and *Wayne's World*.
- **Partnerships.** From 1992 on, Queen partnered with amazing musicians from all over the world. They produced The Freddie Mercury Tribute Concert, benefiting AIDS charities. The Guinness Book of World Records listed it as the "Largest Rock-Star Benefit Concert," televised to 1.2 billion people. From 2004 to 2009 Queen toured the world with Paul Rodgers.

In 2009, Queen performed on *American Idol*, and Adam Lambert was one of the finalists. In 2011, Adam Lambert started touring with Queen. He still does today.

- **Video games.** In 1998, Queen released *Queen: The eYe* video game with EA. The band has also been featured multiple times in *Guitar Hero*.
- **Musicals.** In 2002, Queen coproduced *We Will Rock You*, the musical.
- **Films.** In 2018, the movie *Bohemian Rhapsody* was released on the big screen. It was one of the biggest box office hits of the year.

These are examples of how Queen diversified from its original audience-building activity (album release and touring). Licensing, partnerships, content integrations, and new product launches have all kept Queen at the top of the rock star list.

THE STORY BEHIND CCO MAGAZINE

The original idea for *Chief Content Officer (CCO)* magazine was to reach chief marketing officers and other senior marketers that had budgetary responsibility for content marketing. Our strategy was simple. Get the magazine into their hands, and they would begin to see content marketing as a valuable go-to-market strategy and start funding content resources within the enterprise.

Understanding the budgeting behind a magazine is critical. Areas to consider include:

- **Project management.** The fee for someone to oversee magazine production.
- **Editorial.** Costs for raw content, editing, and proofreading. Any or all of these categories can include outside contributors.
- **Design.** Someone to design the publication's look and lay out each issue.
- **Photos and illustrations.** Any photo shoots or custom graphic creation.
- **Database fees.** Making sure your audience list is postal ready.
- **Printing.** Cost to print the publication.
- **Postage.** Delivery for each issue.
- **Shipping.** Any bulk shipping fees from the printer or to your office.
- **Commissions.** If advertising revenue supports your magazine, you'll need to pay a sales commission. Commission rates are generally 8 to 10 percent for a staff member and up to 20 to 25 percent to hire a freelance salesperson or external sales team.

Our general folio (page count) was between 40 and 64 pages. Your cost will depend on the number of total pages, number of editorial pages, and number of magazines you print, but you should prepare to spend at least \$40,000 per issue. Sponsor advertisers in our publication defrayed those costs entirely. In general, we broke even or made a small profit on each issue. This was acceptable, since the overall goal of the print magazine was not revenue or profit, but as a channel to co-market and gather subscriber data.

The list goes on . . .

- Agency Management Institute started a blog as its base platform, later diversifying into a podcast, then an in-person event.
- [Salattósen](#) (The Salad Chick) leveraged her followers on Facebook to diversify into Instagram, then launched a book series.

- Kristen Bor (*Bearfoot Theory*) started by testing Instagram, built her audience with a blog, and then diversified into Pinterest.
- Teach Better launched its Grid Method with a blog, then expanded into instructional videos. Now it's contemplating self-publishing books.

Once you create a loyal audience, it's seductive to continually launch new extensions. This is fine, but I recommend at least nine months between each launch. This will give you time to work out the bugs with each extension before moving onto the next.

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CHAPTER 20

ACQUIRING CONTENT ASSETS

Buy land, they're not making it anymore.

MARK TWAIN

If you determine the properties you want to purchase and build relationships with those owners over time, you improve your chance of buying the property at a good price.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

Over the past 20 years, Disney has purchased ESPN, Pixar, Marvel, and Lucasfilm, acquiring the greatest content library in the world. This is what great media companies do: they look to acquire first and build second.

A few years ago I sat in a marketing meeting with one of the world's largest producers of consumer goods. The discussion centered on building audiences through content in various markets. In some of the markets, the company already had a solid content platform built. In others, there was nothing on the horizon.

The plan under discussion was an acquisition strategy of multiple properties, where the organization would buy blogging sites and media properties that already had built-in audiences and content platforms.

Sometimes it makes sense to build. Sometimes it makes sense to buy. Here's the takeaway: media and publishing professionals are taught to

always look to acquire at a reasonable price first, before spending the time and resources to build. What may look expensive up front may not be so expensive if you spread those costs out over three to five years (the time it takes to build a true *Content Inc.* model).

A friend of mine who works as chief marketing officer for one of the largest brands in the world said this: “It’s much harder to go from zero to one, than from one to 100. Always look to buy first.”

TWO THINGS

Blogging sites and media companies want and need two things.

The first is the *capability to tell stories*. They have the people and processes to consistently churn out amazing content.

The second, and maybe more important, is that blogs and media sites come with *built-in audiences*.

Although merger and acquisition strategies have been happening ever since the first media company was launched, nonmedia companies are starting to get into this game:

- Photography supplies store Adorama put a buying group together when *JPG* magazine was going out of business. The group got access not only to *JPG*’s *Content Inc.* platform and content, but also to *JPG*’s 300,000 subscribers (which just happen to be Adorama’s prospects and customers).
- L’Oreal, the global makeup conglomerate, purchased Makeup.com from Live Current Media for more than \$1 million back in 2010.
- Marketing automation company HubSpot wanted to add an agency blog to match its marketing and sales blogs, so it bought the blog *Agency Post* instead of starting fresh. In 2021, Hubspot purchased email newsletter media company *The Hustle* and its more than one million subscribers.
- The SurfStitch Group, a leading online retailer in Australia, purchased two small media companies in the surfing industry, further positioning SurfStitch as the content’s clear content leader.

You can even acquire membership organizations. That's exactly what Salesforce did in 2020 when it purchased *The CMO Club*.

And how did TikTok get so big, so fast? It bought musical.ly. For TikTok, it was easier to grow from an existing base than to start fresh.

As you build out your *Content Inc.* strategy to grow your industry dominance, acquisition strategies are a natural path to follow.

THE PROCESS OF ACQUIRING A CONTENT PLATFORM

Content Marketing Institute purchased multiple properties to add to its platform, including a West Coast conference called Intelligent Content Conference and an awards program it renamed the Content Marketing Awards. CMI decided that purchasing these platforms made more sense than creating them from scratch and then competing with these properties.

To acquire new platforms, follow these seven steps.

STEP 1. DETERMINE YOUR GOAL

As with any good business decision, start by determining the reasons it might make sense to purchase an existing content platform. Your business objectives for a purchase might include:

- To cover a geographic area that your business is currently absent from with an in-person component. The ultimate goal would be to reach more customers for cross-selling, up-selling, and decreasing your customer turnover rate in that region.
- To insert your brand into the conversation around a topic you are not well known for. Let's say you manufacture a certain type of steel, and you've identified some use in the oil and gas industry. It may make sense to look at smaller oil and gas blog sites or events and become a credible part of the industry lexicon.
- To accomplish subscription objectives. Most likely, the platform will come with a built-in audience for you to nurture, grow, or leverage for cross-selling.

- To purchase the content assets themselves and the associated search engine optimization and share the benefits that come with them.

STEP 2. CLEARLY IDENTIFY THE AUDIENCE

For this to work, you need a clear understanding of the audience gap you are trying to fill. For example, CMI targeted senior-level marketers at large organizations with its magazine, *Chief Content Officer*. CMI targeted marketing, PR, social media, and SEO managers and directors at mid-market and larger enterprises for Content Marketing World, CMI's event.

STEP 3. MAKE YOUR SHORT LIST OF PLATFORMS

After you identify your objective and your audience, start making a list of relevant platforms that will help you meet your goals. Avoid setting any limitations at this point. You can list events, blog sites, media sites, association sites, and maybe even some sites directly from your influencer list.

As you make the list, it's handy to put it all into a spreadsheet containing relevant subscriber information, such as:

- Origination date
- Current number of subscribers
- Known revenue sources (list each of them)
- Ownership structure (for example, independent blogger or media company)

For a conference or trade show, here is a list of assets we look for when purchasing an event:

- Number of attendees (past two years) with percentage of growth (or loss).
- Number of exhibitors (past two years) with percentage of growth (or loss).
- Number of media partners (past two years).
- General regional location.

- Registration cost (rate card).
 - Marquee value (this is a subjective rate determining the cache for the event—a five-point scale should work just fine).
 - Possibility for setting up a media platform around the event (again, something on a five-point scale is sufficient). There may be potential to build the event into a fully functional media platform with online content, web events, and more.
-

Scott McCafferty and Mike Emich founded WTWH Media, LLC, in 2006 after running a boutique media representative firm. Nine months before that, Scott attended sales meetings with six different publishing operations. At those meetings, Scott noticed a consistent trend: when he brought up online advertising solutions, every publisher told him to stay focused on selling print pages. Scott knew he needed to make a change.

McCafferty and Emich went ahead and developed a comprehensive business plan with close to 50 pages detailing projections and assumptions. Within that nearly 10-year-old plan, there were two critical factors that remain true today. They believed readers would take control of their information channels and marketers would require measurable results from their investments.

As the business grew, McCafferty often referred to business advice he received from David Murdock, chairman and CEO of Dole Food Company. In a social meeting with Murdock, McCafferty asked him how he bought and sold companies. Murdock said that he simply made a list of the industries in which he wanted to acquire a business and a list of companies he wanted to purchase. He then would call each owner and ask if he or she wanted to sell. Some would say yes; some would say no.

Applying Murdock's advice, McCafferty made lists of websites in technologies that WTWH covered. He then emailed the owners asking if they would consider selling. Over an eight-year period, WTWH has negotiated five transactions by applying this principle. Along the way, he recognized a certain mix of common ingredients within each transaction:

- Typically, the sites were community based with an active user group.

- They were owned and operated by a single operator, who viewed the business as a hobby.

Today WTWH Media, LLC, manages 40-plus technology-based websites, multiple print publications, and a series of vertical events. It provides marketing services in the design engineering, renewable energy, fluid power, and medical markets.

STEP 4. APPROACH THE BEST OPPORTUNITY

There are two approaches I recommend. I've seen both of them work. You can reach out to your top pick and see where the conversation goes. The issue is that you are putting all your eggs in one basket. A better option may be to approach your top three picks all at once and say that you are interested in purchasing their website, event, etc.

You'll likely be amazed at the reactions you receive. Some of the operators will never have imagined that they'd be approached for a purchase. Others (probably those with a media background) will already have an exact idea of what their exit strategy is and what they are looking for.

The key at this point is to get discussions started, so you can gauge where potential interest may lie. The worst-case scenario when approaching a possible seller that isn't interested in selling is that you now have the potential to grow a relationship from this first contact. You never know when intentions might change, and now you have an inside track if they do.

STEP 5. DETERMINE THE PURCHASE VALUE

There is a standard way to measure smaller web properties and events (more in [Chapter 22](#)), but this first part is critical: *figure out what the owner wants*. Just like you do with your influencers, it's your job to find out what the platform owner's goals and aspirations are. Maybe it's just monetary (though this is unlikely). Perhaps the owner is looking for a new opportunity, or he or she desperately wants out of the business. (Many blog site owners or event owners never imagine that their project might get

larger than what they can manage or might grow in a different direction than what they intended.)

As I said, there is a proper valuation process for smaller web properties and events. To engage in this process, you both need to sign a mutual nondisclosure agreement for protection—on both sides. Then request the business's profit and loss statement for the previous two years, at least. You may also need to see documentation on current sponsorship agreements and other contracts the company holds, to confirm that its P&L statement can be verified. (Legal specifics can vary widely, so please consult your legal representation before you approach any opportunity.)

For website purchases, some deals are done on a per-subscriber basis, some on a net profit basis. In one example I worked on, a media deal was based on paying \$1 per subscriber. In another, it was five times earnings, paid out over a two-year period. Smaller conferences generally go for around five times net profit. (If the conference's annual profit is \$100,000, you would pay \$500,000 for the property.)

Let's look at a small conference example:

- Attendees: 250
- Exhibitors: 20
- Revenue: \$340,000
- Expenses: \$270,000
- Net profit: \$70,000

General value of the business: $\$70,000 \times 5 = \$350,000$

A bit more goes into it, but the estimated general value of this event would be around \$350,000.

STEP 6. MAKE YOUR OFFER

Before you make a formal offer, make sure that your price is in the right ballpark and that the owner agrees to the basics of your terms. If you have that agreement, you'll need the event owner to sign a formal letter of intent (LOI). The LOI indicates that both sides agree to continue the conversation and take the relationship to the next level of the process. It's the business

acquisition equivalent of getting engaged—while it's not a legally binding act in and of itself, it serves as an official statement of your intentions. (Please consult legal representation on creating an LOI.)

STEP 7. FINAL NEGOTIATIONS

Now, before you sign anything, consider these final questions:

- What email databases and print lists are available? Do you have permission to email people in the database directly? Should you get double opt-in permission?
- What assets are available? Videos? Blog posts? Podcast episodes? Conducting a full audit of the company's assets might be necessary.
- What social channels are in use?
- Who are the prime influencers in this space that we should connect with? Request contact details and areas of expertise (if needed).
- What vendors does the company work with? Whom would it recommend?

Over the following 30 to 60 days, you work on a formal asset purchase agreement and review all the documentation to make sure all facts, figures, and discussions are accurate and verifiable. From there, contracts are signed, followed by corks popping on your celebratory bottles of champagne (optional, but a nice touch).

Victor Gao believed that Arrow Electronics, a Fortune 150 company, should be the leading informational provider in the electronics engineering space. He also believed it would be easier to buy that aspiration than to construct it from scratch.

Over an 18-month period, Victor's team approached large media companies and independent operators in the electronics space. Arrow Electronics ultimately bought more than 50 credible media websites. These not only run at a profit, but have given Arrow the largest audience of electronics engineers in the world.

FINAL STEP: MAINTAIN QUALITY

John Blondin is a media and marketing consultant specializing in M&A. He has a critical reminder for anyone purchasing a media asset. John says: “I do believe that a strong and efficiently structured enterprise can benefit through a media asset acquisition based on retaining credibility through the delivery of content that is not compromised in the manner of the old traditional advertorial. Quality content with a conscience should be the mantra.”

John’s last statement is the key: *quality content with a conscience*. If you are purchasing a media asset, it will no longer be an asset if you do not consistently deliver quality content on that platform. Please do not acquire an asset if you will simply use it to promote your products and services. Degrade the audience experience, and your purchase becomes a complete waste of time.

Making acquisitions as a small company might seem daunting, but don’t be phased. I’ve been involved in deals that have taken a week and some that lasted a year, from \$15,000 total to more than a million dollars. Sometimes the best deals happen very quickly and cost just a few thousand dollars.

VALUING A SITE WITH NO REVENUE

There are a number of websites available for sale that lack revenues and profits. In that case, you can value the site with the following:

- **Name.** Does the name have inherent value? Website URLs that include a popular word (like marketing) or short URLs (like beer.com) may be valued on name alone.
- **Domain authority.** Use sites like Moz.com and Ahrefs.com to determine domain authority (DA). DA is a score to 100, created by Moz, that predicts how likely a site will rank in search engine result pages. A score of 50 is decent, while a score of 70 to 80 is amazing. A website investor might pay \$20,000 for a site in the 50s and six figures—plus for a site that has a DA of 70 or higher.
- **Search results.** If there is a particular set of search engine keywords that are important for you and your business, you may be able to purchase a website that already ranks in the top 10 for one of your

keywords. Many website investors buy sites like this and then improve the landing page that the search engine displays for that keyword. Sometimes a small alteration can make a big difference in improving search rankings.

As well, there are many auction sites available to purchase sites with little to no revenue. Try [Flippa.com](https://www.flippa.com/) or Quiet Light Brokerage for starters. Prices range from a few thousand to a few million. And for more information on website investing, I recommend [Investing.io](https://investing.io/).

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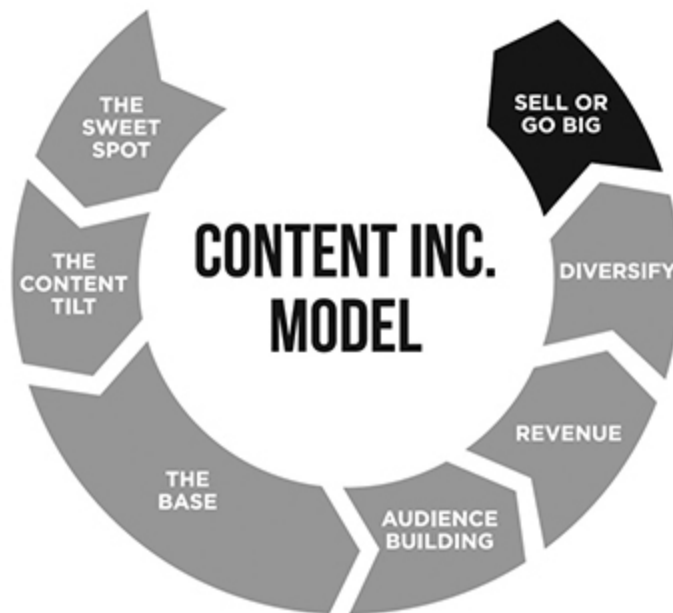
PART 8

SELL OR GO BIG

What's truly important—and what I find myself forgetting and having to relearn—is that right here, right now, I am free. Free to be myself and to express myself.

KAT VON D.

You've come this far. The spoils of war are in sight. Now you have a decision to make. To sell it all or continue to fight. *And yes, I made this rhyme on purpose.*



CHAPTER 21

EXIT PLANNING

As an artist, as a brand, as a rapper, as a musician, you know you got a window and a lot of people. Even an athlete; they don't have an exit strategy. It's just living in the false reality that it's going to be like this forever.

NIPSEY HUSSLE (AKA ERMIAH JOSEPH ASGHEDOM)

Regardless of your ultimate goal, every entrepreneur needs an exit plan.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

It doesn't matter what industry entrepreneurs are in, what country they live in, or how many people are involved in the business. One thing is for sure: they almost always lack an exit strategy.

Maybe you think you don't need one. Perhaps you want to leave the business to your kids when you pass. Perhaps you want your business partner to take over. Maybe you dream of selling big someday. Whatever is in your head, we need to get that plan on paper and start on the strategy immediately.

When do you begin the exit strategy? When you start the business.

When I left that executive media position to start what became the Content Marketing Institute, I had dreams of selling for millions. But at first, I did nothing about it. I thought about how amazing it would be, but I didn't plan for it.

About a year after starting the business, I wrote this statement in the “financial goals” section of my list of goals (see [Chapter 1](#)): “My wife and I sell the company in 2015 for more than \$15 million.”

I wrote this in 2008. That year, the business generated about \$60,000 in total revenue and took a \$50,000 loss. The business was worthless. In context, the statement is laughable, ridiculous.

As crazy as it was, this is the statement I read to myself twice a day, once in the morning and once before bed each evening. Every so often, I tweaked the overall strategy for the business to help deliver on that goal. My wife and I made thousands of decisions over several years in order to make that statement a reality.

There was a reason we chose that particular year (2015) and the total amount (\$15 million). First, by 2015 my children would be 14 and 12. My hope was to sell the business in order to spend time with them before they left for college or their next journey. Second, my wife and I did several analyses and believed we needed \$10 million to do all the things we wanted to do in the future for our kids, our charity, and our style of living. We conferred with our accountant and attorney, did the math, and realized we’d need to sell for \$15 million before taxes to take home \$10 million, considering employee gifts as well as federal and state taxes.

YOUR EXIT

In the next section, I detail how I executed my personal exit strategy, which was to sell the *Content Inc.* model we created in exchange for financial freedom. If selling is not in your cards, what is?

Visualize yourself and your family in 10 years. Where are you? What are you doing? What’s different? How are you making the world a better place?

Jay Acunzo, founder of Marketing Showrunners, doesn’t ever think about exiting his business. He says, “My goal with the business is to have impact. And if someday, the way I can have impact and help more people is another organization acquires ours, great. We’ll consider that. But the reason I’m doing this business is I see a way to construct a high-leverage entity to effect change. And so I will do anything that fits the why and fits the mission, so long as it’s helping people. I’m doing the thing I want to do and want to see how long the party can last.”

Jay's ongoing strategy is different from mine. He writes all his business goals in something he calls "The Grand Vision," which everyone on the team can access.

How will you build your grand vision?

According to the Edward Lowe Foundation, there are a number of steps in creating an exit strategy.

1. Decide on a target date for a change in your role.
2. Get feedback from your family or investors. If you have loved ones working inside or outside the business, they need to be aware of your thinking.
3. Create the plan. You can sell the company to your children, to employees, or to a strategic or financial buyer. You could also merge with another company.
4. Once complete, publish the plan. Your management and family members should know your intentions. One of the best things we did when we sold CMI was making sure the management team knew ahead of time and was compensated on any transaction.
5. When you're ready, start implementing the plan.

EXIT PLANNING STARTS AT THE BEGINNING

By 2010, our *Content Inc.* model started coming into form. The revenue opportunities were presenting themselves, and I could envision the company we would become. I could also envision what types of companies would want to buy us.

Over a few months, I began to list the types of companies that could possibly buy us in the future. I only listed strategic buyers (not financial buyers) since my goal was not to stay with the business too long after the sale.

I added pure media companies, event companies, education and training companies, consulting companies, and even a few of our sponsors to the list. After compiling what I believed was an all-encompassing list, I

narrowed it down to my top five (see the Warren Buffett section in [Chapter 1](#)).

How did I do this? I looked at those companies that I believed (1) would keep the mission of CMI strong and alive and (2) had the funds to purchase us at or over our asking price.

COMPLETE THE DETAIL

Once you have your top five, fill in the gaps. A spreadsheet works best at this point. Complete these columns:

1. **Parent company.** List the parent company.
2. **Acquiring brand.** Does the parent company have a sub-brand or brand extension that would be integral in the purchase? For example, is Alphabet/Google (the parent company) buying you directly, or is the purchaser Nest (a sub-brand of Alphabet)? In the latter case, it probably would still go through Alphabet, but Nest is the one in the negotiation room.
3. **Rationale.** Why would each one want to buy you? Does your *Content Inc.* model satisfy a content gap for the buyer? Do you have access to an audience it desperately needs? Have you developed a product that would complete its portfolio?
4. **Key contact(s).** Who is the decision maker? Who are the gatekeepers to get to the decision maker? Is this one person's decision, or are there multiple team members? If multiple, list the team.

MEET AND GREET

Nice start! Now the work begins.

Your quest, over the next 12 to 18 months, is to meet and/or chat with each of the key contacts on the list. That doesn't mean you mention anything about selling the company. At this point, just get to know them and

start forming a business relationship. Maybe (just maybe) there is a project both companies could work on together (a win-win).

For our list, I was able to set up appointments and meetings at trade shows and events. Do the research and find out what events your contacts speak at or attend. Send the email and set up the appointments. Something like:

Hi Sue,

Not sure if you know me, but my name is Joe Pulizzi, founder of Content Marketing Institute. I'll be attending XYZ event and would love to buy you coffee if you have 30 minutes. Would just be nice to meet, catch up, and talk shop. I have XYZ times and dates available. If that doesn't work, shoot me some alternative times.

Keep your email short and to the point, and always include times and dates (executives hate back-and-forth emails). You'd be surprised how many meetings you'll get this way. If you don't have an email address, try a direct message through Twitter or LinkedIn.

NURTURE THE RELATIONSHIP

Once you've met the contacts, the nurturing process begins. Every other month, send them an important link or report. Doesn't have to be much, but a "Thought this report would be of interest. Check out [page 4](#)" goes a long way.

FINALIZE YOUR LIST

Some exiting entrepreneurs do not limit the list. They like having more companies and the possibility of diverse offers. My preference is six to eight companies, but if you need a few more on the list, that is fine. You aren't sending a tweet out to the world that you are for sale. You are approaching a few trusted people and businesses that should very much be

interested in purchasing your business. You have done your research and know there is a fit.

GROW TOWARD THE GOAL

My wife and I wanted to close a deal in 2015. The problem? By the end of 2014 we did not have the financial numbers to justify a \$15 million valuation (more on valuation in a second or so). Because of this, we made multiple decisions in 2014, including purchasing two small properties and an email database. We believed that those purchases, along with continual organic growth, would get us to where we needed to be.

At the beginning of 2015, everything was in place, and we were ready to execute the rest of the strategy.

GET YOUR HOUSE IN ORDER

You have two meetings to take. First, your attorney.

What needs to happen to protect you and your family? Are there any legal issues you need to be aware of?

Now is also the time to check through all your partnership, vendor, and employee agreements. Are there any problem areas?

Do this:

1. Make copies of every agreement you have, and place them in a folder (paper or digital).
2. Pay your attorney to review (or re-review) all agreements to spot problem areas.
3. Fix anything that needs fixing.

After the meeting with the attorney, your next stop is to visit the accountant.

The big issue is that, most likely, the way you produce your financials will probably not be the way the buyer needs them for analysis purposes. This is something to keep in mind now (more on that later).

Your accountant needs to review all tax implications with you. Is there a better time to sell? A better type of buyer? Make sure the accountant lays out everything so you can confirm that your final list is correct and your timing is in the ballpark.

FIND A FINANCIAL ADVISOR

The best advice I can give you: do not go through this process yourself.

That means finding a financial advisor that can run point on all correspondence and negotiations. Unless your deal is expected to be for more than \$50 million, I recommend hiring an independent financial advisor (not a larger firm).

This is something you should be researching as well. For about a year before we put the selling plan in action, I researched financial advisors. Besides scouring Google, I asked industry friends (in confidence) and attended event sessions on mergers and acquisitions. The advisor we chose used to be the CFO at a large media company and had 20 years of experience working on small acquisitions like ours. I approached him after seeing him speak at an event, and we hit it off immediately.

According to Hal Greenberg of The Riverside Company, most media businesses use what's called the Lehman formula when hiring a financial advisor. It looks like this:

- 5 percent of the first \$2 million
- 4 percent of the next \$2 million
- 3 percent of the next \$2 million
- 2 percent of the next \$2 million
- 1 percent of the next \$2 million and up

On a \$10 million deal, the fee would be \$300,000, or 3 percent, plus 1 percent above \$10 million. For our deal, we agreed that:

1. Financial advisor receives 2 percent of the sale price up to \$10 million (only on the up-front sale price, not on earnouts or bonuses after sale).

2. Financial advisor receives 1.5 percent of anything over \$10 million.
3. Fee for a successful sale capped at \$300,000 total.
4. Financial advisor receives \$150 per hour if there is no deal. In this case, we had our financial advisor keep track of the hours.

FINALIZE THE LIST

If you have chosen wisely, your financial advisor will have some thoughts about your list. Make sure your advisor reviews the list and confirms your hypotheses.

My initial list of four potential buyers grew to eight after discussions with our advisor. We put each possibility in a spreadsheet, did a complete analysis of each opportunity, and agreed that we would approach those eight companies.

OFFERING MEMORANDUM

After agreeing on a final list, we put the calendar together, leading up to sending out the investment memorandum. The sections of the investment memorandum include:

Executive summary

Investment highlights

The company

Overview—Content Marketing Institute

Financial summary

Product offerings (break these down)

Audience/database

Marketing and sales

Production

Growth opportunities

Market overview

Competitors
Management and ownership
Executive management
Employees and contractors
Ownership
Conclusion

Keep this document to no more than 20 pages. I agonized over our document, spending more than three months going through multiple drafts. You probably will as well.

THE NIBBLE

For all the contacts with whom I had a direct relationship, I sent a quick email:

Hi Bob,

I'm in the process of selling Content Marketing Institute. Would you be interested in seeing the Offering Memorandum?

When someone said yes, I introduced our financial advisor, who quickly took me off the email chain and proceeded with the process.

In situations where I did not know the main contact, our financial advisor found the correct contact and worked to set up a quick call discussing the opportunity.

Once we knew which parties were or were not interested, we proceeded to the next step.

THE NONDISCLOSURE AGREEMENT

Five of the eight companies were interested in taking a closer look at our financials and asked to see the full offering memorandum. Our financial

advisor received each main contact's signature on a basic nondisclosure agreement and then emailed over the memorandum.

The financial advisor also sent over dates when we could take calls and answer questions, as well as a deadline for receiving letters of intent from interested buyers.

THE LOI

From the interested five potential buyers, we received two letters of intent. A letter of intent is a short, nonbinding contract that precedes a binding agreement, such as a share purchase agreement or asset purchase agreement.

A letter of intent typically includes:

- Transaction overview and structure
- Timeline
- Due diligence
- Confidentiality
- Exclusivity

An LOI is not binding in any way. It is like a marriage proposal. Sure, you are serious, but we are not really married yet.

The first LOI we received was a genuinely nice package, but below what we were looking for in terms of purchase price. The second one I will never forget.

I had just finished a workshop in New York. I had a voice mail from my financial advisor, who told me to check my email. This one was from a global events company.

I opened it. Read it. Read it again. Then I called my wife. When looking back, this was our moment, the moment when we cried and told each other that "we did it." Financially, it was everything we could have asked for. From an operations point of view, we needed some clarifications. The company was asking for a lot in return for its investment, and rightly so.

Over the next two weeks there was back-and-forth on several issues, culminating in the formal pitch meeting.

THE PITCH MEETING

Exactly one month after receiving the LOI, we had our first in-person meeting. My wife, our financial advisor, and I reserved a small conference room in New York City for our meeting with two of the buyer's senior executives. One was in charge of M&A for the division, and the other ran the actual division.

To prepare, I put together a presentation based on the offering memorandum and worked hard to address the concerns the buyer had raised. The meeting was intense. The buyer challenged many of our growth assumptions. It lasted about three hours, and I was exhausted when we were finished.

THE SIGNED LOI

How silly I was to think the LOI we received meant something. It does not. It is like Play-Doh in the can before sculpting a piece of art. It's the signed LOI that counts. That becomes the template used to build the final asset purchase agreement.

After the pitch meeting, we received a number of requests from the buyer, including all our past financials, our updated projections based on the meeting, our sales pipeline, and our organizational structure. This was the moment we discovered that our taxes and accounting setup were completely different from that of the buyers. *Word of warning:* Get your accountant involved as soon as possible in the process.

Approximately seven weeks after the pitch meeting, we received an amended LOI and I signed it. Although the overall financial number did not change, some money was moved from the up-front payment to the earnout (money we get based on performance up to three years after sale). We were happy with it, but here is the truth: you should only count on the up-front money when selling your company. Anything could happen after the deal goes through. An earnout or bonus, while great in some cases, may never materialize. My wife and I signed the deal because the up-front number met our objectives.

FINANCIAL HELL AND NEGOTIATIONS

The next four months were some of the worst of my life. My wife and I completed literally hundreds of spreadsheets and operational documents. I started to despise the person who invented spreadsheets. If you want to sell, especially to a global corporation, like we did, be aware of what can happen and the things you must do.

Some of our event registrations were tracking below pace, and the buyer was concerned. That said, all the buyer's questions had been answered, and it was time to see the final agreement. Weeks went by. No word. No agreement. I was getting concerned.

Walking out of a meeting in downtown Cleveland, I received a call from my financial advisor. He told me to sit down.

Apparently, the buyer was going to send us the final agreement with some major changes. First, the buyer reduced the up-front payment again. Second, the buyer lowered the total financial deal.

I was deflated. Exhausted. Frustrated. I took down all the details from my financial advisor, ended the call, and sat in the middle of Tower City in downtown Cleveland trying to figure out what to do. After all, the ball was still in our court. We could always say no.

I called my wife and relayed the details. I told her I was thinking about canceling the deal. She said she would support whatever decision I made, even though she *really* wanted to sell the business.

Instead of feeling sorry for myself, I looked at this as an opportunity. If the buyer wanted to spend less money, maybe I could ask for other things in exchange for lowering the price. I started scratching out notes. I created a new plan.

I would accept the terms with provisions. First, I wanted it in writing that no person would be fired or let go without my permission while I was still with the company. Second, I was concerned about staying on with the company for three years after the deal was signed. If the buyer wanted to lower the deal, I wanted more freedom. I asked the buyer to cut my time from three years to a year and a half. (My wife would leave after six months.) Third, if the buyer was going to cut the up-front payment, I wanted to accelerate the earnout. I asked for a higher percentage on the initial parts of the earnout to make us whole, if we hit certain sales targets.

The buyer agreed to each of these clauses. The first two (keeping the team intact and shortening my stay) were absolutely worth every penny we did not receive in up-front payment. Never be afraid to ask for anything. The worst that could happen is that people say no.

NOTIFYING THE TEAM

A month later, the deal was finalized. The sale took 6 months from receiving the LOI to a signed asset purchase agreement, and exactly 12 months from when we started the selling process.

Once we received the final signature, my wife and I eagerly anticipated the up-front deposit. I almost dropped the computer when I saw all the zeros in my online banking statement. When we received the money, the deal was officially done. Our bank account showed an additional \$17.9 million.

Now came the hardest part. My wife and I split up the calls to our team members and notified each one. Those who received a large bonus payment were ecstatic about the bonus, but still they and most of the other team members were sad. They did not want to see things change. It helped that they all knew the goal was always to sell, so they were not completely surprised.

It has been more than four years since the deal went through, and almost every person from the original team is still employed at Content Marketing Institute. Of all things, this might warm my heart the most. It means we did something right.

FROM CONTRACTORS TO EMPLOYEES

We used the 1099 contractor model for all our team members. Until the sale, there were only two employees in the business: my wife and myself. From start until sale, we encouraged our contractors to work on side projects and never work more than 32 hours per week, to comply with tax law. The buyer required that we convert key team members to full-time employees. The company believed a large portion of CMI's value was in the team, and it did not want to lose key members.

Before the deal was complete, about a dozen contractors needed to agree to go full-time (with benefits) in the new organization. Most agreed to this happily, especially the ones that wanted ongoing healthcare benefits.

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CHAPTER 22

EVALUATING YOUR OPTIONS

In life you have three options with any situation that is a challenge. Remove yourself from the situation, change it, or accept it.

PHIL MCGRAW

It's never all or nothing. There are a variety of options when it comes to the future of your business and finding your creative and financial freedom.

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

In the year 2000, Netflix was a tiny two-year-old startup that delivered movie DVDs to subscribers via the mail. That year, it had 100 employees, 300,000 subscribers, and a loss of \$57 million.

It was desperate to sell.

The Netflix founders approached the CEO of Blockbuster, a \$6 billion movie-rental chain with 9,000 locations, about a possible acquisition. Netflix asked for \$50 million from Blockbuster in exchange for the company.

Blockbuster said no, so Netflix decided to take the company public.

Today Netflix is valued at approximately \$250 billion. In Bend, Oregon, stands the last remaining Blockbuster store.

SELLING PART OF THE BUSINESS

It doesn't have to be all or nothing when it comes to selling the business. Unlike what we did at CMI, Brian Clark of Copyblogger sold off portions of his business to accomplish his goals.

According to Brian:

StudioPress was our WordPress division. It included a design framework, Genesis, designs that went with that framework, and then our WordPress hosting. That was all acquired by WP Engine, which is a WordPress hosting company. The other division was called the Rainmaker division, and that was our software-as-a-service products that included the Rainmaker platform, Scribe, and some miscellaneous software that all worked with that platform. Rainmaker was a CMS, our own content management system, and StudioPress was for people who used WordPress and wanted just to make that easier and better looking.

I didn't want to be in a service business anymore. I wanted to be an online business. When I started Copyblogger, I didn't want employees. I wasn't trying to rule the world. I just wanted to be happy and make a living and support my family.

Fast-forward a decade, and I've got an eight-figure company with 65 employees. So, I did not plan for that. Year after year we kept growing, we kept developing new products, we kept making more money, and we made it into eight figures in revenue. That was where we were before the two lines were acquired. Basically, we had hit a point where, for all sorts of reasons, once you get into eight figures—and I hear this many times from entrepreneurs—things change. Your overhead increases, you find yourself with a much larger organization. We were faced with the prospect of either taking private equity or selling. I had no interest in taking private equity. With my children in high school and only with me for a few more years, I didn't want to sacrifice that for someone else's return on investment. So instead, we entered into discussions with people who had been courting us already, and that's how the acquisitions happened.

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY

Brian's advice on IP:

Nothing really prepares you for the way negotiations go, the way due diligence goes. It's a humbling experience to have someone evaluating every single thing you've done with your baby, so to speak. But at the same time, we ran a really tight ship. Understanding the consequences of not buttoning things up from a legal standpoint, financial records, all of that, we were always very mindful of that.

I was incredibly rigorous about intellectual property. That is everything in an acquisition. So, pay very close attention to that and work with attorneys to make sure. For example, the standard common law is that when your employees create something for you, your company owns it. And yet, the better practice is to get each of those people to relinquish all their IP rights to you. We had done that in some cases, but not all, so we had to go back and do it during due diligence. You can imagine how stressful that might be, when some of these people don't work for you anymore. Thankfully, we remained on good terms with just about everyone, and it was no problem.

VENTURE CAPITAL OR NOT

Rand Fishkin, the founder of market research product SparkToro, is also the founder of *Content Inc.* example Moz (formerly SEOMoz), the SEO research tool. With his new startup, he's changing the financial model away from venture capital money. Rand says:

I thought long and hard, especially given my not-so-great experience with Moz, about how to structure SparkToro, such that long-term exit planning was taken into consideration. Moz was venture backed. It was structured in such a way that it really needed a \$100 million-plus exit and even then, really a \$300 million-plus exit before it would be valuable and of interest to its investors. So despite Moz getting to north of \$50 million in recurring annual revenue, it was a stuck-in-the-middle company because it couldn't get the growth rate up. In the venture-capital world, growth rate is really what drives sales and exits.

With SparkToro, I wanted to structure a business that did not require a massive exit in order to be successful for both the team and the investors, and so we did a very unique round of funding. We don't have a name for it. We just called it the SparkToro Funding Structure. We're basically an LLC. Our investors own units. They can get distributions when we're profitable. If we ever do sell, they get their percent of ownership that they have in the company or their money back, whichever is greater.

SparkToro could be one of the best-performing companies in our investors' portfolio, whether we make \$2 million a year, \$20 million, or \$200 million [because it pays out dividends on profit every year]. That is not true for anything in the venture-asset class. I want to trailblaze here, with SparkToro, and hopefully build a structure that other entrepreneurs of all kinds can use to fund their businesses and other investors can get excited about because I think there's a lot more opportunity outside of traditional venture.

For example, let's say you and I own shares in Moz. [Rand and his wife currently own 18 percent of Moz.] Technically, on paper, we have lots of money, but that asset is not liquid. Until or unless somebody buys it, the shares aren't worth anything. I can't sell them to another party. Nobody wants to buy them, so my net worth is essentially what I saved from my salary. The shares are not valuable until and unless there's a sale, and the same is true for our investors. Who knows? Next few years, next decade? Moz somehow finds a way to get growth again and becomes interesting to some party that wants to buy it, but realistically, that might never happen. Even though Moz is profitable to the tune of putting \$5 million to \$10 million in the bank every year, that money doesn't go anywhere.

If you and I owned Moz outright, we could decide, "Hey, the growth rate is only 5 percent or 10 percent a year, but what does it matter? We're each taking home \$5 million a year because the profit margin is amazing." Well, you don't really have that option if you're venture backed, and so the reason SparkToro can be so successful is because even if SparkToro only ever does \$2 million a year in revenue, our expenses are less than half a million dollars a year, so that's \$1.5 million in profit each year that the company can be paying out to its investors. Our investors could have ten times their return, even without a sale ever.

Here's the key, and something that Brian, Rand, and I have all learned. The best way to fund (and then exit) your business is first by not taking any outside money. Second, if you must take money, ask family, friends, or small, individual investors. Third, try to avoid venture capital with a *Content Inc.* model at all costs. In Rand's case, the VC money he took prevented a successful exit. He could not decide when to exit his own business.

VALUATION

There is a simple answer to what your *Content Inc.* business is worth: whatever someone is willing to pay for it. I'm not trying to be funny. In some cases, I've seen buyers pay a huge premium for a media company, and at other times almost nothing.

Valuations for large public media companies run between two and four times revenue. Netflix and Disney run north of four, while AMC Networks and News Corp have dropped to less than two ([Table 22.1](#)).

Table 22.1 Media valuations are never equal, and there are reasons this happens

Revenue/Equity Value of Highest Market Cap Media Companies					
Premium <4		Mid 2-4		Low <2	
Netflix	7.4	Discovery	3.4	ViacomCBS	1.8
Disney	4.6	Comcast	2.9	AMC Networks	1.7
		<i>New York Times</i>	2.7	Meredith Corp.	1.5
		AT&T	2.6	Lions Gate	1.4
		Fox	2.2	News Corp.	1.0
				Gannett	0.7
				Sky Network	0.7

Source: Capital IQ, December 2019.

When private companies are purchased, the numbers are all over the board. According to the *Wall Street Journal* and PitchBook, Spotify bought Gimlet (the podcast company) for 15 times revenue, or a \$230 million purchase price on \$15 million in revenue. PopSugar sold to Group Nine for three times revenue, while Pluto TV sold to Viacom for 2.3 times revenue.

Smaller media and *Content Inc.* enterprises are often valued at less. Your company's value depends on your revenue, your profit, and what exactly you sell. After we worked out all the back-and-forth, we ended up selling

Content Marketing Institute for about 2.5 times revenue and 10 times net profit. Since we were mostly an events company (the majority of our revenues came from paid event registrations and sponsorships), that was the agreed valuation between us and our prospective buyers.

If you go back to the *Content Inc.* revenue model in [Chapter 18](#), you'll see that your company will get higher multiples on subscription and event revenues, because they are more predictable revenue streams (pandemic aside). Valuations for online education are comparable to software-as-a-service models, where the multiples seem to be around eight times revenue. Membership models, like Netflix and Copyblogger Pro, are glorious because of the automatic monthly or annual billing (similar to models such as Slack or Salesforce).

Businesses where most of the revenue is from advertising or sponsorship receive lower multiples. A few years back, a colleague of mine sold his print magazine property for 1 times revenue, while another sold his regional event business (generally 100 people at each event) for 1.25 times revenue. It's totally fine to start by getting whatever revenue you can (say sponsorship), but *Content Inc.* models should always strive to work toward more predictable revenue streams.

Industries matter, as does consumer versus business-to-business. Media mergers-and-acquisitions and marketing consultant John Blondin uses EBITDA (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization) to value the companies he advises. John says:

Within Australia and New Zealand, a reasonable consumer title would command a multiple of 5 to 25 times EBITDA. High profile titles [go] at high multiples. With business-to-business media operations, the values used to sit at between 3 and 5 times EBITDA. However, over the past five years I have sold several titles for \$1 million or more based on 0.85 to 1.75 times EBITDA. I also sold a title to a Travel Company that saw the database and digital brands as valuable to their business. The company was sold for one dollar with the new owner taking over the existing staff liabilities. Deals are deals are deals. It comes down to finding a buyer who is interested in the sector and can recognize an upside for their model.

All this means that your *Content Inc.* business should be valued anywhere from 1 to 3 times revenue, with between 2 and 2.5 times being a fair starting valuation. If you are looking at EBITDA, look at 5 times for an unloved industry (or a nonrecurring revenue model) and 10 to 15 times for a recurring revenue model. Before selling our company, my wife and I used 2 times revenue (or 8 to 10 times EBITDA) as a base valuation for our *Content Inc.* business. To hit our goal of selling for \$15 million, we knew we couldn't sell in 2015, since our 2014 revenue was \$6.8 million (2 times EBITDA would come to around \$14 million for a sale price). We waited almost a full year until we had visibility on our 2015 final revenue numbers (around \$9 million). We did the math and knew we could expect to receive offers in an acceptable price range.

GOING THE DISTANCE

You don't have to sell. Once you build a *Content Inc.* model, you have many other options. As we've discussed, John Lee Dumas, founder of *Entrepreneurs On Fire*, has made a different decision: "I've decided to keep the business and stay small. We have 3 virtual assistants (payroll under \$3,000 monthly), a 70% or more net profit margin, and a couple million in revenue we get to keep a year (4% total tax in Puerto Rico). I have no desire to build a content enterprise, but rather focus on lifestyle design, where happiness, health and freedom are the focus."

John has made multiple decisions to make this a reality, including the move to Puerto Rico and the multiple virtual assistants. His ongoing profit statements (which he makes public) show that his business is printing money.

Miild, the Danish sustainable beauty brand, decided to go big, creating partnerships with major retailers in Norway and Germany. Its goal is to get its products out to the entire world.

Charlotte Labee from *Your Brain Balance* will never sell: "If I sell the company I would lose my mission. I have more than 60 years left to live, so let me work on this for the next 60 years and I will be happy."

Jean-Baptiste Duquesne sold 750g in two parts, selling 20 percent of the company in 2013 and the rest in 2016. Today, he is happy managing 750g

International (renamed Groupe SEB Media) with a goal of launching a new international brand in 2021, to gain worldwide exposure.

Kristen Bor from *Bearfoot Theory* is planning to slow down a bit. She's transitioned much of her work to a full-time employee. She'd like to stay involved in the business, but also wants to see what could be on the horizon.

Drew McLellan of Agency Management Institute is working on a transition plan. "I'm just now starting to think about my company as assets," says Drew. "I have all these different assets that someone could buy either together or separately. Now I'm working on changing the business from just work that I love to make it more sellable down the road."

Every *Content Inc.* model can have a different plan, but each one needs to start with some kind of plan.

MANAGING BURNOUT

Matthew Patrick from *Game Theory* has spent "the last two years on exit strategies, long-term goals and long-term potential."

For Matthew, burnout is a real concern for *Content Inc.* models:

Some content creators have been going for a weekly video, or maybe seven weekly videos, without missing a beat for the better part of eight, nine, 10-plus years. Even ourselves. Game Theory's been running as a show for eight years and we've rarely missed a week. And it's exhausting when each episode takes a hundred hours to produce. So what you've seen over the last two years is a lot of open and honest talk about creator burnout. About "Hey, I hopped on this content treadmill and I need a break or I'm out of ideas or I'm spent."

When you start you're just hoping to make enough to live off of, get enough followers to reach whatever threshold. You never think about what the end goal is.

Matthew looks at one of the greatest *Content Inc.* examples of all time, [Smosh.com](https://www.smosh.com), for inspiration. The founders wanted to leave the business, so over the course of a few years, they slowly seated other cast members. These cast members started in supporting roles, and the audience gradually

got familiar with them. Over time, the supporting roles became main roles. The founders transitioned trust to new team members. The plan worked, and the two founders had a successful exit.

Doing this successfully takes years of planning. Even before we began the selling process, my wife and I worked to put the spotlight on the team, instead of always focusing on me. By the time we sold, I was producing a minimum amount of content, so there was really no noticeable change in our content production and the audience didn't have to worry.

For a successful exit, Matthew reiterates that “you have to start thinking about [the exit] years in advance and build toward that goal.” If you don't plan correctly, “as soon as you bounce out, everyone bounces out with you.”

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PART 9

NEXT-LEVEL *CONTENT INC.*

Knowledge has to be improved, challenged, and increased constantly, or it vanishes.

PETER DRUCKER

You've built a successful *Content Inc.* business. Now what can you do to keep the momentum going?

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CHAPTER 23

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

Never look back unless you are planning to go that way.

HENRY DAVID THOREAU

If it takes 5 years to create a \$5 million asset, what could you accomplish with your *Content Inc.* model in 10 years?

If you've got this covered, just skip to the next chapter.

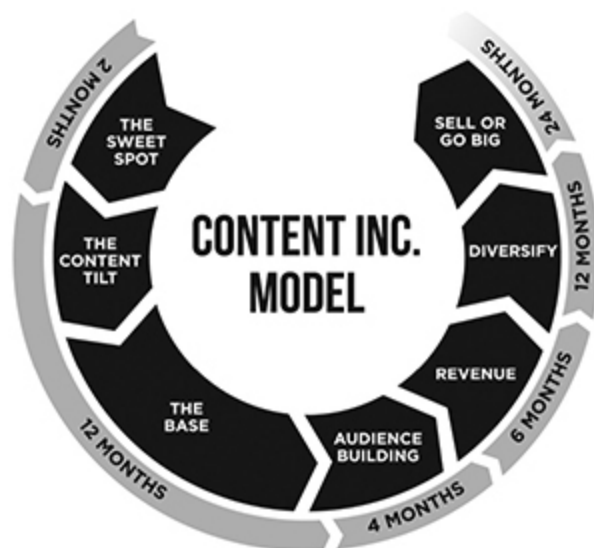
There is no definitive timetable for success. I wish there were.

I started my *Content Inc.* journey in April 2007 and almost quit in September 2009 because I felt I did not have the patience to continue. Luckily, I stayed with it, promising my wife I would give it a few more months. By May 2010, the audience numbers started to flourish, and we were able to secure sponsorships to keep the company going. In 2011 we hit a million dollars in revenue. The next three years we hit the Inc. 500 list of fastest-growing private companies. In 2016, we sold for nearly \$30 million.

We hit the \$5 million valuation mark in the year 2012, five years after we started. It's not rocket science, but that seems to be a good benchmark. Most of the *Content Inc.* cases interviewed for this book are valued between \$2 million and \$10 million after five years.

THE *CONTENT INC.* MODEL TIMETABLE

In looking at hundreds of *Content Inc.* examples over the past decade, the following chart becomes useful in gauging how long the process should take.



Let's examine each step in more detail.

THE SWEET SPOT AND THE CONTENT TILT: 2 MONTHS

It takes a few months to find your sweet spot and begin testing your content tilt. For CMI, the tilt of content marketing (as a term) was immediate. It took an adjustment a few years later, a focus on enterprise marketing professionals, to push the model into high gear.

THE BASE: 12 MONTHS

It is acceptable to test out platforms in your first couple of months. By at least the 6-month mark, you should decide on your core platform. Another 6 months and you should have your content plan, your frequency, and your subscription options set for maximum audience building.

AUDIENCE BUILDING: 4 MONTHS

Once the base is working, everything should be focused on building opt-in subscribers. Have an email offering, especially if your base is built on a

social media platform. Though the base may be working, you probably do not have a large or focused enough audience to drive revenue yet.

REVENUE: 6 MONTHS

Although you will want to drive revenue as soon as possible, revenue options seem to present themselves at about the 18-month mark. Take these months to identify the best revenue option, and stick with it for a few months before seeking out other revenue options. Focus is key.

DIVERSIFY: 12 MONTHS

Now that you have one critical platform working, you need to “derisk” the model by creating additional extensions. These can be organic launches or content asset acquisitions. Prime diversification time occurs around two to three years.

SELL OR GO BIG: 24 MONTHS

The timetable depends on your overall goals and exit strategy. At minimum, if you have not already done so, you need to develop a written exit strategy once you are deep into the diversification stage. If you’ve gone this far, you most likely have a truly valuable business and one that will either be precious to someone else or print money for you as a lifestyle business for years to come.

ONE WORD: *PATIENCE*

Be patient.

There are only nine months between when I believed I was a complete failure and when I started something that promised success. As I think back, it would have been so easy to give up and go find a “real” job. I’m so glad I didn’t. My *Content Inc.* outcome was the stuff dreams are made of. If I had not been patient, none of it would have happened.

There is no doubt in my mind that this is the absolute best way to launch a business. Yes, it is different. Some may say it is strange, but it is a better

strategy than just hoping a new product idea will take hold. Be like David, who fought the urge to fight just like everyone else had against Goliath (and lost). Take a different route and put the odds in your favor.

GETTING STUCK

As you progress through this model, there will be moments where you feel the model is not working quite to your expectations. That makes sense.

Content Inc., as a way of launching a business, is a new muscle for most people. We have been used to communicating through mass media for so many years, and now we are trying to figure out how to deliver value to our customers outside of our products and services.

If you are struggling with your program, come back and review this chapter. You may be struggling for any of these reasons:

- **Selfish content marketing.** Create content that solves customers' pain points or touches on aspirations. Stop talking about your products and services so much. If you do, make it about your customers.
- **You stop.** The biggest reason the model fails is because you either stop or aren't consistent. Remember, the content you deliver is like a promise to your customers. The biggest reason the examples in this book succeeded was because the people never stopped producing amazing and compelling content.
- **Activity instead of audience.** Having people share and engage with your content here and there does not mean much unless you are building an audience. One of the biggest mistakes *Content Inc.* models make is not planning, in advance, to acquire an audience through content creation and distribution.
- **No promotion.** Have you spent too much of your time and resources on content, and not enough on marketing the content?
- **No point of view.** To position yourself as an expert in your industry, you need a point of view. Take a stance. Walking the fence is boring and, more importantly, usually doesn't work.

- **No process.** I see it every day. *Scenario:* A marketing campaign means placing ads. Then someone asks about the blog or white paper. People scurry about, and someone runs out to get the content. Plan up front to create, repurpose, and distribute content.
- **No call to action.** Each piece of content should have a call to action or behavior you'd like to see. What would happen if you asked "why?" to each piece of content you create? By doing this, you will be compelled to either know the call to action or kill the content for lack of purpose.
- **Forgetting employees.** Employee expertise is the most underused content asset. Your employees give your brand life. Leverage them in the creation and distribution process. Start with the 5 percent that get it. Show success stories and move on to the rest of your employee base.
- **One word: *editing*.** Editing may be the most underrated piece of the content process. Sometimes entrepreneurs don't understand that the first draft of a piece of content is called a good start. Enter the editor. Get one or hire one.

What's holding you back from your *Content Inc.* model?

ARE YOU RISKING ENOUGH?

In preparation for this version of *Content Inc.*, I listened to an interview between Joe Rogan and Colin O'Brady.

Colin is a professional endurance athlete, which means he does things that most people don't, like climb Mount Everest or walk across Antarctica. He mentioned an idea that fascinated me.

He said that most people live their lives on a scale between a 4 and a 6. So on a 10-point scale, 1 being the worst possible day and 10 being the best possible day, Colin believes that most people never get too high or too low.

People just live routine days doing routine things. But think about it. A rating of 4 isn't horrible for your worst possible day. And while 6 isn't great, it's not terrible.

Colin disagrees. He believes that the majority of people aren't taking enough risks. They aren't, as he puts it, chasing their Mount Everest. When you chase big, risky ideas and goals, Colin believes, you rarely fall into the middle of the scale. You are often an 8, 9, or 10, or if you took a big risk and failed, you are a 1 or a 2.

Is he right? Frankly, I don't know—but it did get me asking myself if I take enough risks.

I'm a risk taker at heart. I started a business when I probably shouldn't have and wrote a novel when I didn't have a clue how to write one. I love challenges like that. To me, these were big ideas. But now I'm starting to question whether I'm taking enough risks.

I see a lot of people around me waiting. Waiting for retirement. Waiting for the next holiday. Waiting for a promotion. In all these cases, are they really making a positive impact on the world, living between a 4 and a 6? That's not for me to answer, but it does get me thinking.

Maybe I'm not doing enough. Maybe I could be doing more. Am I afraid to take certain risks? Am I so afraid of a 1 that I'm unwilling to go for a 10?

Not five minutes after I listened to Colin make his little speech with Joe Rogan, I accidentally pulled this quote from my cluttered desk. It's by Calvin Coolidge, thirtieth president of the United States:

Nothing in the world can take the place of persistence. Talent will not; nothing is more common than unsuccessful men with talent. Genius will not; unrewarded genius is almost a proverb. Education will not; the world is full of educated derelicts. Persistence and determination alone are omnipotent. The slogan "Press On" has solved and always will solve the problems of the human race.

I love this quote because it gives you no excuses.

What's holding you back from making all your dreams come true?

Everything is impossible until it happens.

NELSON MANDELA

MOVING FORWARD

Yes, there will be challenges. There will be times you are not sure you are on the right path. That is natural for any entrepreneur or small business owner. But here's the truth: Until now, it was cost prohibitive for entrepreneurs to build a loyal audience. Until now, the communication channels were not available. Until now, the audience wasn't willing to connect.

Until now.

By following the *Content Inc.* method in this book, you have an opportunity to make a difference in your life, your family, your career path, and the world. I hope that you seize that opportunity today and never look back.

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CHAPTER 24

JOIN THE MOVEMENT

The revolution is not an apple that falls when it is ripe. You have to make it fall.

CHE GUEVARA

Content Inc. is a journey—one that changed my life for the better. I’m hoping the same will be true for you.

This book is a good start, but it’s not enough. There is so much more we need to learn and do to create an amazing business that starts with the needs of your audience (not the product you want to sell). As the platforms and the business model continue to change, so does our need for ongoing training.

This chapter is all about resources to help inspire and educate you on your *Content Inc.* initiative.

Here are some resources I believe will help:

- **The Tilt.** After finishing the second version of this book, something didn’t feel right. I love how it turned out. The model is correct. But it’s not enough. I pulled some of my friends together to create The Tilt (thetilt.com), a news and education site that helps content entrepreneurs build an audience and grow revenue. We send out the newsletter two times per week. Please sign up at thetilt.com. You won’t regret it.
- **The Content Inc. podcast.** Every Monday I release a short podcast episode, which is always less than 10 minutes long. I try to keep the episodes very actionable, and depending on how fast you run, four episodes equals about a five-kilometer run. Just go to Apple Podcasts, Spotify, Stitcher, or Overcast and type in “Content Inc.”

- ***This Old Marketing* podcast.** Every Friday morning, Robert Rose and I cover the latest marketing news in a style that's (let's say) unique. My hope is that you'll be educated and entertained at the same time. Each podcast is one hour long. Go to thisoldmarketing.site to gain access to every episode.
- ***The Random Newsletter* by Joe Pulizzi.** This is my personal newsletter, where I cover insights about the Content Inc. model, publishing and success techniques, and ideas on finances. I always end with "One Random Thing" that I'm hopeful will change your life. I distribute it every other Thursday. Sign up at JoePulizzi.com.

NEXT-GENERATION CONTENT INC.

As you progress in your *Content Inc.* journey, you'll get to the point where you'll need even more resources and insights to keep growing. Here are some resources that will help:

Writing

- **Ann Handley's *Total Annarchy* newsletter and her book *Everybody Writes*.** Perfect to improve your writing
- **Brian Clark and Copyblogger.** Truly useful site for digital copywriting practices
- **Sarah Mitchell and Typeset's blog.** Valuable resource on writing and copywriting

Content and Media Operations

- **Li Jin.** Li spearheaded the *Passion Economy* movement. She has an amazing podcast with Nathan Baschez called *Means of Creation* and runs a valuable tech resource for creators at sidehustlestack.co/.
- **A Media Operator.** A must-read newsletter on how media companies run from Jacob Donnelly.
- **Simon Owens.** Simon covers diverse case studies by content entrepreneurs at simonowens.substack.com.

SEO/Analytics

- **Andy Crestodina and Orbit Media Studios' blog.** Excellent for practical tips on analytics and SEO. Andy does incredible research on industry blogging.
- **Wil Reynolds and Seer Interactive.** Will knows more about search engine optimization than I'll ever dream of knowing.
- **Mike Murray and Online Marketing Coach.** I've worked with Mike for 15 years, and he's never steered me wrong.

Findability

- **Gini Dietrich and Spin Sucks.** *Spin Sucks* is a powerful (non) public relations blog.
- **Lee Odden and TopRank's online marketing blog.** The blog is a great all-around marketing blog, but best for online findability.
- **Neal Schaffer and his book *Age of Influence*.** I got an early peek at this influencer marketing book. It's well worth the purchase.

Content Marketing

- **Jay Acunzo and Marketing Showrunners.** Marketing Showrunners is an amazing resource to help you run a digital video show or podcast.
- **Robert Rose.** He's the smartest man in content marketing and probably the leading content marketing consultant for enterprises. Robert and I wrote *Killing Marketing* together, an excellent resource if you are a marketer in a large enterprise. *Listen to our podcast.*
- **Brittany Berger's blog.** Brittany actively promotes doing more with less content. Love it!
- **Melanie Diezel.** Read her amazing book *The Content Fuel Framework*.
- **Andrew Hanelly.** His Revmade marketing email newsletter is excellent.

- **Dennis Shiao.** Dennis is one of the best marketing consultants in the business.

Content Strategy

- **Margot Bloomstein.** Her book is *Content Strategy at Work*.
- **Adele Revella and Buyer Persona Institute.** The best in the business on buyer personas.
- **Andrea Fryrear.** One of the world's leading experts on agile marketing.
- **Ahava Liebttag.** Her *The Digital Crown* on successful web marketing is an amazing book.
- **Val Swisher.** If you start going deep into content strategy, pick up her book *Global Content Strategy*.
- **Scott Abel, founder of *The Content Wrangler*.** Scott's online magazine is an amazing resource on the practice of content strategy.
- **Kristina Halvorson and Brain Traffic.** Their site, contentstrategy.com, is perfect if you don't understand the differences between content strategy and content marketing.

Social Media

- **Matt Navarra.** Matt is a must follow on Twitter (@MattNavarra) and his Geekout newsletter is one of the best in the industry.
- **Jeff Bullas's blog.** This is an incredible resource for social media and findability.
- **David Meerman Scott and *Fanocracy*.** Want to learn how to turn customers into fans? *Fanocracy* is your book.
- **Michael Stelzner and Social Media Examiner.** Social Media Examiner is the leading digital resource for social media marketing.
- **Mari Smith.** No person on the earth knows more about Facebook than Mari.
- **Brian Fanzo.** Listen to his *Press the Damn Button* podcast.

- **Jeff Korhan.** His book *Built-in Social* (especially good for service companies) is amazingly useful.

Podcasting/Audio

- **Jeremiah Owyang.** Jeremiah has amazing advice on most marketing topics, but he is elite when it comes to social audio. Check out his blog at web-strategist.com/blog/.
- **Pat Flynn and the *Smart Passive Income Podcast*.** Pat Flynn trailblazed in the podcast space. If you have a podcast, follow him.
- **Pamela Muldoon.** Pamela is a content strategist and the best female voice-over talent in the business.
- **Mitch Joel.** His *Six Pixels of Separation* podcast is one of the best and longest-running podcasts out there.

Visual Storytelling

- **Donna Moritz's blog.** An amazing resource to learn more about visual content.
- **Buddy Scalera.** A master of visual storytelling. Check him out at ComicBookSchool.com.
- **Jason Miller.** He parlayed his experience at LinkedIn and Microsoft and built Rock 'N Roll Cocktail, an amazing rock photography/marketing education site.

Digital Marketing

- **Allen Gannett and *The Creative Curve!*** Allen's book *The Creative Curve!* is a fresh take on digital marketing.
- **Mark Schaefer and *Marketing Rebellion*.** *Marketing Rebellion* is an excellent book on the state of marketing today.
- **Andrew Davis's blog.** Andrew Davis is the most interesting man in marketing.
- **Convince & Convert.** Jay Baer offers this amazing resource of marketing blogs, books, and more.

- **Heidi Cohen.** Read her excellent *Actionable Marketing Guide* e-newsletter to keep tabs on what's going on in marketing.
- **Scott and Alison Stratten.** Their excellent *UnPodcast* tells you what *not* to do in marketing. Plus, Scott is hilarious.
- **John Hall and Relevance.com.** Relevance.com is a fantastic digital resource.
- **Sally Hogshead and *Fascinate*.** *Fascinate* is an excellent book to help you better understand your own skill base (for finding your sweet spot).
- **Jason Therrien and the thunder::tech blog.** The blog includes amazing case studies and step-by-step guides.
- **Jon Wuebben.** His book is *Future Marketing: Winning in the Prosumer Age*.

Email Marketing

- **Jessica Best.** My go-to person for anything related to email marketing

Entrepreneurship

- **Chris Ducker and Youpreneur.** Chris has built an amazing platform for entrepreneurs, including an event and an inspiring podcast.
- **Chris Brogan and Kerry Gorgone.** Their amazing video interview show, *The Backpack Show*, is perfect for entrepreneurs.
- **John Lee Dumas and *Entrepreneurs On Fire*.** The *Entrepreneurs On Fire* podcast is almost a must-listen for entrepreneurs.
- ***The James Altucher Show* podcast.** I almost always find something useful on James's podcast.
- **Marcus Sheridan and *They Ask, You Answer*.** *They Ask, You Answer* is the perfect book for understanding how to create content your customers really need.

Business to Business

- **Doug Kessler and Velocity Partners' blog.** Perhaps the best business-to-business marketing blog on the planet.
- **Michael Brenner and Marketing Insider Group.** Perfect for marketing leadership, insight, and research.
- **Pam Didner's blog.** Awesome for information on sales enablement.
- **Ardath Albee and Marketing Interactions.** Need to understand the B2B buyer? Marketing Interactions is your place.
- **Bernie Borges.** His podcast is the *Modern Marketing Engine*.
- **Tim Riesterer and *The Expansion Sale*.** *The Expansion Sale* is an excellent book for understanding customer psychology.
- **Tom Martin.** His book is *The Invisible Sale*.
- **Julia McCoy.** Her book is *Practical Content Strategy & Marketing*.
- **Aaron Orendorff and IconiContent.** Excellent for B2B strategy and e-commerce tips.

Agency Life

- **Drew McLellan and Stephen Woessner.** Their book *Sell with Authority* is a must-read for any marketing agency professional.
- **Paul Roetzer.** His book *The Marketing Agency Blueprint* is a fantastic agency book.

Legal Issues

- **Ruth Carter and her book *The Legal Side of Blogging*.** Ruth's book offers vital information.
- **Sharon Toerek and her Legal+Creative blog.** The *L+C Blog* is excellent.

Data/AI/MarTech

- **Paul Roetzer and Marketing AI Institute.** Marketing AI Institute is the leading educational resource for marketing and artificial intelligence.

- **Scott Brinker and the Marketing Technology Landscape supergraphic.** If you haven't seen the Marketing Technology Landscape supergraphic, stop right now and Google it.
- **Christopher Penn.** I go to Christopher whenever I have an analytics or data science question. He's the best in the business.
- **Douglas Karr and Martech Zone.** The Martech Zone is the site for all things marketing technology.

Research

- **Mantis Research.** It provides the best education on marketing research and research practices.
- **Tom Webster and Edison Research.** Edison Research is the place on the web for audio and podcasting trends and research.

What's Next

- **Joel Comm, Travis Wright, and *The Bad Crypto Podcast*.** Joel and Travis are trailblazing in the non-fungible token (NFT) space.
- **Bradley Miles.** Bradley is founder of Roll, one of the leaders in social money. His email newsletter, *The Social Money Times*, is a must read.

There are amazing experts all over the world. Here are some international thought leaders you must follow:

- **AJ Huisman, Bert Van Loon, and Content Marketing Fast Forward.** These gentlemen are taking content marketing to the next level in the Netherlands.
- **Cassio Politi and the book *Content Marketing Masterclass*.** Cassio has written an amazing book and is perhaps the leading thought leader on content in Brazil.
- **Fernando Labastida with Content Marketing Latam.** Fernando has been pushing content marketing into Latin America for a decade.
- **Joakim Ditlev.** Mr. Content Marketing in Denmark.

- **Jesper Laursen.** The founder of the *Native Advertising Institute*. He also runs an incredible content agency in Denmark.
- **Igor Savic, Primož Inkret, Anja Garbajs, and Nenad Senic with PM in Slovenia.** They run the leading content agency in Slovenia. And they also run the best event in Slovenia, *POMP Forum*.
- **Michiel Schoonhoven and Denis Doeland from NXTLI (the Netherlands).** Their Content Impact Framework is one of the best content marketing models I've seen.
- **Cor Hospes.** One of the leading content marketers in the Netherlands, Cor offers an amazing blog and newsletter.
- **Mark Masters.** His *You Are the Media Podcast* series originates in the United Kingdom.

FINAL THOUGHTS

I try to respond to as many tweets and emails as I can. You can find me on Twitter @JoePulizzi and on email at joe@thetilt.com. Although I've cut my speaking back a bit, I still do a number of keynotes throughout the year. If you are interested in finding out more about having me speak at your event, you can get all the details at JoePulizzi.com.

Thank you for taking the time to read this book. I truly hope it was a valuable experience for you.

Now go out and make life happen. Be epic!

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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

To the over 100 amazing businesses featured in this book: This model is yours. Thank you for inspiring me each and every day to do better.

A very special thanks to Clare McDermott and Joakim Ditlev for the countless interview hours so critical for this book's success.

To the entire Content Marketing Institute team for helping to make this book possible.

To Laura/Jim, Becky/Marc, and Kristin/JK for making every minute of this journey a blast.

To my boys, Joshua and Adam. Never settle. Ask questions. I'm so proud of both of you.

To my immediate family, Terry and Tony Pulizzi, Lea and Steve Smith, Tony and Cathy Pulizzi, Jim and Sandy McDermott, Sandy Kozelka, Ryan and Amy Kozelka, and Laura Kozelka for all your love and support.

To Pam. My best friend. With you, every day is better than the last. I love you. Most (obviously)!

Phil 4:13

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